

NCE Books 2-4

204 articles

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Book 2

1. A Private Conversation

Last week I went to the theatre. I had a very good seat. The play was very interesting. I did not enjoy it. A young man and a young woman were sitting behind me. They were talking loudly. I got very angry. I could not hear the actors. I turned round. I looked at the man and the woman angrily. They did not pay any attention. In the end, I could not bear it. I turned round again. 'I can't hear a word!' I said angrily.

'It's none of your business,' the young man said rudely. 'This is a private conversation!'

2. Breakfast or lunch?

It was Sunday. I never get up early on Sundays. I sometimes stay in bed until lunchtime. Last Sunday I got up very late. I looked out of the window. It was dark outside. 'What a day!' I thought. 'It's raining again.' Just then, the telephone rang. It was my aunt Lucy. 'I've just arrived by train,' she said. 'I'm coming to see you.'

'But I'm still having breakfast,' I said.

'What are you doing?' she asked.

'I'm having breakfast,' I repeated.

'Dear me,' she said. 'Do you always get up so late? It's one o'clock!'

3. Please Send Me a Card

Postcards always spoil my holidays. Last summer, I went to Italy. I visited museums and sat in public gardens. A friendly waiter taught me a few words of Italian. Then he lent me a book. I read a few lines, but I did not understand a word. Every day I thought about postcards. My holidays passed quickly, but I did not send cards to my friends. On the last day I made a big decision. I got up early and bought thirty-seven cards. I spent the whole day in my room, but I did not write a single card!

4. An exciting trip

I have just received a letter from my brother, Tim. He is in Australia. He has been there for six months. Tim is an engineer. He is working for a big firm and he has already visited a great number of different places in Australia. He has just bought an Australian car and has gone to Alice Springs, a small town in the centre of Australia. He will soon visit Darwin. From there, he will fly to Perth. My brother has never been abroad before, so he is finding this trip very exciting.

5. No wrong numbers

Mr. James Scott has a garage in Silbury and now he has just bought another garage in Pinhurst.

Pinhurst is only five miles from Silbury, but Mr. Scott cannot get a telephone for his new garage, so he has just bought twelve pigeons.

Yesterday, a pigeon carried the first message from Pinhurst to Silbury. The bird covered the distance in three minutes.

Up to now, Mr. Scott has sent a great many requests for spare parts and other urgent messages from one garage to the other.

In this way, he has begun his own private 'telephone' service.

6. Percy Buttons

I have just moved to a house in Bridge Street. Yesterday a beggar knocked at my door. He asked me for a meal and a glass of beer. In return for this, the beggar stood on his head and sang songs. I gave him a meal. He ate the food and drank the beer. Then he put a piece of cheese in his pocket and went away. Later a neighbour told me about him. Everybody knows him. His name is Percy Buttons. He calls at every house in the street once a month and always asks for a meal and a glass of beer.

7. Too late

The plane was late and detectives were waiting at the airport all morning. They were expecting a valuable parcel of diamonds from South Africa. A few hours earlier, someone had told the police that thieves would try to steal the diamonds. When the plane arrived, some of the detectives were waiting inside the main building while others were waiting on the airfield. Two men took the parcel off the plane and carried it into the Customs House. While two detectives were keeping guard at the door, two others opened the parcel. To their surprise, the precious parcel was full of stones and sand!

8. The Best and the Worst

Joe Sanders has the most beautiful garden in our town. Nearly everybody enters for 'The Nicest Garden Competition' each year, but Joe wins every time. Bill Frith's garden is larger than Joe's. Bill works harder than Joe and grows more flowers and vegetables, but Joe's garden is more interesting. He has made neat paths and has built a wooden bridge over a pool. I like gardens too, but I do not like hard work. Every year I enter for the garden competition too, and I always win a little prize for the worst garden in the town!

9. A Cold Welcome

On Wednesday evening, we went to the Town Hall. It was the last day of the year and a large crowd of people had gathered under the Town Hall clock. It would strike twelve in twenty minutes' time. Fifteen minutes passed and then, at five to twelve, the clock stopped. The big minute hand did not move. We waited and waited, but nothing happened. Suddenly someone shouted, 'It's two minutes past twelve! The clock has stopped!' I looked at my watch. It was true. The big clock refused to welcome the New Year. At that moment, everybody began to laugh and sing.

10. Not For Jazz

We have an old musical instrument. It is called a clavichord. It was made in Germany in 1681. Our clavichord is kept in the living room. It has belonged to our family for a long time. The instrument was bought by my grandfather many years ago. Recently it was damaged by a visitor. She tried to play jazz on it! She struck the keys too hard and two of the strings were broken. My father was shocked. Now we are not allowed to touch it. It is being repaired by a friend of my father's.

11. One Good Turn Deserves Another

I was having dinner at a restaurant when Tony Steele came in.

Tony worked in a lawyer's office years ago, but he is now working at a bank.

He gets a good salary, but he always borrows money from his friends and never pays it back.

Tony saw me and came and sat at the same table.

He has never borrowed money from me.

While he was eating, I asked him to lend me twenty pounds.

To my surprise, he gave me the money immediately.

'I have never borrowed any money from you,' Tony said, 'so now you can pay for my dinner!'

12. Goodbye and Good Luck

Our neighbour, Captain Charles Alison, will sail from Portsmouth tomorrow.

We'll meet him at the harbour early in the morning.

He will be in his small boat, Topsail.

Topsail is a famous little boat.

It has sailed across the Atlantic many times.

Captain Alison will set out at eight o'clock, so we'll have plenty of time.

We'll see his boat and then we'll say goodbye to him.

He will be away for two months.

We are very proud of him.

He will take part in an important race across the Atlantic.

13. The Greenwood Boys

The Greenwood Boys are a group of pop singers.

At present, they are visiting all parts of the country.

They will be arriving here tomorrow.

They will be coming by train and most of the young people in the town will be meeting them at the station. Tomorrow evening they will be singing at the Workers' Club.

The Greenwood Boys will be staying for five days.

During this time, they will give five performances.

As usual, the police will have a difficult time.

They will be trying to keep order.

It is always the same on these occasions.

14. Do you speak English?

I had an amusing experience last year.

After I had left a small village in the south of France, I drove on to the next town.

On the way, a young man waved to me.

I stopped and he asked me for a lift.

As soon as he had got into the car, I said good morning to him in French and he replied in the same language. Apart from a few words, I do not know any French at all.

Neither of us spoke during the journey.

I had nearly reached the town, when the young man suddenly said, very slowly, "Do you speak English?"

As I soon learnt, he was English himself!

15. Good News

The secretary told me that Mr. Harmsworth would see me.

I felt very nervous when I went into his office.

He did not look up from his desk when I entered.

After I had sat down, he said that business was very bad.

He told me that the firm could not afford to pay such large salaries.

Twenty people had already left.

I knew that my turn had come.

'Mr. Harmsworth,' I said in a weak voice.

'Don't interrupt,' he said.

Then he smiled and told me I would receive an extra thousand pounds a year!

16. A polite request

If you park your car in the wrong place, a traffic policeman will soon find it.

You will be very lucky if he lets you go without a ticket.

However, this does not always happen.

Traffic police are sometimes very polite.

During a holiday in Sweden, I found this note on my car: 'sir, we welcome you to our city. This is a "No Parking" area.

You will enjoy your stay here if you pay attention to our street signs. This note is only a reminder.'

If you receive a request like this, you cannot fail to obey it!

17. Always young

My aunt Jennifer is an actress.

She must be at least thirty-five years old.

In spite of this, she often appears on the stage as a young girl.

Jennifer will have to take part in a new play soon.

This time, she will be a girl of seventeen.

In the play, she must appear in a bright red dress and long black stockings.

Last year in another play, she had to wear short socks and a bright, orange-coloured dress.

If anyone ever asks her how old she is, she always answers, 'Darling, it must be terrible to be grown up!'

18. He often does this!

After I had had lunch at a village pub, I looked for my bag.

I had left it on a chair beside the door and now it wasn't there!

As I was looking for it, the landlord came in.

'Did you have a good meal?' he asked.

'Yes, thank you,' I answered, 'but I can't pay the bill. I haven't got my bag.'

The landlord smiled and immediately went out.

In a few minutes he returned with my bag and gave it back to me.

'I'm very sorry,' he said. 'My dog had taken it into the garden. He often does this!'

19. Sold out

The play may begin at any moment, I said.

'It may have begun already,' Susan answered.

I hurried to the ticket office. 'May I have two tickets please?' I asked.

'I'm sorry, we've sold out,' the girl said.

'What a pity!' Susan exclaimed.

Just then, a man hurried to the ticket office.

'Can I return these two tickets?' he asked.

'Certainly,' the girl said.

I went back to the ticket office at once.

'Could I have those two tickets please?' I asked.

'Certainly,' the girl said, 'but they're for next Wednesday's performance. Do you still want them?'

I might as well have them,' I said sadly.

20. One man in a boat

Fishing is my favourite sport. I often fish for hours without catching anything. But this does not worry me. Some fishermen are unlucky. Instead of catching fish, they catch old boots and rubbish. I am even less lucky. I never catch anything - not even old boots. After having spent whole mornings on the river, I always go home with an empty bag. 'You must give up fishing!' my friends say. 'It's a waste of time.' But they don't realize one important thing. I'm not really interested in fishing. I am only interested in sitting in a boat and doing nothing at all!

21. Mad or not

Aeroplanes are slowly driving me mad. I live near an airport and passing planes can be heard night and day. The airport was built years ago, but for some reason it could not be used then. Last year, however, it came into use. Over a hundred people must have been driven away from their homes by the noise. I am one of the few people left. Sometimes I think this house will be knocked down by a passing plane. I have been offered a large sum of money to go away, but I am determined to stay here. Everybody says I must be mad and they are probably right.

22. A Glass Envelope

My daughter, Jane, never dreamed of receiving a letter from a girl of her own age in Holland. Last year, we were travelling across the Channel and Jane put a piece of paper with her name and address on it into a bottle. She threw the bottle into the sea. She never thought of it again, but ten months later, she received a letter from a girl in Holland. Both girls write to each other regularly now. However, they have decided to use the post office. Letters will cost a little more, but they will certainly travel faster.

23. A New House

I had a letter from my sister yesterday. She lives in Nigeria. In her letter, she said that she would come to England next year. If she comes, she will get a surprise. We are now living in a beautiful new house in the country. Work on it had begun before my sister left. The house was completed five months ago. In my letter, I told her that she could stay with us. The house has many large rooms and there is a lovely garden. It is a very modern house, so it looks strange to some people. It must be the only modern house in the district.

24. It could be worse

I entered the hotel manager's office and sat down. I had just lost £50 and I felt very upset. 'I left the money in my room,' I said, 'and it's not there now.' The manager was sympathetic, but he could do nothing. 'Everyone's losing money these days,' he said. He started to complain about this wicked world but was interrupted by a knock at the door. A girl came in and put an envelope on his desk. It contained £50. 'I found this outside this gentleman's room,' she said. 'Well,' I said to the manager, 'there is still some honesty in this world!'

25. Do the English speak English?

I arrived in London at last. The railway station was big, black and dark. I did not know the way to my hotel, so I asked a porter. I not only spoke English very carefully, but very clearly as well. The porter, however, could not understand me. I repeated my question several times and at last he understood. He answered me, but he spoke neither slowly nor clearly. 'I am a foreigner,' I said. Then he spoke slowly, but I could not understand him. My teacher never spoke English like that! The porter and I looked at each other and smiled. Then he said something and I understood it. 'You'll soon learn English!' he said. I wonder. In England, each person speaks a different language. The English understand each other, but I don't understand them! Do they speak English?

26. The Best Art Critics

I am an art student and I paint a lot of pictures.

Many people pretend that they understand modern art.

They always tell you what a picture is 'about'.

Of course, many pictures are not 'about' anything.

They are just pretty patterns.

We like them in the same way that we like pretty curtain material.

I think that young children often appreciate modern art better than anyone else.

They notice more.

My sister is only seven, but she always tells me whether my pictures are good or not.

She came into my room yesterday.

'What are you doing?' she asked.

'I'm hanging this picture on the wall,' I answered.

'It's a new one.

Do you like it?'

She looked at it critically for a moment.

'It's all right,' she said, 'but isn't it upside down?'

I looked at it again.

She was right! It was!

27. A wet night

Late in the afternoon, the boys put up their tent in the middle of a field. As soon as this was done, they cooked a meal over an open fire. They were all hungry and the food smelled good. After a wonderful meal, they told stories and sang songs by the campfire. But some time later it began to rain. The boys felt tired so they put out the fire and crept into their tent. Their sleeping bags were warm and comfortable, so they all slept soundly. In the middle of the night, two boys woke up and began shouting. The tent was full of water! They all leapt out of their sleeping bags and hurried outside. It was raining heavily and they found that a stream had formed in the field. The stream wound its way across the field and then flowed right under their tent!

28. No parking

Jasper White is one of those rare people who believes in ancient myths. He has just bought a new house in the city, but ever since he moved in, he has had trouble with cars and their owners. When he returns home at night, he always finds that someone has parked a car outside his gate. Because of this, he has not been able to get his own car into his garage even once. Jasper has put up 'No Parking' signs outside his gate, but these have not had any effect. Now he has put an ugly stone head over the gate. It is one of the ugliest faces I have ever seen. I asked him what it was and he told me that it was Medusa, the Gorgon. Jasper hopes that she will turn cars and their owners to stone. But none of them has been turned to stone yet!

29. Taxi

Captain Ben Fawcett has bought an unusual taxi and has begun a new service. The 'taxi' is a small Swiss aeroplane called a 'Pilatus Porter'. This wonderful plane can carry seven passengers. The most surprising thing about it, however, is that it can land anywhere: on snow, water, or even on a ploughed field. Captain Fawcett's first passenger was a doctor who flew from Birmingham to a lonely village in the Welsh mountains. Since then, Captain Fawcett has flown passengers to many unusual places. Once he landed on the roof of a block of flats and on another occasion, he landed in a deserted car park. Captain Fawcett has just refused a strange request from a businessman. The man wanted to fly to Rockall, a lonely island in the Atlantic Ocean, but Captain Fawcett did not take him because the trip was too dangerous.

30. Football or Polo?

The Wayle is a small river that cuts across the park near my home. I like sitting by the Wayle on fine afternoons. It was warm last Sunday, so I went and sat on the river bank as usual. Some children were playing games on the bank and there were some people rowing on the river. Suddenly, one of the children kicked a ball very hard and it went towards a passing boat. Some people on the boat shouted at the children. But they did not hear them. The ball struck one of the oarsmen on the nose and knocked him out. The man was very angry as he was in pain. He did not catch

the ball either. Everyone laughed except the man! Then he sat down and laughed too.

31. Success Story

Yesterday afternoon Frank Hawkins was telling me about his experiences as a young man. Frank is now the head of a very large business company, but as a boy he used to work in a small shop. It was his job to repair bicycles and at that time he used to work fourteen hours a day. He saved money for years and in 1958 he bought a small workshop of his own. In his twenties Frank used to make spare parts for aeroplanes. At that time he had two helpers. In a few years the small workshop had become a large factory which employed seven hundred and twenty - eight people. Frank smiled when he remembered his hard early years and the long road to success. He was still smiling when the door opened and his wife came in. She wanted him to repair their son's bicycle!

32. Shopping Made Easy

People are not so honest as they once were. The temptation to steal is greater than ever before-especially in large shops. A detective recently watched a well - dressed woman who always went into a large store on Monday mornings. One Monday, there were fewer people in the shop than usual when the woman came in, so it was easier for the detective to watch her. The woman first bought a few small articles. After a little time, she chose one of the most expensive dresses in the shop and handed it to an assistant who wrapped it up for her as quickly as possible. Then the woman simply took the parcel and walked out of the shop without paying. When she was arrested, the detective found out that the shop - assistant was her daughter. The girl 'gave' her mother a free dress once a week!

33. Out of the Darkness

Nearly a week passed before the girl was able to explain what had happened to her. One afternoon she set out from the coast in a small boat and was caught in a storm. Towards evening, the boat struck a rock and the girl jumped into the sea. Then she swam to the shore after spending the whole night in the water. During that time she covered a distance of eight miles. Early next morning, she saw a light ahead. She knew she was near the shore because the light was high up on the cliffs. On arriving at the shore, the girl struggled up the cliff towards the light she had seen. That was all she remembered. When she woke up a day later, she found herself in hospital.

34. Quick work

Dan Robinson has been worried all week. Last Tuesday he received a letter from the local police. In the letter he was asked to call at the station. Dan wondered why he was wanted by the police, but he went to the station yesterday and now he is not worried any more. At the station, he was told by a smiling policeman that his bicycle had been found. Five days ago, the policeman told him, the bicycle was picked up in a small village four hundred miles away. It is now being sent to his home by train. Dan was most surprised when he heard the news. He was amused too, because he never expected the bicycle to be found. It was stolen twenty years ago when Dan was a boy of fifteen!

35. Stop Thief!

Roy Trenton used to drive a taxi. A short while ago, however, he became a bus driver and he has not regretted it. He is finding his new work far more exciting. When he was driving along Catford Street recently, he saw two thieves rush out of a shop and run towards a waiting car. One of them was carrying a bag full of money. Roy acted quickly and drove the bus straight at the thieves. The one with the money got such a fright that he dropped the bag. As the thieves were trying to get away in their car, Roy drove his bus into the back of it. While the battered car was moving away, Roy stopped his bus and telephoned the police. The thieves' car was badly damaged and easy to recognize. Shortly afterwards, the police stopped the car and both men were arrested.

36. Across the Channel

Debbie Hart is going to swim across the English Channel tomorrow. She is going to set out from the French coast at five o'clock in the morning. Debbie is only eleven years old and she hopes to set up a new world record. She is a strong swimmer and many people feel that she is sure to succeed. Debbie's father will set out with her in a small boat. Mr. Hart has trained his daughter for years. Tomorrow he will be watching her anxiously as she swims the long distance to England. Debbie intends to take short rests every two hours. She will have something to drink but she will not eat any solid food. Most of Debbie's school friends will be waiting for her on the English coast. Among them will be Debbie's mother, who swam the Channel herself when she was a girl.

37. The Olympic Games

The Olympic Games will be held in our country in four years' time. As a great many people will be visiting the country, the government will be building new hotels, an immense stadium, and a new Olympic-standard swimming pool. They will also be building new roads and a special railway line. The Games will be held just outside the capital and the whole area will be called 'Olympic City'. Workers will have completed the new roads by the end of this year. By the end of next year, they will have finished work on the new stadium. The fantastic modern buildings have been designed by Kurt Gunter. Everybody will be watching anxiously as the new buildings go up. We are all very excited and are looking forward to the Olympic Games because they have never been held before in this country.

38. Everything except the weather

My old friend, Harrison, had lived in the Mediterranean for many years before he returned to England. He had often dreamed of retiring in England and had planned to settle down in the country. He had no sooner returned than he bought a house and went to live there. Almost immediately he began to complain about the weather, for even though it was still summer, it rained continually and it was often bitterly cold. After so many years of sunshine, Harrison got a shock. He acted as if he had never lived in England before. In the end, it was more than he could bear. He had hardly

had time to settle down when he sold the house and left the country. The dream he had had for so many years ended there. Harrison had thought of everything except the weather.

39. Am I all right?

While John Gilbert was in hospital, he asked his doctor to tell him whether his operation had been successful, but the doctor refused to do so. The following day, the patient asked for a bedside telephone. When he was alone, he telephoned the hospital exchange and asked for Doctor Millington. When the doctor answered the phone, Mr. Gilbert said he was inquiring about a certain patient, a Mr. John Gilbert. He asked if Mr. Gilbert's operation had been successful and the doctor told him that it had been. He then asked when Mr. Gilbert would be allowed to go home and the doctor told him that he would have to stay in hospital for another two weeks. Then Dr. Millington asked the caller if he was a relative of the patient. 'No,' the patient answered, 'I am Mr. John Gilbert.'

40. Food and Talk

Last week at a dinner - party, the hostess asked me to sit next to Mrs. Rumbold. Mrs. Rumbold was a large, unsmiling lady in a tight black dress. She did not even look up when I took my seat beside her. Her eyes were fixed on her plate and in a short time, she was busy eating. I tried to make conversation.

"A new play is coming to 'The Globe' soon," I said. "Will you be seeing it?"

"No," she answered.

"Will you be spending your holidays abroad this year?" I asked.

"No," she answered.

"Will you be staying in England?" I asked.

"No," she answered.

In despair, I asked her whether she was enjoying her dinner.

"Young man," she answered, "if you ate more and talked less, we would both enjoy our dinner!"

41. Do You Call That a Hat?

'Do you call that a hat?' I said to my wife.

'You needn't be so rude about it,' my wife answered as she looked at herself in the mirror.

I sat down on one of those modern chairs with holes in it and waited. We had been in the hat shop for half an hour and my wife was still in front of the mirror.

'We mustn't buy things we don't need,' I remarked suddenly. I regretted saying it almost at once.

'You needn't have said that,' my wife answered. 'I needn't remind you of that terrible tie you bought yesterday.'

'I find it beautiful,' I said. 'A man can never have too many ties.'

'And a woman can't have too many hats,' she answered.

Ten minutes later we walked out of the shop together. My wife was wearing a hat that looked like a lighthouse!

42. Not very musical

As we had had a long walk through one of the markets of Old Delhi, we stopped at a square to have a rest. After a time, we noticed a snake charmer with two large baskets at the other side of the square, so we went to have a look at him. As soon as he saw us, he picked up a long pipe which was covered with coins and opened one of the baskets. When he began to play a tune, we had our first glimpse of the snake. It rose out of the basket and began to follow the movements of the pipe. We were very much surprised when the snake charmer suddenly began to play jazz and modern pop songs. The snake, however, continued to 'dance' slowly. It obviously could not tell the difference between Indian music and jazz!

43. Over the South Pole

In 1929, three years after his flight over the North Pole, the American explorer, R.E. Byrd, successfully flew over the South Pole for the first time. Though, at first, Byrd and his men were able to take a great many photographs of the mountains that lay below, they soon ran into serious trouble. At one point, it seemed certain that their plane would crash. It could only get over the mountains if it rose to 10,000 feet. Byrd at once ordered his men to throw out two heavy food sacks. The plane was then able to rise and it cleared the mountains by 400 feet. Byrd now knew that he would be able to reach the South Pole which was 300 miles away, for there were no more mountains in sight. The aircraft was able to fly over the endless white plains without difficulty.

44. Through the Forest

Mrs. Anne Sterling did not think of the risk she was taking when she ran through a forest after two men. They had rushed up to her while she was having a picnic at the edge of a forest with her children and tried to steal her handbag. In the struggle, the strap broke and, with the bag in their possession, both men started running through the trees. Mrs. Sterling got so angry that she ran after them. She was soon out of breath, but she continued to run. When she caught up with them, she saw that they had sat down and were going through the contents of the bag, so she ran straight at them. The men got such a fright that they dropped the bag and ran away. 'The strap needs mending,' said Mrs. Sterling later, 'but they did not steal anything.'

45. A Clear Conscience

The whole village soon learnt that a large sum of money had been lost. Sam Benton, the local butcher, had lost his wallet while taking his savings to the post office. Sam was sure that the wallet must have been found by one of the villagers, but it was not returned to him. Three months passed, and then one morning, Sam found his wallet outside his front door. It had been wrapped up in newspaper and it contained half the money he had lost, together with a note which said: 'A thief, yes, but only 50 per cent a thief!' Two months later, some more money was sent to Sam with another note: 'Only 25 per cent a thief now!' In time, all Sam's money was paid back in this

way. The last note said: 'I am 100 per cent honest now!'

46. Expensive and Uncomfortable

When a plane from London arrived at Sydney airport, workers began to unload a number of wooden boxes which contained clothing.

No one could account for the fact that one of the boxes was extremely heavy. It suddenly occurred to one of the workers to open up the box. He was astonished at what he found. A man was lying in the box on top of a pile of woolen goods.

He was so surprised at being discovered that he did not even try to run away. After he was arrested, the man admitted hiding in the box before the plane left London. He had had a long and uncomfortable trip, for he had been confined to the wooden box for over eighteen hours. The man was ordered to pay £3,500 for the cost of the trip. The normal price of a ticket is £2,000!

47. A Thirsty Ghost

A public house which was recently bought by Mr. Ian Thompson is up for sale. Mr. Thompson is going to sell it because it is haunted. He told me that he could not go to sleep one night because he heard a strange noise coming from the bar. The next morning, he found that the doors had been blocked by chairs and the furniture had been moved. Though Mr. Thompson had turned the lights off before he went to bed, they were on in the morning. He also said that he had found five empty whisky bottles which the ghost must have drunk the night before. When I suggested that some villagers must have come in for a free drink, Mr. Thompson shook his head. The villagers have told him that they will not accept the pub even if he gives it away.

48. Did you want to tell me something?

Dentists always ask questions when it is impossible for you to answer. My dentist had just pulled out one of my teeth and had told me to rest for a while. I tried to say something, but my mouth was full of cotton-wool. He knew I collected match boxes and asked me whether my collection was growing. He then asked me how my brother was and whether I liked my new job in London. In answer to these questions I either nodded or made strange noises. Meanwhile, my tongue was busy searching out the hole where the tooth had been. I suddenly felt very worried, but could not say anything. When the dentist at last removed the cotton-wool from my mouth, I was able to tell him that he had pulled out the wrong tooth.

49. The end of a dream

Tired of sleeping on the floor, a young man in Teheran saved up for years to buy a real bed. For the first time in his life, he became the proud owner of a bed which had springs and a mattress. Because the weather was very hot, he carried the bed on to the roof of his house. He slept very well for the first two nights, but on the third night, a storm blew up. A gust of wind swept the bed off the roof and sent it crashing into the courtyard below. The young man did not wake up until the bed had struck the ground. Although the bed was smashed to pieces, the man was miraculously unhurt. When he woke up, he was still on the mattress. Glancing at the bits of wood and metal that lay around him, the man sadly picked up the mattress and carried it into his house. After he had put it on the floor, he promptly went to sleep again.

50. Taken for a ride

I love travelling in the country, but I don't like losing my way. I went on an excursion recently, but my trip took me longer than I expected.

'I'm going to Woodford Green,' I said to the conductor as I got on the bus, 'but I don't know where it is.'

'I'll tell you where to get off,' answered the conductor.

I sat in the front of the bus to get a good view of the countryside. After some time,

the bus stopped. Looking round, I realized with a shock that I was the only passenger left on the bus.

'You'll have to get off here,' the conductor said. 'This is as far as we go.'

'Is this Woodford Green?' I asked.

'Oh dear,' said the conductor suddenly. 'I forgot to put you off.'

'It doesn't matter,' I said. 'I'll get off here.'

'We're going back now,' said the conductor.

'Well, in that case, I prefer to stay on the bus,' I answered.

51. Reward for Virtue

My friend, Hugh, has always been fat, but things got so bad recently that he decided to go on a diet. He began his diet a week ago. First of all, he wrote out a long list of all the foods which were forbidden. The list included most of the things Hugh loves: butter, potatoes, rice, beer, milk, chocolate; and sweets. Yesterday I paid him a visit. I rang the bell and was not surprised to see that Hugh was still as fat as ever. He led me into his room and hurriedly hid a large parcel under his desk. It was obvious that he was very embarrassed. When I asked him what he was doing, he smiled guiltily and then put the parcel on the table. He explained that his diet was so strict that he had to reward himself occasionally. Then he showed me the contents of the parcel. It contained five large bars of chocolate and three bags of sweets!

52. A pretty carpet

We have just moved into a new house and I have been working hard all morning. I have been trying to get my new room in order. This has not been easy because I own over a thousand books. To make matters worse, the room is rather small, so I have temporarily put my books on the floor. At the moment, they cover every inch of floor space and I actually have to walk on them to get in or out of the room. A short while ago, my sister helped me to carry one of my old bookcases up the stairs. She went into my room and got a big surprise when she saw all those books on the floor. 'This is the prettiest carpet I have ever seen,' she said. She gazed at it for some time

then added, 'You don't need bookcases at all. You can sit here in your spare time and read the carpet!'

53. Hot Snake

At last firemen have put out a big forest fire in California. Since then, they have been trying to find out how the fire began. Forest fires are often caused by broken glass or by cigarette ends which people carelessly throw away. Yesterday the firemen examined the ground carefully, but were not able to find any broken glass. They were also quite sure that a cigarette end did not start the fire. This morning, however, a fireman accidentally discovered the cause. He noticed the remains of a snake which was wound round the electric wires of a 16,000 - volt power line. In this way, he was able to solve the mystery. The explanation was simple but very unusual. A bird had snatched up the snake from the ground and then dropped it on to the wires. The snake then wound itself round the wires. When it did so, it sent sparks down to the ground and these immediately started a fire.

54. Sticky fingers

After breakfast, I sent the children to school and then I went to the shops. It was still early when I returned home. The children were at school, my husband was at work and the house was quiet. So I decided to make some meat pies. In a short time I was busy mixing butter and flour and my hands were soon covered with sticky pastry. At exactly that moment, the telephone rang. Nothing could have been more annoying. I picked up the receiver between two sticky fingers and was dismayed when I recognized the voice of Helen Bates. It took me ten minutes to persuade her to ring back later. At last I hung up the receiver. What a mess! There was pastry on my fingers, on the telephone, and on the doorknobs. I had no sooner got back to the kitchen than the doorbell rang loud enough to wake the dead. This time it was the postman and he wanted me to sign for a registered letter!

55. Not a gold mine

Dreams of finding lost treasure almost came true recently. A new machine called 'The Revealer' has been invented and it has been used to detect gold which has been buried in the ground. The machine was used in a cave near the seashore where-it is said-pirates used to hide gold. The pirates would often bury gold in the cave and then fail to collect it. Armed with the new machine, a search party went into the cave hoping to find buried treasure. The leader of the party was examining the soil near the entrance to the cave when the machine showed that there was gold under the ground. Very excited, the party dug a hole two feet deep. They finally found a small gold coin which was almost worthless.

The party then searched the whole cave thoroughly but did not find anything except an empty tin trunk. In spite of this, many people are confident that 'The Revealer' may reveal something of value fairly soon.

56. Faster than Sound!

Once a year, a race is held for old cars. A lot of cars entered for this race last year and there was a great deal of excitement just before it began. One of the most handsome cars was a Rolls - Royce Silver Ghost. The most unusual car was a Benz which had only three wheels. Built in 1885, it was the oldest car taking part. After a great many loud explosions, the race began. Many of the cars broke down on the course and some drivers spent more time under their cars than in them! A few cars, however, completed the race. The winning car reached a speed of forty miles an hour - much faster than any of its rivals. It sped downhill at the end of the race and its driver had a lot of trouble trying to stop it. The race gave everyone a great deal of pleasure. It was very different from modern car races but no less exciting.

57. Can I help you, madam?

A woman in blue jeans stood at the window of an expensive shop. Though she hesitated for a moment, she finally went in and asked to see a dress that was in the window. The assistant who served her did not like the way she was dressed. Glancing at her scornfully, he told her that the dress was sold. The woman walked

out of the shop angrily and decided to punish the assistant next day. She returned to the shop the following morning dressed in a fur coat, with a handbag in one hand and a long umbrella in the other. After seeking out the rude assistant, she asked for the same dress. Not realizing who she was, the assistant was eager to serve her this time. With great difficulty, he climbed into the shop window to get the dress. As soon as she saw it, the woman said she did not like it. She enjoyed herself making the assistant bring almost everything in the window before finally buying the dress she had first asked for.

58. A Blessing in Disguise

The tiny village of Frinley is said to possess a 'cursed tree'. Because the tree was mentioned in a newspaper, the number of visitors to Frinley has now increased. The tree was planted near the church fifty years ago, but it is only in recent years that it has gained an evil reputation. It is said that if anyone touches the tree, he will have bad luck; if he picks a leaf, he will die. Many villagers believe that the tree has already claimed a number of victims. The vicar has been asked to have the tree cut down, but so far he has refused. He has pointed out that the tree is a useful source of income as tourists have been coming from all parts of the country to see it. In spite of all that has been said, the tourists have been picking leaves and cutting their names on the tree - trunk. So far, not one of them has been struck down by sudden death!

59. In or out

Our dog, Rex, used to sit outside our front gate and bark. Every time he wanted to come into the garden he would bark until someone opened the gate. As the neighbours complained of the noise, my husband spent weeks training him to press his paw on the latch to let himself in. Rex soon became an expert at opening the gate. However, when I was going out shopping last week, I noticed him in the garden near the gate. This time he was barking so that someone would let him out! Since then, he has developed another bad habit. As soon as he opens the gate from the outside, he comes into the garden and waits until the gate shuts. Then he sits and barks until someone lets him out. After this he immediately lets himself in and begins barking again. Yesterday my husband removed the gate and Rex got so

annoyed we have not seen him since.

60. The Future

At a village fair, I decided to visit a fortune - teller called Madam Bellinsky. I went into her tent and she told me to sit down. After I had given her some money, she looked into a crystal ball and said: 'A relation of yours is coming to see you. She will be arriving this evening and intends to stay for a few days. The moment you leave this tent, you will get a big surprise. A woman you know well will rush towards you. She will speak to you and then she will lead you away from this place. That is all.' As soon as I went outside, I forgot all about Madam Bellinsky because my wife hurried towards me. 'Where have you been hiding?' she asked impatiently. 'Your sister will be here in less than an hour and we must be at the station to meet her. We are late already.' As she walked away, I followed her out of the fair.

61. Trouble with the Hubble

The Hubble telescope was launched into space by NASA on April 20, 1990 at a cost of over a billion dollars.

Right from the start there was trouble with the Hubble. The pictures it sent us were very disappointing because its main mirror was faulty! NASA is now going to put the telescope right, so it will soon be sending up four astronauts to repair it. The shuttle Endeavour will be taking the astronauts to the Hubble.

A robot-arm from the Endeavour will grab the telescope and hold it while the astronauts make the necessary repairs. Of course, the Hubble is above the earth's atmosphere, so it will soon be sending us the clearest pictures of the stars and distant galaxies that we have ever seen.

The Hubble will tell us a great deal about the age and size of the universe. By the time you read this, the Hubble's eagle eye will have sent us thousands and thousands of wonderful pictures.

62. After the Fire

Firemen had been fighting the forest fire for nearly three weeks before they could get it under control. A short time before, great trees had covered the countryside for miles around. Now, smoke still rose up from the warm ground over the desolate hills. Winter was coming on and the hills threatened the surrounding villages with destruction, for heavy rain would not only wash away the soil but would cause serious floods as well. When the fire had at last been put out, the forest authorities ordered several tons of a special type of grass - seed which would grow quickly. The seed was sprayed over the ground in huge quantities by aeroplanes. The planes had been planting seed for nearly a month when it began to rain. By then, however, in many places the grass had already taken root. In place of the great trees which had been growing there for centuries, patches of green had begun to appear in the blackened soil.

63. She was not amused

Jeremy Hampden has a large circle of friends and is very popular at parties. Everybody admires him for his great sense of humour - everybody, that is, except his six - year - old daughter, Jenny. Recently, one of Jeremy's closest friends asked him to make a speech at a wedding reception. This is the sort of thing that Jeremy loves. He prepared the speech carefully and went to the wedding with Jenny. He had included a large number of funny stories in the speech and, of course, it was a great success. As soon as he had finished, Jenny told him she wanted to go home. Jeremy was a little disappointed by this but he did as his daughter asked. On the way home, he asked Jenny if she had enjoyed the speech. To his surprise, she said she hadn't. Jeremy asked her why this was so and she told him that she did not like to see so many people laughing at him!

64. The Channel Tunnel

In 1858, a French engineer, Aime Thome de Gamond, arrived in England with a plan for a twenty - one - mile tunnel under the English Channel. He said that it would be possible to build a platform in the centre of the Channel. This platform would serve as a port and a railway station. The tunnel would be well - ventilated if

tall chimneys were built above sea level. In 1860, a better plan was put forward by an Englishman, William Low. He suggested that a double railway - tunnel should be built. This would solve the problem of ventilation, for if a train entered this tunnel, it would draw in fresh air behind it. Forty - two years later a tunnel was actually begun. If, at the time, the British had not feared invasion, it would have been completed. The world had to wait almost another 100 years for the Channel Tunnel. It was officially opened on March 7, 1994, finally connecting Britain to the European continent.

65. Jumbo versus the police

Last Christmas, the circus owner, Jimmy Gates, decided to take some presents to a children's hospital. Dressed up as Father Christmas and accompanied by a 'guard of honour' of six pretty girls, he set off down the main street of the city riding a baby elephant called Jumbo. He should have known that the police would never allow this sort of thing. A policeman approached Jimmy and told him he ought to have gone along a side street as Jumbo was holding up the traffic. Though Jimmy agreed to go at once, Jumbo refused to move. Fifteen policemen had to push very hard to get him off the main street. The police had a difficult time, but they were most amused. 'Jumbo must weigh a few tons,' said a policeman afterwards, 'so it was fortunate that we didn't have to carry him. Of course, we should arrest him, but as he has a good record, we shall let him off this time.'

66. Sweet as Honey

In 1963 a Lancaster bomber crashed on Wallis Island, a remote place in the South Pacific, a long way west of Samoa. The plane wasn't too badly damaged, but over the years, the crash was forgotten and the wreck remained undisturbed. Then in 1989, twenty - six years after the crash, the plane was accidentally rediscovered in an aerial survey of the island. By this time, a Lancaster bomber in reasonable condition was rare and worth rescuing. The French authorities had the plane packaged and moved in parts back to France. Now a group of enthusiasts are going to have the plane restored. It has four Rolls - Royce Merlin engines, but the group will need to have only three of them rebuilt. Imagine their surprise and delight when they broke open the packing cases and found that the fourth engine was sweet as

honey - still in perfect condition. A colony of bees had turned the engine into a hive and it was totally preserved in beeswax!

67. Volcanoes

Haroun Tazieff, the Polish scientist, has spent his lifetime studying active volcanoes and deep caves in all parts of the world. In 1948, he went to Lake Kivu in the Congo to observe a new volcano which he later named Kituro. Tazieff was able to set up his camp very close to the volcano while it was erupting violently. Though he managed to take a number of brilliant photographs, he could not stay near the volcano for very long. He noticed that a river of liquid rock was coming towards him. It threatened to surround him completely, but Tazieff managed to escape just in time. He waited until the volcano became quiet and he was able to return two days later. This time, he managed to climb into the mouth of Kituro so that he could take photographs and measure temperatures. Tazieff has often risked his life in this way. He has been able to tell us more about active volcanoes than any man alive.

68. Persistent

I crossed the street to avoid meeting him, but he saw me and came running towards me. It was no use pretending that I had not seen him, so I waved to him. I never enjoy meeting Nigel Dykes. He never has anything to do. No matter how busy you are, he always insists on coming with you. I had to think of a way of preventing him from following me around all morning.

'Hello, Nigel,' I said. 'Fancy meeting you here!'

'Hello, Elizabeth,' Nigel answered. 'I was just wondering how to spend the morning - until I saw you. You're not busy doing anything, are you?'

'No, not at all,' I answered. 'I'm going to...'

'Wouldn't you like to come with me?' he asked, before I had finished speaking.

'Actually, I'm going to the dentist,' I said.

'Oh, what a pity!' Nigel said. 'Then I'll come with you. There's always plenty to read in the waiting room!'

69. But not murder!

I was being tested for a driving licence for the third time. I had been asked to drive in heavy traffic and had done so successfully. After having been instructed to drive out of town, I began to acquire confidence. Sure that I had passed, I was almost beginning to enjoy my test. The examiner must have been pleased with my performance, for he smiled and said. 'Just one more thing, Mr. Eames. Let us suppose that a child suddenly crosses the road in front of you. As soon as I tap on the window, you must stop within five feet.' I continued driving and after some time, the examiner tapped loudly. Though the sound could be heard clearly, it took me a long time to react. I suddenly pressed the brake pedal hard and we were both thrown forward. The examiner looked at me sadly. 'Mr. Eames,' he said, in a mournful voice, 'you have just killed that child!'

70. Red for Danger

During a bullfight, a drunk suddenly wandered into the middle of the ring. The crowd began to shout, but the drunk was unaware of the danger. The bull was busy with the matador at the time, but it suddenly caught sight of the drunk who was shouting rude remarks and waving a red cap. Apparently sensitive to criticism, the bull forgot all about the matador and charged at the drunk. The crowd suddenly grew quiet. The drunk, however, seemed quite sure of himself. When the bull got close to him, he clumsily stepped aside to let it pass. The crowd broke into cheers and the drunk bowed. By this time, however, three men had come into the ring and they quickly dragged the drunk to safety. Even the bull seemed to feel sorry for him, for it looked on sympathetically until the drunk was out of the sight.

71. A Famous Clock

When you visit London, one of the first things you will see is Big Ben, the famous clock which can be heard all over the world on the B.B.C. If the Houses of Parliament had not been burned down in 1834, the great clock would never have been erected. Big Ben takes its name from Sir Benjamin Hall who was responsible for the making of the clock when the new Houses of Parliament were being built. It is not only of immense size, but is extremely accurate as well. Officials from

Greenwich Observatory have the clock checked twice a day. On the B.B.C. you can hear the clock when it is actually striking because microphones are connected to the clock tower. Big Ben has rarely gone wrong. Once, however, it failed to give the correct time. A painter who had been working on the tower hung a pot of paint on one of the hands and slowed it down!

72. A car called Bluebird

The great racing driver, Sir Malcolm Campbell, was the first man to drive at over 300 miles per hour. He set up a new world record in September 1935 at Bonneville Salt Flats, Utah. Bluebird, the car he was driving, had been specially built for him. It was over 30 feet in length and had a 2,500 - horsepower engine. Although Campbell reached a speed of over 304 miles per hour, he had great difficulty in controlling the car because a tyre burst during the first run. After his attempt, Campbell was disappointed to learn that his average speed had been 299 miles per hour. However, a few days later, he was told that a mistake had been made. His average speed had been 301 miles per hour. Since that time, racing drivers have reached speeds over 600 miles per hour. Following in his father's footsteps many years later, Sir Malcolm's son, Donald, also set up a world record. Like his father, he was driving a car called Bluebird.

73. The record-holder

Children who play truant from school are unimaginative. A quiet day's fishing, or eight hours in a cinema seeing the same film over and over again, is usually as far as they get. They have all been put to shame by a boy who, while playing truant, travelled 1,600 miles. He hitchhiked to Dover and, towards evening, went into a boat to find somewhere to sleep. When he woke up next morning, he discovered that the boat had, in the meantime, travelled to Calais. No one noticed the boy as he crept off. From there, he hitchhiked to Paris in a lorry. The driver gave him a few biscuits and a cup of coffee and left him just outside the city. The next car the boy stopped did not take him into the centre of Paris as he hoped it would, but to Perpignan on the French - Spanish border. There he was picked up by a policeman and sent back to England by the local authorities. He has surely set up a record for the thousands of children who dream of evading school.

74. Out of the Limelight

An ancient bus stopped by a dry river bed and a party of famous actors and actresses got off. Dressed in dark glasses and old clothes, they had taken special precautions so that no one should recognize them. But as they soon discovered, disguises can sometimes be too perfect.

This is a wonderful place for a picnic, said Gloria Gleam.

It couldn't be better, Gloria, Brinksley Meers agreed.

No sooner had they sat down than they found it was surrounded by ants. The ants had been quick to find an entrance to their nest.

I thought you said your dog didn't bite! shouted Aunt Elizabeth to the young man as she bandaged her knee.

It doesn't, said the young man.

These are not my dogs, he added, as soon as four policemen arrived to arrest him.

75. SOS

When a light passenger plane flew off course some time ago, it crashed in the mountains and its pilot was killed. The only passengers, a young woman and her two baby daughters, were unhurt. It was the middle of winter. Snow lay thick on the ground. The woman knew that the nearest village was miles away. When it grew dark, she turned a suitcase into a bed and put the children inside it, covering them with all the clothes she could find. During the night, it got terribly cold. The woman kept as near as she could to the children and even tried to get into the case herself, but it was too small. Early next morning, she heard planes passing overhead and wondered how she could send a signal. Then she had an idea. She stamped out the letters 'SOS' in the snow. Fortunately, a pilot saw the signal and sent a message by radio to the nearest town. It was not long before a helicopter arrived on the scene to rescue the survivors of the plane crash.

76. To the Antarctic

In 1956, a Brazilian expedition arrived in Antarctica to explore a region which was completely unknown until then. The aim of the expedition was to study the geology and wildlife of the area. They also hoped to find new species of plants and animals.

The first problem the expedition faced was the extreme cold. Temperatures often dropped to minus 60 degrees Celsius. Despite this, the scientists worked hard, collecting samples of rocks and fossils, and observing the behavior of the penguins and seals.

One day, a member of the expedition noticed something strange in the ice. It was the shape of a large animal. As they dug deeper, they found the frozen body of a prehistoric mammoth. This was an amazing discovery, as it was the first time that such a well - preserved mammoth had been found in Antarctica.

The expedition also had some difficulties with their equipment. Their radio stopped working, and they had problems with their vehicles. But they managed to overcome these problems and continued their research.

After several months, the expedition returned home with a great deal of valuable information. Their findings will help scientists to learn more about the history of the Earth and the evolution of life.

77. A successful operation

The mummy of an Egyptian woman who died in 800 B.C. has just had an operation. The mummy is that of Shepenmut who was once a singer in the Temple of Thebes. As there were strange marks on the X - ray plates taken of the mummy, doctors have been trying to find out whether the woman died of a rare disease. The only way to do this was to operate. The operation, which lasted for over four hours, proved to be very difficult because of the hard resin which covered the skin.

The doctors removed a section of the mummy and sent it to a laboratory. They also found something which the X - ray plates did not show: a small wax figure of the god Duamutef. This god which has the head of a cow was normally placed inside a mummy. The doctors have not yet decided how the woman died.

78. The Last One

After reading an article entitled 'Cigarette Smoking and Your Health' I lit a cigarette to calm my nerves. I smoked with concentration and pleasure as I was sure that this would be my last cigarette. For a whole week I did not smoke at all and during this time, my wife suffered terribly. I had all the usual symptoms of someone giving up smoking: a bad temper and an enormous appetite. My friends kept on offering me cigarettes and cigars. They made no effort to hide their amusement whenever I produced a packet of sweets from my pocket. After seven days of this I went to a party. Everybody around me was smoking and I felt extremely uncomfortable. When my old friend Brian urged me to accept a cigarette, it was more than I could bear. I took one guiltily, lit it and smoked with satisfaction. My wife was delighted that things had returned to normal once more. Anyway, as Brian pointed out, it is the easiest thing in the world to give up smoking. He himself has done it lots of times!

79. By air

I used to travel by air a great deal when I was a boy. My parents used to live in South America and I used to fly there from Europe in the holidays. A flight attendant would take charge of me and I never had an unpleasant experience. I am used to traveling by air and only on one occasion have I ever felt frightened. After taking off, we were flying low over the city and slowly gaining height, when the plane suddenly turned round and flew back to the airport. While we were waiting to land, a flight attendant told us to keep calm and to get off the plane quietly as soon as it had touched down. Everybody on board was worried and we were curious to find out what had happened. Later we learnt that there was a very important person on board. The police had been told that a bomb had been planted on the plane. After we had landed, the plane was searched thoroughly. Fortunately, nothing was found and five hours later we were able to take off again.

80. The Crystal Palace

Perhaps the most extraordinary building of the nineteenth century was the Crystal Palace, which was built in Hyde Park for the Great Exhibition of 1851. The Crystal Palace was different from all other buildings in the world, for it was made of iron and glass. It was one of the biggest buildings of all time and a lot of people from many countries came to see it. A great many goods were sent to the exhibition from various parts of the world. There was also a great deal of machinery on display. The most wonderful piece of machinery on show was Nasmyth's steam hammer. Though in those days, travelling was not as easy as it is today, steam boats carried thousands of visitors across the Channel from Europe. On arriving in England, they were taken to the Crystal Palace by train. There were six million visitors in all, and the profits from the exhibition were used to build museums and colleges. Later, the Crystal Palace was moved to South London. It remained one of the most famous buildings in the world until it was burnt down in 1936.

81. Escape

When he had killed the guard, the prisoner of war quickly dragged him into the bushes. Working rapidly in the darkness, he soon changed into the dead man's clothes. Now, dressed in a blue uniform and with a rifle over his shoulder, the prisoner marched boldly up and down in front of the camp. He could hear shouting in the camp itself. Lights were blazing and men were running here and there: they had just discovered that a prisoner had escaped. At that moment, a large black car with four officers inside it, stopped at the camp gates. The officers got out and the prisoner stood to attention and saluted as they passed. When they had gone, the driver of the car came towards him. The man obviously wanted to talk. He was rather elderly with grey hair and clear blue eyes. The prisoner felt sorry for him, but there was nothing else he could do. As the man came near, the prisoner knocked him to the ground with a sharp blow. Then, jumping into the car, he drove off as quickly as he could.

82. Monster or fish

Fishermen and sailors sometimes claim to have seen monsters in the sea. Though people have often laughed at stories told by seamen, it is now known that many of these 'monsters' which have at times been sighted are simply strange fish.

Occasionally, unusual creatures are washed to the shore, but they are rarely caught out at sea. Some time ago, however, a peculiar fish was caught near Madagascar. A small fishing boat was carried miles out to sea by the powerful fish as it pulled on the line. Realizing that this was no ordinary fish, the fisherman made every effort not to damage it in any way. When it was eventually brought to shore, it was found to be over thirteen feet long. It had a head like a horse, big blue eyes, shining silver skin, and a bright red tail. The fish, which has since been sent to a museum where it is being examined by a scientist, is called an oarfish. Such creatures have rarely been seen alive by man as they live at a depth of six hundred feet.

83. After the Elections

The former Prime Minister, Mr. Wentworth Lane, was defeated in the recent elections. He is now retiring from political life and has gone abroad. My friend, Patrick, has always been a fanatical opponent of Mr. Lane's Radical Progressive Party. After the elections, Patrick went to the former Prime Minister's house. When he asked if Mr. Lane lived there, the policeman on duty told him that since his defeat, the ex - Prime Minister had gone abroad. On the following day, Patrick went to the house again. The same policeman was just walking slowly past the entrance, when Patrick asked the same question. Though a little suspicious this time, the policeman gave him the same answer. The day after, Patrick went to the house once more and asked exactly the same question. This time, the policeman lost his temper. 'I told you yesterday and the day before yesterday,' he shouted, 'Mr. Lane was defeated in the elections. He has retired from political life and gone to live abroad!'

'I know,' answered Patrick, 'but I love to hear you say it!'

84. On Strike

Busmen have decided to go on strike next week. The strike is due to begin on Tuesday. No one knows how long it will last. The busmen have stated that the strike will continue until general agreement is reached about pay and working conditions. Most people believe that the strike will last for at least a week. Many owners of private cars are going to offer 'free rides' to people on their way to work. This will relieve pressure on the trains to some extent. Meanwhile, a number of university students have volunteered to drive buses while the strike lasts. All the students are expert drivers, but before they drive any of the buses, they will have to pass a special test. The students are going to take the test in two days' time. Even so, people are going to find it difficult to get to work. But so far, the public has expressed its gratitude to the students in letters to the Press. Only one or two people have objected that the students will drive too fast!

85. Never too old to learn

I have just received a letter from my old school, informing me that my former headmaster, Mr. Stuart Page, will be retiring next week. Pupils of the school, old and new, will be sending him a present to mark the occasion. All those who have contributed towards the gift will sign their names in a large album which will be sent to the headmaster's home. We shall all remember Mr. Page for his patience and understanding and for the kindly encouragement he gave us when we went so unwillingly to school. A great many former pupils will be attending a farewell dinner in his honour next Thursday. It is a curious coincidence that the day before his retirement, Mr. Page will have been teaching for a total of forty years. After he has retired, he will devote himself to gardening. For him, this will be an entirely new hobby. But this does not matter, for, as he has often remarked, one is never too old to learn.

86. Out of control

As the man tried to swing the speedboat round, the steering wheel came away in his hands. He waved desperately to his companion, who had been water skiing for the last fifteen minutes. Both men had hardly had time to realize what was happening when they were thrown violently into the sea. The speedboat had struck a buoy, but it continued to move very quickly across the water. Both men had just begun to swim towards the shore, when they noticed with dismay that the speedboat was moving in a circle. It now came straight towards them at tremendous speed. In less than a minute, it roared past them only a few feet away. After it had passed, they swam on as quickly as they could because they knew that the boat would soon return. They had just had enough time to swim out of danger when the boat again completed a circle. On this occasion, however, it had slowed down considerably. The petrol had nearly all been used up. Before long, the noise dropped completely and the boat began to drift gently across the water.

87. A Perfect Alibi

At the time the murder was committed, I was travelling on the 8 o'clock train to London, said the man.

Do you always catch such an early train? asked the inspector.

Of course I do, answered the man. I must be at work at 10 o'clock. My employer will confirm that I was there on time.

Would a later train get you to work on time? asked the inspector.

I suppose it would, but I never catch a later train.

At what time did you arrive at the station?

At ten to eight. I bought a paper and waited for the train.

And you didn't notice anything unusual?

Of course not.

I suggest, said the inspector, that you are not telling the truth. I suggest that you did not catch the 8 o'clock train, but that you caught the 8.25 which would still get you to work on time. You see, on the morning of the murder, the 8 o'clock train did not

run at all. It had broken down at Ferngreen station and was taken off the line.

88. Trapped in a mine

Six men have been trapped in a mine for seventeen hours. If they are not brought to the surface soon they may lose their lives. However, rescue operations are proving difficult. If explosives are used, vibrations will cause the roof of the mine to collapse. Rescue workers are therefore drilling a hole on the north side of the mine. They intend to bring the men up in a special capsule. If there had not been a hard layer of rock beneath the soil, they would have completed the job in a few hours. As it is, they have been drilling for sixteen hours and they still have a long way to go. Meanwhile, a microphone, which was lowered into the mine two hours ago, has enabled the men to keep in touch with their closest relatives. Though they are running out of food and drink, the men are cheerful and confident that they will get out soon. They have been told that rescue operations are progressing smoothly. If they knew how difficult it was to drill through the hard rock, they would lose heart.

89. For Sale

Good afternoon. I believe that this house is for sale.

That's right.

May I have a look at it, please?

Yes, of course. Come in.

How long have you lived here?

I've lived here for twenty years.

Twenty years! That's a long time.

Yes, I've been here since 1976.

Then why do you want to sell it?

Because I've just retired. I want to buy a small house in the country.

How much does this house cost?

\$68,500.

That's a lot of money!

It's worth every penny of it.

Well, I like the house, but I can't decide yet. My wife must see it first.

Women always have the last word.

90. What's for supper?

Fish and chips has always been a favourite dish in Britain, but as the oceans have been overfished, fish has become more and more expensive. So it comes as a surprise to learn that giant fish are terrifying the divers on North Sea oil rigs. Oil rigs have to be repaired frequently and divers, who often have to work in darkness a hundred feet under water, have been frightened out of their wits by giant fish bumping into them as they work. Now they have had special cages made to protect them from these monsters. The fish are not sharks or killer whales, but favourite eating varieties like cod and skate which grow to unnatural sizes, sometimes as much as twelve feet in length. Three factors have caused these fish to grow so large: the warm water round the hot oil pipes under the sea; the plentiful supply of food thrown overboard by the crews on the rigs; the total absence of fishing boats around the oil rigs. As a result, the fish just eat and eat and grow and grow in the lovely warm water. Who eats who?

91. Three Men in a Basket

A pilot noticed a balloon which seemed to be making for a Royal Air Force Station nearby. He informed the station at once, but no one there was able to explain the mystery. The officer in the control tower was very angry when he heard the news, because balloons can be a great danger to aircraft. He said that someone might be spying on the station and the pilot was ordered to keep track of the strange object. The pilot managed to circle the balloon for some time. He could make out three men in a basket under it and one of them was holding a pair of binoculars. When the

balloon was over the station, the pilot saw one of the men taking photographs. Soon afterwards, the balloon began to descend and it landed near an airfield. The police were called in, but they could not arrest anyone, for the basket contained two Members of Parliament and the Commanding Officer of the station! As the Commanding Officer explained later, one half of the station did not know what the other half was doing!

92. Asking for Trouble

It must have been about two in the morning when I returned home. I tried to wake up my wife by ringing the doorbell, but she was fast asleep, so I got a ladder from the shed in the garden, put it against the wall, and began climbing towards the bedroom window. I was almost there when a sarcastic voice below said, 'I don't think the windows need cleaning at this time of the night.' I looked down and nearly fell off the ladder when I saw a policeman. I immediately regretted answering in the way I did, but I said, 'I enjoy cleaning windows at night.'

'So do I,' answered the policeman in the same tone. 'Excuse me for interrupting you. I hate to interrupt a man when he's busy working, but would you mind coming with me to the station?'

'Well, I'd prefer to stay here,' I said. 'You see. I've forgotten my key.'

'Your what?' he called.

'My key,' I shouted.

Fortunately, the shouting woke up my wife who opened the window just as the policeman had started to climb towards me.

93. A noble gift

One of the most famous monuments in the world, the Statue of Liberty, was presented to the United States of America in the nineteenth century by the people of France.

The great statue, which was designed by the sculptor Auguste Bartholdi, took ten years to complete. The actual figure was made of copper supported by a metal

framework which had been especially constructed by Eiffel. Before it could be transported to the United States, a site had to be found for it and a pedestal had to be built. The site chosen was an island at the entrance of New York Harbour. By 1884, a statue which was 151 feet tall had been erected in Paris. The following year, it was taken to pieces and sent to America.

By the end of October 1886, the statue had been put together again and it was officially presented to the American people by Bartholdi. Ever since then, the great monument has been a symbol of liberty for the millions of people who have passed through New York Harbour to make their homes in America.

94. Future Champions

Experiments have proved that children can be instructed in swimming at a very early age. At a special swimming pool in Los Angeles, children become expert at holding their breath under water even before they can walk. Babies of two months old do not appear to be reluctant to enter the water. It is not long before they are so accustomed to swimming that they can pick up weights from the floor of the pool. A game that is very popular with these young swimmers is the underwater tricycle race. Tricycles are lined up on the floor of the pool seven feet under water. The children compete against each other to reach the other end of the pool. Many pedal their tricycles, but most of them prefer to push or drag them. Some children can cover the whole length of the pool without coming up for breath even once. Whether they will ever become future Olympic champions, only time will tell. Meanwhile, they should encourage those among us who cannot swim five yards before they are gasping for air.

95. A fantasy

When the Ambassador of Escalopia returned home for lunch, his wife got a shock. He looked pale and his clothes were in tatters.

'What has happened?' she asked. 'How did your clothes get into such a mess?'

'A fire extinguisher, my dear,' answered the Ambassador drily. 'University students set the Embassy on fire this morning.'

'Good heavens!' exclaimed his wife. 'And where were you at the time?'

'I was in my office as usual,' answered the Ambassador. 'The fire broke out in the basement. I went down immediately, of course, and that fool, Horst, aimed a fire extinguisher at me. He thought I was on fire. I must definitely get that fellow posted.'

The Ambassador's wife went on asking questions, when she suddenly noticed a big hole in her husband's hat.

'And how can you explain that?' she asked.

'Oh, that,' said the Ambassador. 'Someone fired a shot through my office window. Accurate, don't you think? Fortunately, I wasn't wearing it at the time. If I had been, I would not have been able to get home for lunch.'

96. The dead return

A Festival for the Dead is held once a year in Japan. This festival is a cheerful occasion, for on this day, the dead are said to return to their homes and they are welcomed by the living. As they are expected to be hungry after their long journey, food is laid out for them. Specially-made lanterns are hung outside each house to help the dead to find their way. All night long, people dance and sing. In the early morning, the food that had been laid out for the dead is thrown into a river or into the sea as it is considered unlucky for anyone living to eat it. In towns that are near the sea, the tiny lanterns which had been hung in the streets the night before, are placed into the water when the festival is over. Thousands of lanterns slowly drift out to sea guiding the dead on their return journey to the other world. This is a moving spectacle, for crowds of people stand on the shore watching the lanterns drifting away until they can be seen no more.

Book 3

1. A Puma at large

Pumas are large, cat - like animals which are found in America. When reports came into London Zoo that a wild puma had been spotted forty - five miles south of London, they were not taken seriously. However, as the evidence began to accumulate, experts from the Zoo felt obliged to investigate, for the descriptions given by people who claimed to have seen the puma were extraordinarily similar.

The hunt for the puma began in a small village where a woman picking blackberries saw 'a large cat' only five yards away from her. It immediately ran away when she saw it, and experts confirmed that a puma will not attack a human being unless it is cornered. The search proved difficult, for the puma was often observed at one place in the morning and at another place twenty miles away in the evening. Wherever it went, it left behind it a trail of dead deer and small animals like rabbits.

Footprints were seen in a number of places and puma fur was found clinging to bushes. Several people claimed to have seen the puma at different times, but they all agreed that it was a large cat with a long tail and a light - brown coat. All the evidence pointed to the fact that the puma was in the area.

In the end, the mystery was solved when the puma was caught by a farmer in a trap. It was a young puma which had strayed from its mother and decided to go exploring on its own. It must have been in the area for some time, for it had already eaten some of the deer and small animals that were in the area. It was taken to London Zoo, where it lived for several months before it died.

2. Thirteen Equals One

Our vicar is always raising money for one cause or another, but he has never managed to get enough money to have the church clock repaired. The big clock which used to strike the hours day and night was damaged many years ago and has been silent ever since.

One night, however, our vicar woke up with a start: the clock was striking the hours!

Looking at his watch, he saw that it was one o'clock, but the bell struck thirteen times before it stopped. Armed with a torch, the vicar went up into the clock tower to see what was going on. In the torchlight, he caught sight of a figure whom he immediately recognized as Bill Wilkins, our local grocer.

'Whatever are you doing up here Bill?' asked the vicar in surprise.

'I'm trying to repair the bell,' answered Bill. 'I've been coming up here night after night for weeks now. You see, I was hoping to give you a surprise.'

'You certainly did give me a surprise!' said the vicar. 'You've probably woken up everyone in the village as well. Still, I'm glad the bell is working again.'

'That's the trouble, vicar,' answered Bill. 'It's working all right, but I'm afraid that at one o'clock it will strike thirteen times and there's nothing I can do about it.'

We shall have to get the bell fixed, said the vicar, 'but not yet.

I'm afraid it will not be over until the last stroke has been struck. And the last stroke may not be for some time yet.'

3. An unknown goddess

Some time ago, an interesting discovery was made by archaeologists on the Aegean island of Kea. An American team explored a temple which stands in an ancient city on the promontory of Ayia Irini. The city at one time must have been prosperous, for it enjoyed a high level of civilization. Houses -- often three storeys high -- were built of stone. They had large rooms with beautifully decorated walls. The city was even equipped with a drainage system, for a great many clay pipes were found beneath the narrow streets.

The temple which the archaeologists explored was used as a place of worship from the fifteenth century B.C. until Roman times. In the most sacred room of the temple, clay fragments of fifteen statues were found. Each of these represented a goddess and had, at one time, been painted. The body of one statue was found among remains dating from the fifteenth century B.C. Its missing head happened to be among remains of the fifth century B.C.

This head must have been found in Classical times and carefully preserved. It was very old and precious even then. When the archaeologists reconstructed the fragments, they were amazed to find that the goddess turned out to be a very modern

- looking woman. She stood three feet high and her hands rested on her hips. She was wearing a full - length skirt which swept the ground. Despite her great age, she was very graceful indeed, but, so far, the archaeologists have been unable to discover her identity.

4. The double life of Alfred Bloggs

These days, people who do manual work often receive far more money than people who work in offices. People who work in offices are frequently referred to as 'white - collar workers' for the simple reason that they usually wear a collar and tie to go to work. Such is human nature, that a great many people are often willing to sacrifice higher pay for the privilege of becoming white - collar workers. This can give rise to curious situations, as it did in the case of Alfred Bloggs who worked as a dustman for the Ellesmere Corporation.

When he got married, Alf was too embarrassed to say anything to his wife about his job. He simply told her that he worked for the Corporation. Every morning, he left home dressed in a smart black suit. He then changed into overalls and spent the next eight hours as a dustman. Before returning home at night, he took a shower and changed back into his suit. Alf did this for over two years and his fellow dustmen kept his secret. Alf's wife has never discovered that she married a dustman and she never will, for Alf has just found another job. He will soon be working in an office. He will be earning only half as much as he used to, but he feels that his rise in status is well worth the loss of money.

5. The facts

Editors of newspapers and magazines often go to extremes to provide their readers with unimportant facts and statistics. Last year a journalist had been instructed by a well - known magazine to write an article on the president's palace in a new African republic. When the article arrived, the editor read the first sentence and then refused to publish it. The article began: 'Hundreds of steps lead to the high wall which surrounds the president's palace.' The editor at once sent the journalist a fax instructing him to find out the exact number of steps and the height of the wall.

The journalist immediately set out to obtain these important facts, but he took a long

time to send them. Meanwhile, the editor was getting impatient, for the magazine would soon go to press. He sent the journalist two more faxes, but received no reply. He sent yet another fax informing the journalist that if he did not reply soon he would be fired. When the journalist finally replied, he said that he had been arrested while counting the steps in front of the president's palace. The police had told him that he was not allowed to park his car there. As he had no place to stay, he decided to spend the night in the station. He counted the steps again, and then the height of the wall. When he got home, he sent the editor the facts as he had promised.

6. Smash-and-grab

The expensive shops in a famous arcade near Piccadilly were just opening. At this time of the morning, the arcade was almost empty. Mr Taylor, the owner of a jewellery shop was admiring a new window display. Two of his assistants had been working busily since 8 o'clock and had only just finished. Diamond necklaces and rings had been beautifully arranged on a background of black velvet. After gazing at the display for several minutes, Mr Taylor went back into his shop.

The silence was suddenly broken when a large car, with its headlights on and its horn blaring, roared down the arcade. It came to a stop outside the jeweller's. One man stayed at the wheel while two others with black stockings over their faces jumped out and smashed the window of the shop with iron bars. While this was going on, Mr Taylor was upstairs. He and his staff began throwing furniture out of the window. Chairs and tables went flying into the arcade. One of the thieves was struck by a heavy statue, but he was too busy helping himself to diamonds to notice any pain. The raid was all over in three minutes, for the men scrambled back into the car and it moved off at a fantastic speed. Just as it was leaving, Mr Taylor rushed out and ran after it throwing ashtrays and vases, but it was impossible to stop the thieves. They had got away with thousands of pounds worth of diamonds.

7. Mutilated ladies

Has it ever happened to you? Have you ever put your trousers in the washing machine and then remembered there was a large bank note in your back pocket? When you rescued your trousers, did you find the note was whiter than white?

People who live in Britain needn't despair when they make mistakes like this (and a lot of people do)! Fortunately for them, the Bank of England has a team called Mutilated Ladies which deals with claims from people who fed their money to a machine or to their dog. Dogs, it seems, love to chew up money!

A recent case concerns Jane Butlin whose fiancé, John, runs a successful furniture business. John had a very good day and put his wallet containing £3,000 into the microwave oven for safekeeping. Then he and Jane went horse - riding. When they got home, Jane cooked their dinner in the microwave oven and without realizing it, cooked her fiancé's wallet as well. Imagine their dismay when they found a beautifully - cooked wallet and notes turned to ash! John went to see his bank manager who sent the remains of wallet and the money to the special department of the Bank of England in Newcastle: the Mutilated Ladies! They examined the remains and John got all his money back. 'So long as there's something to identify, we will give people their money back,' said a spokeswoman for the Bank. 'Last year, we paid out over £1.5m on 21,000 claims.'

8. A famous monastery

The Great St. Bernard Pass connects Switzerland to Italy. At 2,473 metres, it is the highest mountain pass in Europe. The famous monastery of St. Bernard, which was founded in the eleventh century, lies about a mile away. For hundreds of years, St. Bernard dogs have saved the lives of travellers crossing the dangerous Pass. These friendly dogs, which were first brought from Asia, were used as watch - dogs even in Roman times. Now that a tunnel has been built through the mountains, the Pass is less dangerous, but each year, the dogs are still sent out into the snow whenever a traveller is in difficulty. Despite the new tunnel, there are still a few people who rashly attempt to cross the Pass on foot.

During the summer months, the monastery is very busy, for it is visited by thousands of people who cross the Pass in cars. As there are so many people about, the dogs have to be kept in a special enclosure. In winter, however, life at the monastery is quite different. The temperature drops to - 30 and very few people attempt to cross the Pass. The monks prefer winter to summer for they have more privacy. The dogs have greater freedom, too, for they are allowed to wander outside their enclosure. The only regular visitors to the monastery in winter are parties of skiers who go there at Christmas and Easter. These young people, who love the peace of the mountains, always receive a warm welcome at St. Bernard's monastery.

9. Flying Cats

Cats never fail to fascinate human beings. They can be friendly and affectionate towards humans, but they lead mysterious lives of their own as well. They never become submissive in the way that dogs and horses do, and they seem to have a mysterious intelligence of their own.

Some cats are reputed to have remarkable powers of perception and are able to sense the approach of thunderstorms long before they break. This feline sensitivity to one of the principle forces of nature has been used to explain certain phenomena which otherwise remain inexplicable. For instance, a cat is said to instinctively know which room in a house contains its mistress without ever having entered it. In one instance which has been reported, a cat left his house, crossed several roads, climbed a fence, proceeded along the top of the fence, entered a neighbor's garden, and walked straight into their house to a room where the owner was sleeping, just in time to wake her up when a fire had just broken out. (There were some people who thought that this was all part of an elaborate plot!) There are also stories about cats who supposedly have the power to predict earthquakes. Japanese researchers have been able to make their own cats misbehave just by giving them a tiny electric shock: they have been trying to find out whether cats can really detect earthquakes early or whether it was a false alarm.

Most of us have seen cats rubbing their faces against the legs of the people they live with or curling up in their laps. They do this not only to be affectionate but also to mark out their territory. When cats are communicating with each other, they use a variety of different vocalizations as well as a whole range of body postures and facial expressions. They spit, hiss and growl when they are angry or frightened. They arch their backs and make their fur stand on end when they feel threatened. They purr when they are contented. The language of cats is still only partly understood by humans, but it is obvious that they have a complex system of communication.

Cats also have a very accurate sense of time. They know when it is time to get up, when it is time to go to bed, and when it is time to eat. They are also very good at finding their way home. Even if they are taken to a strange place many miles away, they are able to find their way back to their original home. This homing instinct, as it is called, is still not fully understood by scientists, but it is thought to be related to the cat's highly developed sense of smell and its ability to recognize certain landmarks.

Finally, cats are very good at taking care of themselves. They groom themselves

constantly, licking their fur clean and removing any dirt or parasites. They also keep their claws sharp by scratching on suitable surfaces. This self - care is important for their survival, because cats are solitary animals and they have to be able to look after themselves in the wild.

10. The Loss of the Titanic

The great ship, Titanic, sailed for New York from Southampton on April 10th, 1912. She was carrying 1,316 passengers and a crew of 891. Even by modern standards, the 46,000 ton Titanic was a colossal ship. At that time, however, she was not only the largest ship that had ever been built, but was regarded as unsinkable, for she had sixteen watertight compartments. Even if two of these were flooded, she would still be able to float. The tragic sinking of this great liner will always be remembered, for she went down on her first voyage with heavy loss of life.

Four days after setting out, while the Titanic was sailing across the icy waters of the North Atlantic, a huge iceberg was suddenly spotted by a lookout. After the alarm had been given, the great ship turned sharply to avoid a direct collision. The Titanic turned just in time, narrowly missing the immense wall of ice which rose over 100 feet out of the water beside her. Suddenly, there was a slight trembling sound from below, and the captain went down to see what had happened. The noise had been so faint that no one thought that the ship had been damaged. Below, the captain realized to his horror that the Titanic was sinking rapidly, for five of her sixteen watertight compartments had already been flooded! The order to abandon ship was given and hundreds of people plunged into the icy water. As there were not enough lifeboats for everybody, 1,500 lives were lost.

11. Not Guilty

Customs Officers are quite tolerant these days. They are paid to turn a blind eye to things. Only a few, like Sergeant Custard, earn their pay by being eagle - eyed. One such officer was Tim Smith, who controlled the southern frontier of the city. He had a reputation for being tough on smugglers. Every day he would see a lorry load of goods pass through his area and he was always suspicious. He often had a hunch that something was wrong, even when there was no evidence to support his feeling. One

day, he noticed a small van which was parked outside a large store. It was early in the morning and the van was unoccupied. Smith decided to keep an eye on it. As the day progressed, he saw people coming and going from the store, but no one went near the van. By lunchtime, Smith was really beginning to wonder what was going on. Then, just after lunch, a man came out of the store, walked over to the van and opened the back door. Smith immediately rushed over. 'What are you doing?' he demanded. 'I'm just making a delivery,' the man replied. 'Oh, really?' said Smith. 'Then why has this van been sitting here all morning with no one near it?' 'I don't know,' said the man. 'I'm just following my orders.' Smith was not convinced. He decided to search the van. He found nothing suspicious inside. Just as he was about to give up, he noticed a small compartment under the floor. He opened it and found a large quantity of cigarettes. 'What's this?' he asked the man. 'I - I don't know,' stammered the man. 'It's not mine.' 'Well, it's in your van,' said Smith. 'You're under arrest for smuggling.' 'But I'm not guilty,' protested the man. 'I didn't put those cigarettes there.' 'Then who did?' asked Smith. 'I don't know,' said the man. 'I'm just a delivery man.' Smith took the man to the police station. There, he was questioned further. But he still maintained his innocence. In the end, the police had to let him go. They had no evidence to prove that he was guilty. Smith was disappointed. He had been so sure that the man was a smuggler. But he had to admit that he had been wrong. He learned a valuable lesson that day: not to jump to conclusions.

12. Life on a Desert Island

Most of us have formed an unrealistic picture of life on a desert island. We sometimes imagine a desert island to be a sort of paradise where the sun always shines. Life there is simple and good. Ripe fruit falls from the trees and you never have to work. The other side of the picture is quite the opposite. Life on a desert island is wretched. You either starve to death or live like Robinson Crusoe, waiting for a boat which never comes. Perhaps there is an element of truth in both these pictures, but few of us have had the opportunity to find out. Two men who recently spent five days on a coral island wished they had stayed there longer. They were taking a badly damaged boat from the Virgin Islands to Miami to have it repaired. During the journey, their boat began to sink. They quickly loaded a small rubber dinghy with food, matches, and cans of beer and rowed for a few miles across the Caribbean until they arrived at a tiny coral island. There were hardly any trees on the island and there was no water, but this did not prove to be a problem. The men collected rain - water in the rubber dinghy. As they had brought a spear gun with

them, they had plenty of food. They caught lobster and fish every day, and, as one of them put it 'ate like kings'. When a passing tanker rescued them five days later, both men were genuinely sorry that they had to leave.

13. It's only me

After her husband had gone to work. Mrs. Richards sent her children to school and went upstairs to her bedroom. She was too excited to do any housework that morning, for in the evening she would be going to a fancy - dress party with her husband. She intended to dress up as a ghost and as she had made her costume the night before, she was impatient to try it on. Though the costume consisted only of a sheet, it was very effective. After putting it on, Mrs. Richards went downstairs. She wanted to find out whether it would be comfortable to wear.

Just as Mrs. Richards was entering the dining room, there was a knock on the front door. She knew that it must be the baker. She had told him to come straight in if ever she failed to open the door and to leave the bread on the kitchen table. Not wanting to frighten the poor man, Mrs. Richards quickly hid in the small storeroom under the stairs.

She heard the front door open and heavy footsteps in the hall. Suddenly the door of the storeroom was opened and a man entered. Mrs. Richards realized that it must be the baker. She coughed to draw his attention to her presence, but the man did not look up. Instead, he just stared at her, then he let out a cry and jumped back several feet. When Mrs. Richards walked towards him, he fled, slamming the door behind him.

Mrs. Richards was astonished. Then she smiled as she realized that the man was blind. He had come to read the meter.

14. A noble gangster

There was a time when the owners of shops and businesses in Chicago had to pay large sums of money to gangsters in return for 'protection'. If the money was not paid promptly, the gangsters would quickly put a man out of business by destroying his shop. Obtaining 'protection money' is not a modern crime. As long ago as the

fourteenth century, an Englishman, Sir John Hawkwood, made the remarkable discovery that people would rather pay large sums of money than have their life work destroyed by gangsters.

Six hundred years ago, Sir John Hawkwood arrived in Italy with a band of soldiers and settled near Florence. He soon made a name for himself and came to be known to the Italians as Giovanni Acuto. Whenever the Italian city - states were at war with each other, Hawkwood used to hire his soldiers to princes who were willing to pay the high price he demanded. In times of peace, when business was bad, Hawkwood and his men would march into a city - state and, after burning down a few farms, would offer to go away if protection money was paid to them. Hawkwood made large sums of money in this way. In spite of this, the Italians regarded him as a sort of hero. When he died at the age of eighty, the Florentines gave him a state funeral and had a picture painted which was dedicated to the memory of 'the most valiant soldier and most notable leader, Signor Giovanni Acuto'.

15. Fifty pence worth of trouble

Children always appreciate small gifts of money. Father, of course, provides a regular supply of pocket-money, but uncles and aunts are always a source of extra income. With some children, small sums go a long way. If sixpences are not exchanged for sweets, they rattle for months inside money-boxes. Only very thrifty children manage to fill up a money - box. For most of them, sixpence is a small price to pay for a satisfying bar of chocolate.

My nephew, George, has a money-box but it is always empty. Very few of the sixpences I have given him have found their way there. I gave him sixpence yesterday and advised him to save it. Instead, he bought himself sixpence worth of trouble.

On his way to the sweet - shop, he dropped his sixpence and it rolled along the pavement and then disappeared down a drain.

George took off his jacket, rolled up his sleeves and pushed his right arm through the drain cover. He could not find his sixpence anywhere, and what is more, he could not get his arm out. A crowd of people gathered round him and a lady rubbed his arm with soap and butter, but George was firmly stuck.

The fire - brigade was called and two firemen freed George using a special type of

grease. George was not too upset by his experience because the lady who owns the sweet shop heard about his troubles and rewarded him with a large box of chocolates.

16. Mary had a Little Lamb

Mary and her husband Dimitri lived in the tiny village of Perachora in southern Greece. One of Mary's prize possessions was a little white lamb which her husband had given her. She kept it tied to a tree in a field during the day and went to fetch it every evening. One evening, however, the lamb was missing. The rope had been cut, so it was obvious that the lamb had been stolen.

When Dimitri came in from the fields, his wife told him what had happened. Dimitri at once set out to find the thief. He knew it would not prove difficult in such a small village. After telling several of his friends about the theft, Dimitri found out that his neighbour, Aleko, had suddenly acquired a new lamb. Dimitri immediately went to Aleko's house and angrily accused him of stealing the lamb. He told him he had better return it or he would call the police. Aleko denied taking it and led Dimitri into his backyard. It was true that he had just bought a lamb, he explained, but his lamb was black. Ashamed of having acted so rashly, Dimitri apologized to Aleko for having accused him. While they were talking it began to rain and Dimitri stayed in Aleko's house until the rain stopped. When he went outside half an hour later, he was astonished to find that the little black lamb was almost white. Its wool, which had been dyed black, had been washed clean by the rain!

17. The longest suspension bridge in the world

Verrazano, an Italian about whom little is known, sailed into New York Harbour in 1524 and named it Angouleme. He described it as 'a very agreeable situation located within two small hills in the midst of which flowed a great river.' Though Verrazano is by no means considered to be a great explorer, his name will probably remain immortal, for on November 21st, 1964, the longest suspension bridge in the world was named after him.

The Verrazano Bridge, which was designed by Othmar Ammann, joins Brooklyn to Staten Island. It has a span of 4,260 feet. The bridge is so long that the shape of the

earth had to be taken into account by its designer. Two great towers support four huge cables. The towers are built on immense underwater platforms made of steel and concrete. The platforms extend to a depth of over 100 feet under the sea. These alone took sixteen months to build. Above the surface of the water, the towers rise to a height of nearly 700 feet. They support the cables from which the bridge has been suspended. Each of the four cables contains 26,108 lengths of wire. It has been estimated that if the bridge were packed with cars, it would still only be carrying a third of its total capacity. However, size and strength are not the only important things about this bridge. Despite its immensity, it is both simple and elegant, fulfilling its designer's dream to create 'an enormous object drawn as faintly as possible'.

18. Electric Currents in Modern Art

Modern sculpture rarely surprises us any more. The idea that modern art can only be seen in museums is mistaken. Even people who take no interest in art cannot have failed to notice examples of modern sculpture on display in public places. Strange forms stand in gardens, and outside buildings and shops. We have got quite used to them. Some so - called 'modern' pieces have been on display for nearly eighty years.

In spite of this, some people - including myself - were surprised by a recent exhibition of modern sculpture. The first thing I saw when I entered the art gallery was a notice which said: 'Do not touch the exhibits. Some of them are dangerous!' The objects on display were pieces of moving sculpture. Oddly shaped forms that are suspended from the ceiling and move in response to a gust of wind are quite familiar to everybody. These objects, however, were different. Lined up against the wall, there were long thin wires attached to metal spheres. The spheres had been magnetized and attracted or repelled each other all the time. In the centre of the hall, there were a number of tall structures which contained coloured lights. These lights flickered continuously like traffic lights which have gone mad. Sparks were emitted from small black boxes and red lamps flashed on and off angrily. It was rather like an exhibition of pre - historic electronic equipment. These peculiar forms not only seemed designed to shock people emotionally, but to give them electric shocks as well!

I soon learnt about all the tricks of the trade. Early in the morning, we were told, there is a large pool of water in the centre of the hall which reflects the sculptures. This, apparently, is to give the illusion that the sculptures are floating in mid - air.

Next to the pool there is a deep pit with a ladder, so that visitors can descend into it and experience these curious sculptures more fully. There is also an art gallery in the pit, which displays some modern paintings. The paintings look so real that they seem to be floating on the wall. I was so intrigued by these works of art that I decided to buy a catalogue. As I was leaving, I noticed that all the visitors were given a small electric shock as they passed through the turnstile. It was a most unusual exhibition.

19. A Very Dear Cat

Kidnappers are rarely interested in animals, but they recently took considerable interest in Mrs. Eleanor Ramsay's cat. Mrs. Eleanor Ramsay, a very wealthy old lady, has shared a flat with her cat, Rastus, for a great many years. Rastus leads an orderly life. He usually takes a short walk in the evenings and is always home by seven o'clock. One evening, however, he failed to arrive. Mrs. Ramsay got very worried. She looked everywhere for him but could not find him.

Three days after Rastus' disappearance, Mrs. Ramsay received an anonymous letter. The writer stated that Rastus was in safe hands and would be returned immediately if Mrs. Ramsay paid a ransom of £1,000. Mrs. Ramsay was instructed to place the money in a cardboard box and to leave it outside her door. At first, she decided to go to the police, but fearing that she would never see Rastus again - the letter had made that quite clear - she changed her mind. She drew £1,000 from her bank and followed the kidnapper's instructions. The next morning, the box had disappeared but Mrs. Ramsay was sure that the kidnapper would keep his word. Sure enough, Rastus arrived punctually at seven o'clock that evening. He looked very well, though he was rather thirsty, for he drank half a bottle of milk. The police were astounded when Mrs. Ramsay told them what she had done. She explained that Rastus was very dear to her. Considering the amount she paid, he was dear in more ways than one!

20. Pioneer Pilots

In 1908 Lord Northcliffe offered a prize of £1,000 to the first man who would fly across the English Channel.

Over a year passed before the first attempt was made.

On July 19th, 1909, in the early morning, Hubert Latham took off from the French coast in his plane the 'Antoinette IV'.

He had travelled only seven miles across the Channel when his engine failed and he was forced to land on the sea.

The 'Antoinette' floated on the water until Latham was picked up by a ship.

Two days later, Louis Bleriot arrived near Calais with a plane called 'No. XI'.

Bleriot had been making planes since 1905 and this was his latest model.

A week before, he had completed a successful overland flight during which he covered twenty - six miles.

Latham, however, did not give up easily.

He, too, arrived near Calais on the same day with a new 'Antoinette'.

It looked as if there would be an exciting race across the Channel.

Both planes were going to take off on July 25th, but Latham failed to get up early enough.

After making a short test flight at 4.15 a.m., Bleriot set off half an hour later.

His great flight lasted thirty - seven minutes.

When he landed near Dover, the first person to greet him was a local policeman.

Latham made another attempt a week later and got within half a mile of Dover, but he was unlucky again.

His engine failed and he landed on the sea for the second time.

21. Daniel Mendoza

Boxing matches were very popular in England two hundred years ago. In those days, boxers fought with bare fists for prize money. Because of this, they were known as 'prize - fighters'. However, boxing was very crude, for there were no rules and a prize - fighter could be seriously injured or even killed during a match.

One of the most colourful figures in boxing history was Daniel Mendoza, who was born in 1764. The use of gloves was not introduced until 1860, when the Marquis of Queensberry drew up the first set of rules. Though he was technically a prize - fighter, Mendoza did much to change crude prize - fighting into a sport, for he brought science to the game. In his day, Mendoza enjoyed tremendous popularity. He was adored by rich and poor alike.

Mendoza rose to fame swiftly after a boxing - match when he was only fourteen years old. This attracted the attention of Richard Humphries who was then the most eminent boxer in England. He offered to train Mendoza and his young pupil was quick to learn. In fact, Mendoza soon became so successful that Humphries turned against him. The two men quarrelled bitterly and it was clear that the argument could only be settled by a fight. A match was held at Stilton, where both men fought for an hour. The public bet a great deal of money on Mendoza, but he was defeated. Mendoza met Humphries in the ring on a later occasion and he lost for a second time.

It was not until his third match in 1790 that he finally beat Humphries and became Champion of England. Meanwhile, he founded a highly successful Academy and even Lord Byron became one of his pupils. He earned enormous sums of money and was paid as much as 100 pounds for a single appearance. Despite this, he was so extravagant that he was always in debt. After he was defeated by a boxer called Gentleman Jackson, he was quickly forgotten. He was sent to prison for failing to pay his debts and died in poverty in 1836.

22. By Heart

Some plays are so successful that they run for years on end. In many ways, this is unfortunate for the poor actors who are required to go on repeating the same lines night after night. One would expect them to know their parts by heart and never have cause to falter. Yet this is not always the case.

A famous actor in a highly successful play was once cast in the role of an aristocrat who had been imprisoned in the Bastille for twenty years. In the last act, a gaoler would always come on to the stage with a letter which he would hand to the prisoner. Even though the noble was expected to read the letter at each performance, he always insisted that it should be written out in full.

One night, the gaoler decided to play a joke on his colleague to find out if, after so many performances, he had managed to learn the contents of the letter by heart. The curtain went up on the final act of the play and revealed the aristocrat sitting alone behind bars in his dark cell. Just then, the gaoler appeared with the precious letter in his hands. He entered the cell and presented the letter to the aristocrat. But the copy he gave him had not been written out in full as usual. It was simply a blank sheet of paper. The gaoler looked on eagerly, anxious to see if his fellow - actor had at last learnt his lines. The noble stared at the blank sheet of paper for a few seconds. Then, squinting his eyes, he said: 'The light is dim. Read the letter to me.' And he promptly handed the sheet of paper back to the gaoler. Finding that he could not remember a word of the letter either, the gaoler replied: 'The light is indeed dim, sire. I must get my glasses.' With this, he hurried off the stage. Much to the aristocrat's amusement, the gaoler returned a few moments later with a pair of glasses and the usual copy of the letter which he proceeded to read to the prisoner.

23. One Man's Meat is Another Man's Poison

People become quite illogical when they try to decide what can be eaten and what cannot be eaten. If you lived in the Mediterranean, for instance, you would consider octopus a great delicacy. You would not be able to understand why some people find it repulsive. On the other hand, your stomach would turn at the idea of frying potatoes in animal fat -- the normally accepted practice in many northern countries. The sad truth is that most of us have been brought up to eat certain foods and we stick to them all our lives.

No creature has received more praise and abuse than the common garden snail. Cooked in wine, snails are a great luxury in various parts of the world. There are countless people who, ever since their early years, have learned to associate snails with food. My friend, Robert, lives in a country where snails are despised. As his flat is in a large town, he has no garden of his own. For years he has been asking me to collect snails from my garden and take them to him.

The idea never appealed to me very much, but one day, after a heavy shower, I happened to be walking in my garden when I noticed a huge number of snails taking a stroll on some of my prize plants. Acting on impulse, I collected several dozen, put them in a paper bag, and took them to Robert. Robert was delighted to see me and equally pleased with my little gift. I left the bag in the hall and Robert and I went into the living room where we talked for a couple of hours. I had forgotten all about the snails when Robert suddenly said that I must stay to dinner. Snails would, of course, be the main dish. I did not fancy the idea and I reluctantly followed Robert out of the living room. To my dismay, I saw that there were snails everywhere: they had escaped from the paper bag and had taken complete possession of the hall! I have never been able to look at a snail since then.

24. A skeleton in the cupboard

We often read in novels how a seemingly respectable person or family has some terrible secret which has been concealed from strangers for years. The English language possesses a vivid saying to describe this sort of situation. The terrible secret is called 'a skeleton in the cupboard'. At some dramatic moment in the story, the terrible secret becomes known and a reputation is ruined. The reader's hair stands on end when he reads in the final pages of the novel that the heroine, a dear old lady who had always been so kind to everybody, had, in her youth, poisoned every one of her five husbands.

It is all very well for such things to occur in fiction. To varying degrees, we all have secrets which we do not want even our closest friends to learn, but few of us have skeletons in the cupboard. The only person I know who has a skeleton in the cupboard is George Carlton, and he is very proud of the fact. George studied medicine in his youth. Instead of becoming a doctor, however, he became a successful writer of detective stories. I once spent an uncomfortable weekend which I shall never forget at his house. George showed me to the guestroom which, he said, was very quiet, but I was horrified to find that it looked out onto a cemetery.

'Oh, that's all right,' George said when I told him how I felt. 'I don't mind the view at all.' That was the start of an uncomfortable weekend. The first night, I had scarcely closed my eyes when a strange little man appeared at my bedside. 'I'm sorry to disturb you,' he said, 'but I think there is something wrong with my stomach.' I was in no mood to pass a pleasantry with him, so I simply stared at him until he went away. The next morning I got up early. I had a good breakfast and a pleasant

morning stroll. After lunch, I settled down to read in the garden, but the book I was reading could not hold my attention. Every few minutes I raised my head to look at the view. It was not a pleasant view. I decided to go for a walk. I had not gone far when I saw a figure in the distance. I recognized George. He was walking slowly towards me. When he came near, I noticed that he looked very pale. 'I'm sorry to have troubled you last night,' he said. 'I had a bad night myself. I thought I heard something moving in the cupboard. It was probably a mouse, but it sounded like a skeleton. I'm not used to having skeletons in the cupboard, you know.'

25. The Cutty Sark

One of the most famous sailing ships of the nineteenth century, the Cutty Sark, can still be seen at Greenwich. She stands on dry land and is visited by thousands of people each year. She serves as an impressive reminder of the great ships of the past. Before they were replaced by steam-ships, sailing vessels like the Cutty Sark were used to carry tea from China and wool from Australia. The Cutty Sark was one of the fastest sailing ships that has ever been built. The only other ship to match her was the Thermopylae. Both these ships set out from Shanghai on June 18th, 1872 on an exciting race to England. This race, which went on for exactly four months, was the last of its kind. It marked the end of the great tradition of ships with sails and the beginning of a new era. The first of the two ships to reach Java after the race had begun was the Thermopylae, but on the Indian Ocean, the Cutty Sark took the lead. It seemed certain that she would be the first ship home, but during the race she had a lot of bad luck. In August, she was struck by a very heavy storm during which her rudder was torn away. The Cutty Sark rolled from side to side and it became impossible to steer her. A temporary rudder was made on board from spare planks and it was fitted with great difficulty. This greatly reduced the speed of the ship, for there was a danger that if she travelled too quickly, this rudder would be torn away as well. Because of this, the Cutty Sark lost her lead. After crossing the Equator, the captain called in at a port to have a new rudder fitted, but by now the Thermopylae was over five hundred miles ahead. Though the new rudder was fitted at tremendous speed, it was impossible for the Cutty Sark to win. She arrived in England a week after the Thermopylae. Even this was remarkable, considering that she had had so many delays. There is no doubt that if she had not lost her rudder she would have won the race easily.

After she had been retired, she was put on display in Greenwich in 1954. A great

deal of work was done to restore her, and she is now in perfect condition. Even though she was never actually sailed, the Cutty Sark remains one of the most famous ships of all time.

26. Wanted: a large biscuit tin

No one can avoid being influenced by advertisements. Much as we may pride ourselves on our good taste, we are no longer free to choose the things we want, for advertising exerts a subtle influence on us. In their efforts to persuade us to buy this or that product, advertisers have made a close study of human nature and have classified all our little weaknesses.

Advertisers discovered years ago that all of us love to get something for nothing. An advertisement which begins with the magic word FREE can rarely go wrong. These days, advertisers not only offer free samples, but free cars, free houses, and free trips round the world as well. They devise hundreds of competitions which will enable us to win huge sums of money. Radio and television have made it possible for advertisers to capture the attention of millions of people in this way.

During a radio programme, a company of biscuit manufacturers once asked listeners to bake biscuits and send them to their factory. They offered to pay \$10 a pound for the biggest biscuit baked by a listener. The response to this competition was tremendous. Before long, biscuits of all shapes and sizes began arriving at the factory. One lady brought in a biscuit on a wheelbarrow. It weighed nearly 500 pounds. A little later, a man came along with a biscuit which occupied the whole of his car boot. All the biscuits that were sent were carefully weighed. The largest was 713 pounds. It seemed certain that this would win the prize. But just before the competition closed, a lorry arrived at the factory with a truly colossal biscuit which weighed 2,400 pounds. It had been baked by a college student who had used over 1,000 pounds of flour, 800 pounds of sugar, 200 pounds of fat, and 400 pounds of various other ingredients. It was so large that the lorry that carried it could barely move. The manufacturers had to pay more than they had anticipated, for they bought the biscuit from the student for \$24,000.

27. Nothing to Sell and Nothing to Buy

It has been said that everyone lives by selling something. In the light of this statement, teachers live by selling knowledge, philosophers by selling wisdom and priests by selling spiritual comfort. Though it may be possible to measure the value of material goods in terms of money, it is extremely difficult to estimate the true value of the services which people perform for us. There are times when we would willingly give everything we possess to save our lives, yet we might grudge paying a surgeon a high fee for offering us precisely this service. The conditions of society are such that skills have to be paid for in the same way that goods are paid for at a shop. Everyone has something to sell.

Tramps seem to be the only exception to this general rule. Beggars almost sell themselves as human beings to arouse the pity of passers - by. But real tramps are not beggars. They have nothing to sell and require nothing from others. In seeking independence, they do not sacrifice their human dignity. A tramp may ask you for money, but he will never ask you to feel sorry for him. He has deliberately chosen to lead the life he leads and is fully aware of the consequences. He may never be sure where the next meal is coming from, but he is free from the thousands of anxieties which afflict other people. His few material possessions make it possible for him to move from place to place with ease. By having to sleep in the open, he gets far closer to the world of nature than most of us ever do. He may hunt, beg, or steal occasionally to keep himself alive; he may even, in times of real need, do a little work; but he will never sacrifice his freedom. We often speak of tramps with contempt and put them in the same class as beggars, but how many of us can honestly say that we have not felt a little envious of their simple way of life and their freedom from care?

28. Five pounds too dear

Small boats loaded with wares sped to the great liner as she was entering the harbour. Before she had anchored, the men from the boats had climbed on board and the decks were soon covered with colourful rugs from Persia, silks from India, copper coffee pots, and beautiful handmade silverware. It was difficult not to be tempted.

Many of the tourists on board had begun bargaining with the tradesmen, but I decided not to buy anything until I had disembarked. I had no sooner got off the ship

than I was assailed by a man who wanted to sell me a diamond ring. I had no intention of buying one, but I could not conceal the fact that I was impressed by the size of the diamonds. Some of them were as big as marbles. The man went to great lengths to prove that the diamonds were real. As we were walking past a shop, he held a diamond firmly against the window and made a deep impression in the glass. It took me over half an hour to get rid of him.

The next man to approach me was selling expensive pens and watches. I examined one of the pens closely. It certainly looked genuine. At the base of the gold cap, the words 'made in the U.S.A.' had been neatly inscribed. The man said that the pen was worth £50, but as a special favour, he would let me have it for £30. I shook my head and held up a finger indicating that I was willing to pay a pound. Gesticulating wildly, the man acted as if he found my offer outrageous, but he eventually reduced the price to £10. Shrugging my shoulders, I began to walk away when, a moment later, he ran after me and thrust the pen into my hands. Though he kept throwing up his arms in despair, he readily accepted the pound I gave him. I felt especially pleased with my wonderful bargain--until I got back to the ship. No matter how hard I tried, I could not fill this beautiful pen with ink and it was only when I got off the plane that I realised that I had been tricked by the man. The pen was worthless; it was not even made of gold.

29. Funny or not

The sense of humour is mysteriously bound up with national characteristics. For instance, the French word for "funny" hardly has the same meaning as the English equivalent. If you ask a Frenchman whether the English have a sense of humour, he will probably answer, "Yes, but it's rather peculiar." You can find the same thing in other countries. Each nation has its own ideas of what is funny, and what is in bad taste.

In general, the English and the Americans do not laugh at the same things. The English, for example, do not laugh at the same kind of humour as the Americans. The things which make an Englishman laugh are not always the things which make an American laugh, and vice versa. The fact that they laugh at different things may well make it difficult for a foreigner to understand what is really funny in either country.

Most funny stories are based on comic situations. In spite of national differences,

certain funny situations have a universal appeal. No matter where you live, you would find it difficult not to laugh at, say, Charlie Chaplin's early films. However, a new type of humour, which stems from America, has recently come into fashion. It is called "sick humour". Comedians base their jokes on tragic situations like violent death or serious accidents. Many people find this sort of joke distasteful. The following example of "sick humour" will enable you to judge for yourself.

A man who had broken his right leg was taken to hospital a few weeks before Christmas. From the moment he arrived there, he kept on pestering his doctor to tell him when he would be able to go home. He dreaded having to spend Christmas in hospital. Though the doctor did his best, the patient's recovery was slow. On Christmas day, the man still had his right leg in plaster.

He spent a miserable day in bed thinking of all the fun he was missing. The following day, his mood was better. He was able to sit up in bed and look out of the window. He saw a man being taken into the hospital on a stretcher. As the man was being carried past the window, he caught sight of his neighbour's face. He was horrified to see that his neighbour had his right leg in plaster too. He called out to the man on the stretcher, "I say, what happened to you?" The man on the stretcher groaned and said, "I broke my left leg."

30. The death of a ghost

For years villagers believed that Endley Farm was haunted. The farm was owned by two brothers, Joe and Bob Cox. They employed a few farm hands, but no one was willing to work there long. Every time a worker gave up his job, he told the same story. Farm labourers said that they always woke up to find the work had been done overnight. Hay had been cut and cowsheds had been cleaned. A farm worker, who stayed up all night, claimed to have seen a figure cutting corn in the moonlight. In time, it became an accepted fact that the Cox brothers employed a conscientious ghost that did most of their work for them.

No one suspected that there might be someone else on the farm who had never been seen. This was indeed the case. A short time ago, villagers were astonished to learn that the ghost of Endley had died. Everyone went to the funeral, for the 'ghost' was none other than Eric Cox, a third brother who was supposed to have died as a young man. After the funeral, Joe and Bob revealed a secret which they had kept for over fifty years.

Eric had been the eldest son of the family, very much older than his two brothers. He had been obliged to join the army during the Second World War. As he hated army life, he decided to desert his regiment. When he learnt that he would be sent abroad, he returned to the farm and his father hid him until the end of the war. Fearing the authorities, Eric remained in hiding after the war as well. His father told everybody that Eric had been killed in action. The only other people who knew the secret were Joe and Bob. They did not even tell their wives. When their father died, they thought it their duty to keep Eric in hiding. All these years, Eric had lived as a recluse. He used to sleep during the day and work at night, quite unaware of the fact that he had become the ghost of Endley. When he died, however, his brothers found it impossible to keep the secret any longer.

31. A Lovable Eccentric

True eccentrics never deliberately set out to draw attention to themselves. They disregard social conventions without being conscious that they are doing anything extraordinary. This invariably wins them the love and respect of others, for they add colour to the dull routine of everyday life.

Up to the time of his death, Richard Colson was one of the most notable figures in our town. He was a shrewd and wealthy business - man, but most people in the town hardly knew anything about this side of his life. He was known to us all as Dickie and his eccentricity had become legendary long before he died.

Dickie disliked snobs intensely. Though he owned a large car, he hardly ever used it, preferring always to go on foot. Even when it was raining heavily, he refused to carry an umbrella. One day, he walked into an expensive shop after having been caught in a particularly heavy shower. He wanted to buy a \$300 watch for his wife, but he was in such a bedraggled state that an assistant refused to serve him. Dickie left the shop without a word and returned carrying a large cloth bag. As it was extremely heavy, he dumped it on the counter. The assistant asked him to leave, but Dickie paid no attention to him and requested to see the manager. Recognizing who the customer was, the manager was most apologetic and 'rushed' Dickie into the back room. Dickie took out a thick roll of \$100 bills and started peeling them off one at a time onto the counter. On seeing this, the manager hastened to add the watch to Dickie's bill and then apologized for having been so rude before. Dickie, however, had his own way of doing things. He calmly picked up the watch, put his money back into the bag and left the shop without a word.

The following day, the manager of the shop sent his assistant to Dickie's house with a letter. In the letter, he apologized for his rudeness and begged Dickie to come back to the shop. Dickie accepted the apology and later became a regular customer of the shop.

32. A lost ship

The salvage operation had been a complete failure. The small ship, Elkor, which had been searching the Barents Sea for weeks, was on its way home. A radio message from the mainland had been received by the ship's captain instructing him to give up the search. The captain knew that another attempt would be made later, for the sunken ship he was trying to find had been carrying a precious cargo of gold bullion.

Nevertheless, he was still unwilling to leave the area. 'I'll give it another day or two,' he said to his officers. 'We may as well start looking again. There's still a faint chance that we may find it. It's true that we've been unlucky so far, but we mustn't give up hope.'

Just as the captain was speaking, a large fish, which was almost as long as the ship itself, swam swiftly under the ship and struck it with great force. The ship shook violently and there was a loud explosion. Water flooded into the engine room and the ship sank quickly, with all hands. The captain and his officers were not the only victims. Many of the crew also lost their lives. The few survivors swam as far as they could from the sinking ship until they were picked up by a passing ship.

The Elkor's captain and his officers were taken to a nearby port. From there, they were flown back to their own country. A court of inquiry was held. The captain was blamed for the loss of the ship and for the deaths of the crew. He was found guilty and was sentenced to ten years' imprisonment. The ship's owners were also held responsible for the accident. They were ordered to pay a large sum of money in compensation.

The Elkor was a small ship, but it was carrying a very valuable cargo. It was not surprising that the search for it had been so difficult. The Barents Sea is a very large and stormy area. The ship had been missing for weeks before the Elkor started its search. It had been sailing in a remote part of the sea when it disappeared. There had been no sign of a struggle or of any damage to the ship before it sank. It was as if the ship had simply vanished into thin air.

The Elkor's search had been thorough. The ship had covered a large area of the sea. It had used the latest equipment. The captain had been experienced and determined. But in spite of all these things, the search had been a failure. It was a sad end to a long and difficult search.

33. A day to remember

We have all experienced days when everything goes wrong. A day may begin well enough, but suddenly everything seems to get out of control. What invariably happens is that a great number of things choose to go wrong at precisely the same moment. It is as if a single unimportant event set up a chain of reactions. Let us suppose that you are preparing a meal and keeping an eye on the baby at the same time. The telephone rings and this marks the prelude to an unforeseen series of catastrophes. While you are on the phone, the baby pulls the table - cloth off the table, smashing half your best crockery and cutting himself in the process. You hang up hurriedly and attend to baby, crockery, etc. Meanwhile, the meal gets burnt. As if this were not enough to reduce you to tears, your husband arrives, unexpectedly bringing three guests to dinner. Things can go wrong on a big scale, as a number of people recently discovered in Parramatta, a suburb of Sydney. During the rush hour one evening two cars collided and both drivers began to argue. The woman immediately behind the two cars happened to be a learner. She suddenly got into a panic and stopped her car. This made the driver following her brake hard. His wife was sitting beside him holding a large cake. As she was thrown forward, the cake went right through the windscreen and landed on the road. Seeing a cake flying through the air, a lorry - driver who was drawing up alongside the car, pulled up all of a sudden. The lorry was loaded with empty beer bottles and hundreds of them slid off the back of the lorry and on to the road. This led to yet another angry argument. Meanwhile, the traffic piled up behind. It took the police nearly an hour to get the traffic on the move again. In the meantime, the lorry - driver had to sweep up hundreds of broken bottles. Only two stray dogs benefited from all this confusion, for they greedily devoured the remains of the cake. It was just one of those days!

34. A Happy Discovery

Antique shops exert a peculiar fascination on a great many people. The more expensive kind of antique shop where rare objects are beautifully displayed in glass cases to keep them free from dust is usually a forbidding place. But no one has to muster up courage to enter a less pretentious antique shop. There is always hope that in its labyrinth of musty, dark, disordered rooms a real rarity will be found amongst the piles of assorted junk that litter the floors.

No one discovers a rarity by chance. A truly dedicated bargain hunter must have patience, and above all, the ability to recognize the worth of something when he sees it. To do this, he must be at least as knowledgeable as the dealer. Like a scientist bent on making a discovery, he must cherish the hope that one day he will be amply rewarded.

My old friend, Frank Halliday, is just such a person. He has often described to me how he picked up a masterpiece for a mere £5. One Saturday morning, Frank visited an antique shop in my neighbourhood. As he had never been there before, he found a great deal to interest him. The morning passed rapidly and Frank was about to leave when he noticed a large packing - case lying on the floor. The dealer told him that it had just come in, but that he could not be bothered to open it. Frank begged him to do so and the dealer reluctantly prised it open.

The contents were disappointing. Apart from an interesting - looking carved dagger, the box was full of crockery, much of it broken. Frank gently lifted the crockery out of the box and suddenly noticed a miniature painting at the bottom of the box. As its composition and line reminded him of an Italian painting he knew well, he decided to buy it. Glancing at it briefly, the dealer told him that it was worth £5. Frank could hardly conceal his excitement, for he knew that he had made a real discovery. The tiny painting proved to be an unknown masterpiece by Correggio and was worth hundreds of thousands of pounds.

35. Justice was done

The word justice is usually associated with courts of law. We might say that justice has been done when a man's innocence or guilt has been proved beyond doubt. Justice is part of the complex machinery of the law. Those who seek it, undertake an arduous journey and can never be sure that they will find it. Judges, however wise or

eminent, are human and can make mistakes.

There are rare instances when justice almost ceases to be an abstract conception. Reward or punishment are meted out quite independent of human interference. At such times, justice acts like a living force. When we use a phrase like it serves him right, we are, in part, admitting that a certain set of circumstances has enabled justice to act of its own accord.

When a thief was caught on the premises of a large jewellery store one morning, the shop assistants must have found it impossible to resist the temptation to say 'it serves him right'. The shop was an old - fashioned one with many large, disused fireplaces and tall, narrow chimneys. Towards midday, a girl heard a muffled cry coming from behind one of the walls. As the cry was repeated several times, she ran to tell the manager who promptly rang up the fire brigade. The cry had certainly come from one of the chimneys, but as there were so many of them, the fire - fighters could not be certain which one it was. They located the right chimney by tapping at the walls and listening for the man's cries. After chipping through a wall which was eighteen inches thick, they found that a man had been trapped in the chimney. As it was extremely narrow, the man was unable to move, but the firemen were eventually able to free him by cutting a huge hole in the wall. The sorry - looking, blackened figure that emerged, at once admitted that he had tried to break into the shop during the night but had got stuck in the chimney. He had been there for nearly ten hours. Justice had been done even before the man was handed over to the police.

36. A Chance in a Million

We are less credulous than we used to be. In the nineteenth century, a novelist would bring his story to a conclusion by presenting his readers with a series of coincidences - most of them wildly improbable. Readers happily accepted the fact that an obscure maidservant was really the hero's mother. A long - lost brother, who was presumed dead, was really alive all the time and wickedly plotting to bring about the hero's downfall. And so on. Modern readers would find such naive solutions totally unacceptable. Yet, in real life, circumstances do sometimes conspire to bring about coincidences which anyone but a nineteenth century novelist would find incredible.

A German taxi - driver, Franz Bussman, recently found a brother who was thought to have been killed twenty years before. While on a walking tour with his wife, he

stopped to talk to a workman. After they had gone on, Mrs. Bussman commented on the workman's close resemblance to her husband and even suggested that he might be his brother. Franz poured scorn on the idea, pointing out that his brother had been killed in action during the war. Though Mrs. Bussman was fully acquainted with this story, she thought that there was a chance in a million that she might be right. A few days later, she sent a boy to the workman to ask him if his name was Hans Bussman. Needless to say, the man's name was Hans Bussman and he really was Franz's long - lost brother.

When the brothers were reunited, Hans explained how it was that he was still alive. After having been wounded towards the end of the war, he had been sent to hospital and was separated from his unit. The hospital had been bombed and Hans had made his way back into Western Germany on foot. Meanwhile, his unit was lost and all records of him had been destroyed. Hans returned to his family home, but the house had been bombed and no one in the family was alive. Assuming that his family had been killed during the air - raid, Hans settled down in a village fifty miles away where he had remained ever since.

37. The Westhaven Express

We have learnt to expect that trains will be punctual. After years of conditioning, most of us have developed an unshakable faith in railway timetables. Ships may be delayed by storms; flights may be cancelled because of bad weather, but trains must be on time. Only an exceptionally heavy snowfall might temporarily dislocate railway services. It is all too easy to blame the railway authorities when something does go wrong. The truth is that when mistakes occur, they are more likely to be ours than theirs.

After consulting my railway timetable, I noted with satisfaction that there was an express train to Westhaven. It went direct from my local station and the journey lasted a mere hour and seventeen minutes. When I boarded the train, I could not help noticing that a great many local people got on as well. At the time, this did not strike me as odd. I reflected that there must be a great many people besides myself who wished to take advantage of this excellent service. Neither was I surprised when the train stopped at Widley, a tiny station a few miles along the line. Even a mighty express train can be held up by signals. But when the train dawdled at station after station, I began to wonder. It suddenly dawned on me that this express was not roaring down the line at ninety miles an hour, but barely chugging along at thirty.

One hour and seventeen minutes passed and we had not even covered half the distance. I asked a passenger if this was the Westhaven express, but he had not even heard of it.

I determined to lodge a complaint as soon as we arrived. Two hours later, I was talking angrily to the station master at Westhaven. When I told him that the train was not moving at all, he apologized for the inconvenience. Then he said something which made me think that perhaps this was not his fault after all. 'You see, sir,' he said, 'this isn't the Westhaven express. It's the slow train to Sandy Bay.' He pointed to the right. 'You should have caught the train over there two hours ago.'

38. The first calendar

Future historians will be in a unique position when they come to record the history of our own times. They will hardly know which facts to select from the great mass of evidence that steadily accumulates. What is more, they will not have to rely solely on the written word. Films, videos, CDs and CD-ROMs are just some of the bewildering amount of information they will have. They will be able, as it were, to see and hear us in action. But the historian attempting to reconstruct the distant past is always faced with a difficult task. He has to deduce what he can from the few scanty clues available. Even seemingly insignificant remains can shed interesting light on the history of early man.

Up to now, historians have assumed that calendars came into being with the advent of agriculture, for then man was faced with a real need to understand something about the seasons. Recent scientific evidence seems to indicate that this assumption is incorrect.

Historians have long been puzzled by dots, lines and symbols which have been engraved on walls, bones, and the ivory tusks of mammoths. The nomads who made these markings lived by hunting and fishing during the last Ice Age which began about 35,000 B.C. and ended about 10,000 B.C. By correlating markings made in various parts of the world, historians have been able to read this difficult code. They have found that it is connected with the passage of days and the phases of the moon. It is, in fact, a primitive type of calendar. It has long been known that the hunting scenes depicted on walls were not simply a form of artistic expression. They had a definite function, for they were as much a part of the ritual of hunting as the killing of the prey itself. This ritual was necessary to calm the gods who controlled the

animals. Hunters and fishermen, in particular, were extremely superstitious. Thus, they engraved on the bones of the prey animals the signs of the moon which they had observed. The nomads who made these markings saw the moon as a major influence on their lives. They knew that it would affect the growth of plants and the migration of animals. They were convinced that it was the moon which caused the tides. They noted the phases of the moon in order to predict the times of high and low tides. They made these markings on the bones of the prey animals for two reasons. First, they wanted to record the number of kills they had made. Second, they wanted to mark the passage of days and the phases of the moon.

The ancient hunters' calendar was different from the calendars we use today. For one thing, it was not based on the movement of the sun. It was based on the movement of the moon. For another, it was not a written calendar. It was an engraved calendar. But it was a calendar just the same. It was a means of recording the passage of days and the phases of the moon. It was a way of predicting the times of high and low tides. It was a tool for hunters and fishermen. It was a form of art. It was a form of religious expression. It was a part of the ritual of hunting.

39. Nothing to worry about

The rough road across the plain soon became so bad that we tried to get Bruce to drive back to the village we had come from. Even though the road was littered with boulders and pitted with holes, Bruce was not in the least perturbed. Glancing at his map, he informed us that the next village was a mere twenty miles away. It was not that Bruce always underestimated difficulties. He simply had no sense of danger at all. No matter what the conditions were, he believed that a car should be driven as fast as it could possibly go.

As we bumped over the dusty track, we swerved to avoid large boulders. The wheels scooped up stones which hammered ominously under the car. We felt sure that sooner or later a stone would rip a hole in our petrol tank or damage the engine. Because of this, we kept looking back, wondering if we were leaving a trail of oil and petrol behind us.

What a relief it was when the boulders suddenly disappeared, giving way to a stretch of plain where the only obstacles were clumps of bushes. But there was worse to come. Just ahead of us there was a huge fissure. In response to renewed pleadings, Bruce stopped. Though we all got out to examine the fissure, he remained in the car.

We informed him that the fissure extended for fifty yards and was two feet wide and four feet deep. Even this had no effect. Bruce still drove at a terrifying speed, and soon we had left the fissure far behind. We were now in the middle of a forest which grew thicker and thicker. It was so thick that we could hardly move forward any more.

Bruce went into a low gear and drove at a terrifying speed, keeping the front wheels astride the crack as he followed its zig - zag course. We were all sweating profusely. Not for one minute did he look at the map. He was just driving. At last we could see a dim light in the distance, and soon afterwards we arrived at the village.

40. Food and Talk

Last week at a dinner - party, the hostess asked me to sit next to Mrs. Rumbold. Mrs. Rumbold was a large, unsmiling lady in a tight black dress. She did not even look up when I took my seat beside her. Her eyes were fixed on her plate and in a short time, she was busy eating. I tried to make conversation.

"A new play is coming to 'The Globe' soon," I said. "Will you be seeing it?"

"No," she answered.

"Will you be spending your holidays abroad this year?" I asked.

"No," she answered.

"Will you be staying in England?" I asked.

"No," she answered.

In despair, I asked her whether she was enjoying her dinner.

"Young man," she answered, "if you ate more and talked less, we would both enjoy our dinner!"

41. Illusions of Pastoral Peace

A gifted American psychologist has said, "Worry is a spasm of the emotion; the mind catches hold of something and will not let it go." It is useless to argue with the mind in this condition. The stronger the will, the more futile the task. One can only gently insinuate something else into its convulsive grasp. And if this something else is rightly chosen, if it really attended by the illumination of another field of interest, gradually, and often quite swiftly, the old undue grip relaxes and the process of recuperation and repair begins.

The cultivation of a hobby and new forms of interest is therefore a policy of first importance to a public man. But this is not a business that can be undertaken in a day or swiftly improvised by a mere command of the will. The growth of alternative mental interests is a long process. The seeds must be carefully chosen; they must fall on good ground; they must be sedulously tended, if the vivifying fruits are to be at hand when needed.

To be really happy and really safe, one ought to have at least two or three hobbies, and they must all be real. It is no use starting late in life to say: "I will take an interest in this or that." Such an attempt only aggravates the strain of mental effort. A man may acquire great knowledge of topics unconnected with his daily work, and yet get hardly any benefit or relief. It is no use doing what you like; you have to like what you do. Broadly speaking, human beings may be divided into three classes: those who are toiled to death, those who are worried to death, and those who are bored to death. It is no use offering the manual laborer, tired out with a hard day's work, a seat in a park or a lecture on aesthetics. It is no use inviting the politician or the business man, who has been worried about affairs of state or business all day, to attend a concert or the ballet. It is no use telling the bored, unemployed youth, "Go and play football." The right kind of spiritual food is just as necessary for one class as for another.

Those who are toiled to death are too busy to enjoy life. Those who are worried to death are too nervous to enjoy life. Those who are bored to death are too listless to enjoy life. There is no country in the world where one can not find people who would be happy to spend the rest of their lives in a village if they could. And yet, no country in the world is free from the scourge of poverty. Poverty is like a disease that is constantly spreading. It is not enough to have a good income. One must also have a good way of spending it. There are people who earn a great deal of money, but they are not happy because they do not know how to spend it. There are also people who have very little money, but they are happy because they know how to spend it.

In a world that is constantly changing, the idea of a pastoral idyll is an illusion. The idea of a simple life, free from worry and poverty, is an illusion. The idea of a life where one can do as one pleases, without any restrictions, is an illusion. The idea of a life where one can be completely happy, without any unhappiness, is an illusion. But these illusions are not without value. They give us hope. They give us something to look forward to. They give us the strength to go on.

42. Modern Cavemen

Cave exploration, or pot-holing, as it has come to be known, is a relatively new sport. Perhaps it is the desire for solitude or the chance of making an unexpected discovery that lures people down to the depths of the earth. It is impossible to give a satisfactory explanation for a pot-holer's motives. For him, caves have the same peculiar fascination which high mountains have for the climber. They arouse instincts which can only be dimly understood.

Exploring really deep caves is not a task for the Sunday afternoon Rambler. Such undertakings require the precise planning and foresight of military operations. It can take as long as eight days to rig up rope ladders and to establish supply bases before a descent can be made into a very deep cave. Precautions of this sort are necessary, for it is impossible to foretell the exact nature of the difficulties which will confront the pot-holer. The deepest known cave in the world is the Gouffre Berger near Grenoble. It extends to a depth of 3,723 feet. This immense chasm has been formed by an underground stream which has tunnelled a course through a flaw in the rocks. The entrance to the cave is on a plateau in the Dauphine Alps. As it is only six feet across, it is barely noticeable. The cave might never have been discovered had not the entrance been spotted by the distinguished French potholer, Berger. Since its discovery, it has become a sort of pot-holers' Everest. Though a number of descents have been made, much of it still remains to be explored.

A team of pot-holers recently went down the Gouffre Berger. After entering the narrow gap on the plateau, they climbed down the steep sides of the cave until they came to a narrow corridor. They had to edge their way along this, sometimes wading across shallow streams, or swimming across deep pools. Suddenly they came to a waterfall which dropped into an underground lake at the bottom. They plunged into the lake, and after loading their gear on an inflatable rubber dinghy, let the current carry them to the other side. To their dismay, they found that the caverns were filled with water. This did not deter them, and they were determined to continue their

exploration. One of the members of the team pointed out that they could not go on much longer without fresh water. This led to a search for fresh water which ended in failure. They were so thirsty that they drank a lot of the water in which they had been swimming. The water was not fresh, but it was all they had.

Scientists have expressed their dismay at the fate of the pot - holers. Lack of fresh water and food, and exhaustion will soon make it impossible for them to continue their exploration. They hope that a rescue party will be sent as soon as possible.

43. Fully Insured

Insurance companies are normally willing to insure anything.

Insuring public or private property is a standard practice in most countries in the world.

If, however, you were holding an open air garden party or a fete it would be equally possible to insure yourself in the event of bad weather.

Needless to say, the bigger the risk an insurance company takes, the higher the premium you will have to pay.

It is not uncommon to hear that a ship ping company has made a claim for the cost of salvaging a sunken ship.

But the claim made by a local authority to recover the cost of salvaging a sunken pie dish must surely be unique.

Admittedly it was an unusual pie dish, for it was eighteen feet long and six feet wide.

It had been purchased by a local authority so that an enormous pie could be baked for an annual fair.

The pie committee decided that the best way to transport the dish would be by canal, so they insured it for the trip.

Shortly after it was launched, the pie dish met with some trouble.

The vessel was stranded on a sandbank two days later in a storm.

A tugboat was sent to the ship's assistance.

Despite the fact that a tugboat was towing the pie dish, it could not prevent it from going aground again.

The local authority realized that they could not handle the situation alone, so they decided to call in a dredging company to help them out.

The dredging company sent a huge dredger which could handle the situation.

When the dredger arrived, it began to suck up the sand around the pie dish.

As it sucked up the sand, the dish became lighter and lighter.

Finally, the dish was lifted out of the sand and placed on a barge.

It was then towed to its destination.

The local authority was very pleased with the way things had been handled.

They were also very happy that they had insured the pie dish for the full value.

When they submitted their claim to the insurance company, they were surprised to find that the insurance company was also very happy to pay up.

The insurance company explained that the pie dish was a unique item and that they had no intention of disputing the claim.

After all, they had been fully insured.

44. Speed and Comfort

People traveling long distances frequently have to decide whether they would prefer to go by land, sea, or air. Hardly anyone can positively enjoy sitting in a train for more than a few hours. Train compartments soon get cramped and stuffy. It is almost impossible to take your mind off the journey. Reading is only a partial solution, for the monotonous rhythm of the wheels clicking on the rails soon lulls you to sleep. During the day, sleep comes in snatches. At night, when you really wish to go to sleep, you rarely manage to do so. If you are lucky enough to get a sleeper, you spend half the night staring at the small blue light in the ceiling, or fumbling to find your ticket for inspection. Inevitably you arrive at your destination almost exhausted. Long car journeys are even less pleasant, for it is quite impossible to read. On motorways you can, at least, travel fairly safely at high speeds, but more often than not, the greater part of the journey is spent on narrow, bumpy roads which

are crowded with traffic. By comparison, trips by sea offer a great variety of civilized comforts. You can stretch your legs on the spacious decks, play games, swim, meet interesting people and enjoy good food---always assuming, of course, that the sea is calm. If it is not, and you are likely to get seasick, no form of transport could be worse. Even if you travel in ideal weather, sea journeys take a long time. Relatively few people are prepared to sacrifice up to a third of their holidays for the pleasure of traveling on a ship. Aeroplanes have the reputation of being dangerous and even hardened travellers are intimidated by them. They also have the disadvantage of being an expensive form of transport. But nothing can match them for speed and comfort. Traveling at a height of 30,000 feet, far above the clouds, and at over 500 miles an hour is an exhilarating experience. You do not have to devise ways of taking your mind off the journey, for an aeroplane gets you to your destination rapidly. For a few hours, you settle back in a deep armchair to enjoy the flight. The real escapist can watch a free film show and sip champagne on some services. But even when such refinements are not available, there is plenty to keep you occupied. An aeroplane offers you an unusual and breathtaking view of the world. You soar effortlessly over high mountains and deep valleys. You really see the shape of the land. If the landscape is hidden from view, you can enjoy the extraordinary sight of unbroken cloud plains that stretch out for miles before you, while the sun shines brilliantly in a clear sky. The journey is so smooth that there is nothing to prevent you from reading or sleeping. However you decide to spend your time, one thing is certain: you will arrive at your destination fresh and uncrumpled. You will not have to spend the next few days recovering from a long and arduous journey.

45. The power of the press

In democratic countries any efforts to restrict the freedom of the press are rightly condemned. However, this freedom can easily be abused. Stories about people often attract far more public attention than political events. Though we may enjoy reading about the lives of others, it is extremely doubtful whether we would equally enjoy reading about ourselves. Acting on the contention that facts are sacred, reporters can cause untold suffering to individuals by publishing details about their private lives. Newspapers exert such tremendous influence that they can not only bring about major changes to the lives of ordinary people but can even overthrow a government.

The story of a poor family that acquired fame and fortune overnight, dramatically

illustrates the power of the press. The family lived in Aberdeen, a small town of 23,000 inhabitants in South Dakota. As the parents had five children, life was a perpetual struggle against poverty. They were expecting their sixth child and were faced with even more pressing economic problems. If they had only had one more child, the fact would have passed unnoticed. They would have continued to struggle against economic odds and would have lived in obscurity.

But they suddenly became the parents of quintuplets, four girls and a boy, an event which radically changed their lives. The day after the birth of the five children, an aeroplane arrived in Aberdeen bringing sixty reporters and photographers. The news was of national importance, for the couple had become the parents of the only quintuplets in America.

The rise to fame was swift. Television cameras and newspapers carried the news to everyone in the country. Newspapers and magazines offered the family huge sums for the exclusive rights to publish stories and photographs. Gifts poured in not only from unknown people, but from baby - food manufacturers who wished to advertise their products. The old farmhouse the family lived in was to be replaced by a new \$100,000 home. Reporters kept pressing for interviews so lawyers had to be employed to act as spokes - men for the family at press conferences.

While the five babies were still quietly sleeping in oxygen tents in a hospital nursery, their parents were paying the price for fame. It would never again be possible for them to lead normal lives. They had become the victims of commercialization, for their names had acquired a market value. Instead of being five new family members, these children had immediately become a commodity.

46. Do it yourself

So great is our passion for doing things for ourselves, that we are becoming increasingly less dependent on specialized labour. No one can plead ignorance of a subject any longer, for there are countless do - it - yourself publications. Armed with the right tools and materials, newly - weds gaily embark on the task of decorating their own homes. Men, particularly, spend hours of their leisure time installing their own fireplaces, laying out their own gardens; building garages and making furniture. Some really keen enthusiasts go so far as to build their own computers. Shops cater for the do - it - yourself craze not only by running special advisory services for novices, but by offering consumers bits and pieces which they can assemble at

home. Such things provide an excellent outlet for pent - up creative energy, but unfortunately not all of us are born handymen.

Some wives tend to believe that their husbands are infinitely resourceful and can fix anything. Even men who can hardly drive a nail in straight are supposed to be born electricians, carpenters, plumbers and mechanics. When lights fuse, furniture gets rickety, pipes get clogged, or vacuum cleaners fail to operate, some women assume that their husbands will somehow put things right. The worst thing about the do - it - yourself game is that sometimes even men live under the delusion that they can do anything, even when they have repeatedly been proved wrong. It is a question of pride as much as anything else.

Last spring my wife suggested that I call in a man to look at our lawn - mower. It had broken down the previous summer, and though I promised to repair it, I had never got round to it. I would not hear of the suggestion and said that I would fix it myself. One Saturday afternoon, I hauled the machine into the garden and had a close look at it. As far as I could see, it only needed a minor adjustment: a turn of a screw here, a little tightening up there, a drop of oil and it would be as good as new. Inevitably the repair job was not quite so simple. The mower firmly refused to mow, so I decided to dismantle it. The garden was soon littered with chunks of metal which had once made up a lawn - mower. But I was extremely pleased with myself. I had traced the cause of the trouble. One of the links in the chain that drives the wheels had snapped.

After buying a new chain I was faced with the insurmountable task of putting the confusing jigsaw puzzle together again. I was not surprised to find that the machine still refused to work after I had reassembled it, for the simple reason that I was left with several curiously shaped bits of metal which did not seem to fit anywhere. I gave up in despair. The weeks passed and the grass grew. When my wife nagged me to do something about it, I told her that either I would have to buy a new mower or let the grass grow. Needless to say, our garden is still a mess.

47. Too high a price

Pollution is the price we pay for an overpopulated, over industrialized planet. When you come to think about it, there are only four ways you can deal with rubbish: dump it, burn it, turn it into something you can use again, attempt to produce less of it. We keep trying all four methods, but the sheer volume of rubbish we produce

worldwide threatens to overwhelm us. Rubbish, however, is only part of the problem of polluting our planet. The need to produce ever - increasing quantities of cheap food leads to a different kind of pollution. Industrialized farming methods produce cheap meat products: beef, pork and chicken. The use of pesticides and fertilizers produces cheap grain and vegetables. The price we pay for cheap food may be already too high: Mad Cow Disease (BSE) in cattle, salmonella in chicken and eggs, and listeria in dairy products. And if you think you'll abandon meat and become a vegetarian, you have the choice of very expensive organically - grown vegetables or a steady diet of pesticides every time you think you're eating fresh salads and vegetables, or just having an innocent glass of water! However, there is an even more insidious kind of pollution that particularly affects urban areas and invades our daily lives, and that is noise. Burglar alarms going off at any time of the day or night serve only to annoy passers - by and actually assist burglars to burgle. Car alarms constantly scream at us in the street and are a source of profound irritation. A recent survey of the effects of noise revealed (surprisingly?) that dogs barking incessantly in the night rated the highest form of noise pollution on a scale ranging from 1 to 7. The survey revealed a large number of sources of noise that we really dislike: lawn mowers, transistor radios, motorcycles, etc. New technology has also made its own contribution to noise. A lot of people object to mobile phones, especially when they are used in public places like restaurants or on public transport. Loud conversations on mobile phones invade our thoughts or interrupt the pleasure of meeting friends for a quiet chat. The noise pollution survey revealed a rather surprising and possibly amusing old - fashioned source of noise. It seems we are at our noisiest when we are asleep! The rattling noise of the alarm clock at the bedside wakes us up. What an irritating way to start the day! It doesn't have to be this way. There are laws in most cities to stop factories emitting black smoke into the atmosphere, and there are also laws which force people to adopt anti - pollution measures, but these laws are not always rigidly enforced. It is cheaper for companies to break the laws and pay the fines than to buy the expensive equipment that will reduce the pollution. It is also cheaper for people to continue to throw rubbish away than to spend time and money on recycling. Noise pollution is at its worst in cities. It can make people ill, or drive them mad. It is a problem that we cannot afford to ignore.

48. The Silent Village

In this much - travelled world, there are still thousands of places which are inaccessible to tourists. We always assume that villagers in remote places are friendly and hospitable. But people who are cut off not only from foreign tourists, but even from their own countrymen can be hostile to travellers. Visits to really remote villages are seldom enjoyable - as my wife and I discovered during a tour through the Balkans.

We had spent several days in a small town and visited a number of old churches in the vicinity. These attracted many visitors, for they were not only of great architectural interest, but contained a large number of beautifully preserved frescoes as well. On the day before our departure, several bus loads of tourists descended on the town. This was more than we could bear, so we decided to spend our last day exploring the countryside. Taking a path which led out of the town, we crossed a few fields until we came to a dense wood. We expected the path to end abruptly, but we found that it traced its way through the trees. We tramped through the wood for over two hours until we arrived at a deep stream. We could see that the path continued on the other side, but we had no idea how we could get across the stream. Suddenly my wife spotted a boat moored to the bank. In it there was a boatman fast asleep. We gently woke him up and asked him to ferry us across the stream. The boatman got up, stretched himself and made ready to set off. He was a huge man, well over six feet tall, and broad in proportion, and his muscles bulged out of his shirt sleeves as he rowed. The boat glided smoothly across the lake and we got out on the opposite bank. We were about to walk away when the boatman called out to us. He said something in his local dialect which we could not understand, but he motioned to us to wait. He then went back to the boat and brought out a large tin box. He placed it on the ground in front of us and opened it. Inside were dozens of beautifully carved wooden animals. He had carved them himself, and they were all as different as the villagers whom we had left behind. The boatman wanted an exorbitant amount of money for them, but we had no choice but to pay up. After all, we had no idea how we could get back without his boat. We made our way back to the town as quickly as possible, but we were not in time to catch the bus for our next destination. So we had to hire a car and drive to the airport. The journey was long and tiring, but we were glad to be away from the Silent Village.

49. The Ideal Servant

It is a good thing my aunt Harriet died years ago. If she were alive today she would not be able to air her views on her favourite topic of conversation: domestic servants. Aunt Harriet lived in that leisurely age when servants were employed to do housework. She had a huge, rambling country house called 'The Gables'. She was sentimentally attached to this house, for even though it was far too big for her needs, she persisted in living there long after her husband's death. Before she grew old, Aunt Harriet used to entertain lavishly. I often visited The Gables when I was a boy. No matter how many guests were present, the great house was always immaculate. The parquet floors shone like mirrors; highly polished silver was displayed in gleaming glass cabinets; even my uncle's huge collection of books was kept miraculously free from dust. Aunt Harriet presided over an invisible army of servants that continuously scrubbed, cleaned, and polished. She always referred to them as 'the shifting population', for they came and went with such frequency that I never even got a chance to learn their names. Though my aunt pursued what was, in those days, an enlightened policy, in that she never allowed her domestic staff to work more than eight hours a day, she was extremely difficult to please. While she always decried the fickleness of human nature, she carried on an unrelenting search for the ideal servant to the end of her days, even after she had been seriously weakened by a stroke. Even when she was unable to speak, still her eyes, full of pain and suffering, expressed her unspoken thoughts. Her last message to me consisted of a single word: 'Servants'.

50. New Year Resolutions

The New Year is a time for resolutions. Mentally, at least, most of us could compile formidable lists of 'dos' and 'don'ts'. The same old favourites recur year in year out with monotonous regularity. We resolve to get up earlier each morning, eat less, find more time to play with the children, do a thousand and one jobs about the house, be nice to people we don't like, drive carefully, and take the dog for a walk every day. Past experience has taught us that certain accomplishments are beyond attainment. If we remain inveterate smokers, it is only because we have so often experienced the frustration that results from failure. Most of us fail in our efforts at self-improvement because our schemes are too ambitious and we never have time to carry them out. We also make the fundamental error of announcing our resolutions to everybody so that we look even more foolish when we slip back into our bad old

ways. Aware of these pitfalls, this year I attempted to keep my resolutions to myself. I limited myself to two modest ambitions: to do physical exercises every morning and to read more of an evening. An all - night party on New Year's Eve provided me with a good excuse for not carrying out either of these new resolutions on the first day of the New Year, but on the second, I applied myself assiduously to the task.

The daily exercises lasted only eleven minutes and I proposed to do them early in the morning before anyone had got up. The self - discipline required to drag myself out of bed eleven minutes earlier than usual was considerable. Nevertheless, I managed to creep down into the living - room for two days before anyone found me out. After jumping about on the carpet and twisting the human frame into uncomfortable positions, I sat down at the breakfast table in an exhausted state. It was this that betrayed me. My wife was sitting opposite me, looking rather glum.

'You don't look very well,' she said. 'Is something wrong?'

'I've been doing my exercises,' I said.

'What exercises?' she asked in surprise.

'Jumping about on the carpet and twisting the human frame into uncomfortable positions,' I replied.

'Good heavens!' she exclaimed. 'Why on earth are you doing that?'

'Well, I've made a resolution to do physical exercises every morning,' I explained.

'But you don't look as if you've been doing physical exercises,' she said.

'I haven't finished yet,' I said. 'I've only been doing them for two days.'

'You're making a fool of yourself,' she said. 'You can't expect to improve your physical condition in two days. You need at least a couple of weeks.'

'I know,' I said. 'But I'm determined to carry out my resolution.'

'I'm sure you are,' she said. 'But you're still making a fool of yourself.'

I decided to give up the exercises, because it was clear that my wife was right. I had been making a fool of myself. It was not so much my appearance that betrayed me as my lack of energy. I realized that if I continued to do the exercises, I would be making a fool of myself even more. So I abandoned the idea of physical exercises and concentrated on my second resolution: reading more of an evening. This was easier said than done, because I soon discovered that I had not got the necessary books. I had been thinking about buying some new books for a long time, but I had

always postponed the purchase. Now that I had made a resolution to read more, I needed to buy some books. I went to the local bookstore, but I could not find any books that I really wanted to buy. I was disappointed, but I did not give up. I went to another bookstore, and this time I found some books that I liked. I bought them and took them home. I was pleased with my purchase, but I knew that I still had a long way to go before I could say that I had carried out my resolution. I needed to find time to read the books, and I needed to make sure that I did not slip back into my bad old ways of not reading enough.

51. Predicting the future

Predicting the future is notoriously difficult. Who could have imagined, in the mid 1970s, for example, that by the end of the 20th century, computers would be as common in people's homes as TV sets? In the 1970s, computers were common enough, but only in big business, government departments, and large organizations. These were the so - called mainframe machines. Mainframe computers were very large indeed, often occupying whole air - conditioned rooms, employing full - time technicians and run on specially - written software. Though these large machines still exist, many of their functions have been taken over by small powerful personal computers, commonly known as PCs.

No one could have foreseen, in those days, the rise of these machines called PCs, in which people could type in commands instead of punching holes in cards. It has become clear that the Internet - the computers - network is one of the most powerful tools for the 21st century. School children who know how to use the Internet will be at a great advantage over those who don't. There is no doubt that all this new technology is changing the way we work and offering many other ways of working. We no longer have to work at the same time, at the same place every day. People can telecommute in their pajamas if they like. A recent survey in the United States showed that 80% of all companies interviewed were either already using or planning to use the Internet in their business.

One of the greatest benefits of Internet shopping is that it is open seven days a week, 24 hours a day. Shoppers no longer have to queue up in stores during the rush - hour. This is a great convenience for those who are too busy to go to the stores during regular business hours. The Internet also makes it easier for companies to keep in touch with their customers and for people to keep in touch with each other. Companies can e - mail newsletters to their customers. And families and friends can

send e - mails to each other instead of writing letters or making phone calls.

Another big advantage of the Internet is the amount of information that is available. There are sites on the Internet that list the full text of books. Some sites allow you to download entire books. Other sites offer encyclopedias, dictionaries, and other reference materials. You can also find newspapers, magazines, and other periodicals on the Internet. And, of course, there are millions of web pages with all kinds of information on them.

Predicting the future of the Internet is also difficult. Some experts believe that the Internet will continue to grow and expand. They think that more and more people will use the Internet, and that it will become even more powerful. Others believe that the Internet will become overcrowded and that its growth will slow down. There are also concerns about security. How can we be sure that our e - mail messages are private? How can we be sure that the information we download from the Internet is accurate? These are all questions that need to be answered as the Internet continues to grow.

But one thing is certain: the Internet has changed our lives, and it will continue to change our lives in the future.

52. Mud is Mud

My cousin, Harry, keeps a large curiously-shaped bottle on permanent display in his study. Despite the fact that the bottle is tinted a delicate shade of green, an observant visitor would soon notice that it is filled with what looks like a thick, grayish substance.

If you were to ask Harry what was in the bottle, he would tell you that it contained perfumed mud. If you expressed doubt or surprise, he would immediately invite you to smell it and then to rub some into your skin. This brief experiment would dispel any further doubts you might have. The bottle really does contain perfumed mud.

How Harry came into the possession of this outlandish stuff makes an interesting story which he is fond of relating. Furthermore, the acquisition of this bottle cured him of a bad habit he had been developing for years.

Harry used to consider it a great joke to go into expensive cosmetic shops and make outrageous requests for goods that do not exist. He would invent fanciful names on the spot. On entering a shop, he would ask for a new perfume called 'Scented

Shadow' or for 'insoluble bath cubes'. If a shop assistant told him she had not heard of it, he would pretend to be considerably put out. He loved to be told that one of his imaginary products was temporarily out of stock and he would faithfully promise to call again at some future date, but of course he never did. How Harry managed to keep a straight face during these performances is quite beyond me.

Harry does not need to be prompted to explain how he bought his precious bottle of mud. One day, while he was on holiday, he visited a temple. He noticed that there was an unusual amount of activity going on around an apparently derelict building. Asking around, he discovered that a monk had been living there for years. The monk had been violating the law, repeatedly begging for alms in the town. The townspeople were not very happy about this, but they did not want to offend the monk. They just wished he would go away.

Finally, the townspeople could not stand it any longer and decided to do something about it. They called in a local builder. The builder inspected the building and said that he would be able to make it habitable with a bit of repair work. The townspeople were very happy to hear this and immediately set about collecting money from the public. The builder said that he would start work as soon as he received the money.

The monk, who had heard about this, was not very happy. He did not want to lose his home. He thought of a plan. He went to a nearby cosmetics factory and bought a large bottle of perfumed mud. He took it back to the temple and poured it all over the building. When the townspeople and the builder arrived, they were horrified. The building was covered in a thick layer of grayish mud. The builder said that he could not possibly repair the building now. The townspeople were angry with the monk, but they did not want to get their hands dirty trying to clean it up. They just left the monk alone in his muddy building.

Harry, who had witnessed all this, was very amused. He thought that the monk was very clever. He decided to buy the bottle of mud from the monk. The monk was happy to sell it to him. Harry took the bottle home and put it on permanent display in his study.

53. In the Public Interest

The Scandinavian countries are much admired all over the world for their enlightened social policies. Sweden has evolved an excellent system for protecting the individual citizen from high - handed or incompetent public officers. The system has worked so well, that it has been adopted in other countries too.

The Swedes were the first to recognize that public official like civil servants, police officers, health inspectors or tax - collectors can make mistakes or act over - zealously in the belief that they are serving the public. As long ago as 1809, the Swedish Parliament introduced a scheme to safeguard the interest of the individual. A parliamentary committee representing all political parties appoints a person who is suitably qualified to investigate private grievances against the State. The official title of the person is 'Justiteombudsman', but the Swedes commonly refer to him as the 'J.O.' or 'Ombudsman'.

The Ombudsman is not subject to political pressure. He investigates complaints large and small that come to him from all levels of society. As complaints must be made in writing, the Ombudsman receives an average of 1,200 letters a year. He has eight lawyer assistants to help him and he examines every single letter in detail. There is nothing secretive about the Ombudsman's work, for his correspondence is open to public inspection. If a citizen's complaint is justified, the Ombudsman will act on his behalf. The action he takes varies according to the nature of the complaint. He may gently reprimand an official or even suggest to parliament that a law be altered. The following case is a typical example of the Ombudsman's work.

A foreigner living in a Swedish village wrote to the Ombudsman complaining that he had been ill - treated by the police, simply because he was a foreigner. The Ombudsman immediately wrote to the Chief of Police in the district asking him to send a record of the case. There was nothing in the record to show that the foreigner's complaints were justified. The Ombudsman nevertheless decided to carry out an investigation, for he had received similar complaints from other foreigners in the area. He sent a form to the police chief asking him to make a list of all the foreign residents in the district. The police chief did so and sent the list to the Ombudsman. The Ombudsman then sent a letter to each of the foreigners asking them to describe their experiences with the police. In reply, he received a number of letters from the foreigners which told of the same kind of ill - treatment by the police. These letters enabled the Ombudsman to prove that the police had acted unjustly. He reprimanded the police chief in writing and demanded that he send a written apology to the foreigner. The police chief complied and the foreigner was satisfied.

The Ombudsman's job is not an easy one. He often has to work long hours, and he has to be able to stand up to political pressure. But he is highly respected for his integrity and his impartiality.

54. Instinct or Cleverness

We have been brought up to fear insects. We regard them as unnecessary creatures that do more harm than good. Man continually wages war on them, for they contaminate his food, carry diseases, or devour his crops. They sting or bite without provocation; they fly uninvited into our rooms on summer nights, or beat against our lighted windows.

We live in dread not only of unpleasant insects like spiders or wasps, but of quite harmless one like moths. Reading about them increases our understanding without dispelling our fears. Knowing that the industrious ant lives in a highly organized society does nothing to prevent us from being filled with revulsion when we find hordes of them crawling over a carefully prepared picnic lunch.

No matter how much we like honey, or how much we have read about the uncanny sense of direction which bees possess, we have a horror of being stung. Most of our fears are unreasonable, but they are impossible to erase. At the same time, however, insects are strangely fascinating. We enjoy reading about them, especially when we find that, like the praying mantis, they lead perfectly horrible lives. We enjoy staring at them, entranced as they go about their business, unaware (we hope) of our presence. Who has not stood in awe at the sight of a spider pouncing on a fly, or a column of ants triumphantly bearing home an enormous dead beetle?

Last summer I spent days in the garden watching thousands of ants crawling up the trunk of my prize peach tree. The tree has grown against a warm wall on a sheltered side of the house. I am especially proud of it, not only because it has survived several severe winters, but because it occasionally produces luscious peaches. During the summer, I noticed that the leaves of the tree were beginning to wither. Clusters of tiny insects called aphids were to be found on the underside of the leaves. They were sucking sap from the underside of the leaves of my prize peach tree. I immediately fetched a can of insecticide and sprayed the underside of the leaves thoroughly. I repeated the spraying operation several times before I felt satisfied that I had got rid of all the aphids. For two more weeks, I watched the tree carefully. It seemed that the aphids were gone and the tree was beginning to thrive

again. Then, without warning, a large number of ants began to climb the tree. They were making their way up the trunk in long, thin lines. As soon as they reached the underside of the leaves, they set to work on the aphids. They were carrying the aphids' eggs; they were licking the aphids; they were taking care of the aphids all in return for a little sap which the aphids secrete. I realized that I had been wrong in thinking that the ants were simply thieves. They were in fact the protectors of the aphids. The aphids were supplying the ants with food, and the ants were protecting the aphids from the insecticide spray. It is not always easy to distinguish between things that are beneficial and things that are harmful. It is often necessary to make a distinction between instinct and cleverness.

55. From the Earth: Greetings

Recent developments in astronomy have made it possible to detect planets in our own Milky Way and in other galaxies. This is a major achievement because, in relative terms, planets are very small and do not emit light. Finding planets is proving hard enough, but finding life on them will prove infinitely more difficult. The first question to answer is whether a planet can actually support life. In our own solar system, for example, Venus is far too hot and Mars is far too cold to support life. Only the Earth provides ideal conditions, and even here it has taken more than four billion years for plant and animal life to evolve.

Whether a planet can support life depends on the size and brightness of its star, that is its 'sun'. Imagine a star up to twenty times larger, brighter and hotter than our own sun. A planet would have to be a very long way from it to be capable of supporting life. On the other hand, if the star were small, the life - supporting planet would have to have a close orbit round it and also provide the perfect conditions for water: not too hot and not too cold, as otherwise water would turn to vapour or ice.

Secondly, we may wonder whether there is life on other planets. At present we can only detect life - forms that are based on carbon. Consequently, a search for non - carbon - based life forms may prove to be a fruitless search. However, it is probably a mistake to assume that other life - forms would be similar to our own. They might not need water or oxygen, or even light, as we do. Instead, they might have developed other ways of growing, moving or reproducing.

Finally, we may ask whether life on other planets would be friendly or hostile to us. The answer to this question depends on whether we consider them as potential

friends or foes. If we consider them as friends, we will be more likely to welcome them. If we consider them as foes, we will be more likely to fear them. However, given the vastness of the universe, it is more likely that we will never know the answer to this question.

56. Our neighbour, the river

The river which forms the eastern boundary of our farm has always played an important part in our lives. Without it we could not make a living. There is only enough spring water to supply the needs of the house, so we have to pump from the river for farm use. We tell the river all our secrets. We know instinctively, just as beekeepers with their bees, that misfortune might overtake us if the important events of our lives were not related to it.

Of course, the great thing is not to allow any dogmatic to creep in, not to become narrow and intolerant. And it is the same with political opinions. We all know people who are so addicted to their particular variety of snobbery that they limit their intercourse to people of their own kind, and are very surprised and even hurt if one day they find that their teenage son or daughter has married outside their own class or group. But on the whole, we all have a very wide common ground of agreement on which we can talk without any feeling of restraint or self-consciousness. We all know that if we overfish, the fish in the river will soon be exhausted, and so we have an agreement not to fish in the river for more than a certain number of fish each season. We also know that if we do not take good care of the river, the fish will die, and so we have an agreement to keep the river clean.

There is also the question of security. We all know that if we are not on our guard, some day we will be invaded by our neighbours on the other side of the river. So we keep a watchful eye on them, and at the same time we make sure that they know that we are watching them. But on the whole, we live in peace with them. We are all neighbours, after all.

Our relationship with the river is like that of the ancient Greeks with their gods. We have sacrificed a lot to it, and we have also received a lot from it. It is a very important part of our lives.

57. Back in the old country

I stopped to let the car cool off and to study the map. I had expected to be near my objective by now, but everything still seemed alien to me. I was only five when my father had taken me abroad, and that was eighteen years ago. When my mother had died after a tragic accident, he did not quickly recover from the shock and loneliness. Everything around him was full of her presence, continually reopening the wound. So he decided to emigrate. In the new country he became absorbed in making a new life for the two of us, so that he gradually ceased to grieve. He did not marry again and I was brought up without a woman's care; but I lacked for nothing, for he was both father and mother to me. He always meant to go back one day, but not to stay. His roots and mine had become too firmly embedded in the new land. But he wanted to see the old folk again and to visit my mother's grave. He became mortally ill a few months before we had planned to go and, when he knew that he was dying, he made me promise to go on my own. I hired a car the day after landing and bought a comprehensive book of maps, which I found most helpful on the cross-country journey, but which I did not think I should need on the last stage. It was not that I actually remembered anything at all. But my father had described over and over again what we should see at every milestone, after leaving the nearest town, so that I was positive I should recognize it as familiar territory. Well, I had been wrong, for I was now lost. I looked at the map and then at the milometer. I had come ten miles since leaving the town, and at this point, according to my father, I should be looking at farms and cottages in a valley, with the spire of the church of our village showing in the far distance. I could see no valley, no farms, no cottages and no church spire - only a lake. I decided that I must have taken a wrong turning somewhere. So I drove back to the town and began to retrace my steps, taking the routes I had not taken before. It was a slow process, full of frustrations and regular disappointments. Just when I was beginning to despair, I came upon a signpost. And it was only as I was studying it that I realized I had been looking at it from the wrong angle all the time. There was my village, right where my father had said it would be. I drove on for a few miles and then I saw it. My father had described it to me so often that I recognized it immediately - my mother's old home. Then I turned a corner and, as I did so, I realized that I had been deceived by an optical illusion. I had been following a man who was two hundred yards ahead of me and who was also driving slowly. As he turned a corner, I assumed that he must be making for the same destination as myself. I followed him for a long time, but at last I lost him in the darkness. I looked at my watch. It was past midnight. I was very tired and also very hungry by this time, but there was still no sign of the village. I was beginning to wonder if I had made a mistake. Just then I saw a faint light in the distance. I

drove towards it, hoping that it was a sign of some sort of habitation. It was a small house, and I could see a man working in the garden. I got out of the car and walked towards him. He stopped his work and looked at me. "You're lost, aren't you?" he said. "Yes," I replied. "I'm looking for my mother's old home." "Your mother's old home?" he said. "There are no houses here." "But it must be here," I said. "My father described it to me so often." "Your father?" he said. "Who was your father?" "His name was Henry," I said. "Henry who?" he asked. "Henry Twycross," I said. "Oh," he said. "I knew him. He used to live here. But that was a long time ago. There's been a lot of change since then." "But where is my mother's old home?" I asked. "It's gone," he said. "It was knocked down years ago." "But why?" I asked. "Because it was in the way of progress," he said. "There was a new road being built and it had to be removed." "So what am I to do?" I asked. "You can stay here if you like," he said. "I have a spare room." "Thank you," I said. "But I think I'll go on." "Where to?" he asked. "I don't know," I said. "I just want to see the old country." "Well," he said. "Good luck." I got back into the car and drove off. I was very sad. I had come all this way to find my mother's old home, but it was gone. I had been deceived by my father's description and by my own memories. I was lost again, not only in the physical sense but also in the emotional sense. I drove on for a while, but I was not really interested in where I was going. I was just thinking about my father and my mother and the old days. Then I saw a signpost. It said "To the old country". I followed it. I don't know where it led me, but I followed it. I was still lost, but I was following the signpost to the old country.

58. A Spot of Bother

The old lady was glad to be back at the block of flats where she lived. Her shopping had tired her and her basket had grown heavier with every step of the way home. In the lift her thoughts were on lunch and a good rest; but when she got out at her own floor, both were forgotten in her sudden discovery that her front door was open. She was thinking that she must reprimand her daily maid the next morning for such a monstrous piece of negligence, when she remembered that she had gone shopping after the maid had left and she knew that she had turned both keys in their locks. She walked slowly into the hall and at once noticed that all the room doors were open, yet following her regular practice she had shut them before going out. Looking into the drawing room, she saw a scene of confusion over by her writing desk. It was as clear as daylight then that burglars had forced an entry during her absence. Her first impulse was to go round all the rooms looking for the thieves, but then she decided

that at her age it might be more prudent to have someone with her, so she went to fetch the porter from his basement. By this time her legs were beginning to tremble, so she sat down and accepted a cup of very strong tea, while he telephoned the police. Then, her composure regained, she was ready to set off with the porter's assistance to search for any intruders who might still be lurking in her flat.

They went through the rooms, being careful to touch nothing, as they did not want to hinder the police in their search for fingerprints. The chaos was inconceivable. She had lived in the flat for thirty years and was a veritable magpie at hoarding; and it seemed as though everything she possessed had been tossed out and turned over and over. At least sorting out the things she should have discarded years ago was now being made easier for her. Then a police inspector arrived with a constable and she told them of her discovery of the ransacked flat. The inspector began to look for fingerprints, while the constable checked that the front door locks had not been forced, thereby proving that the burglars had either used skeleton keys or entered over the balcony. There was no trace of fingerprints, but the inspector found a dirty red bundle that contained jewellery which the old lady said was not hers. So their entry into this flat was apparently not the burglars' first job that day and they must have been disturbed. The inspector then asked the old lady to try to check what was missing by the next day and advised her not to stay alone in the flat for a few nights. The old lady thought he was a fussy old fool at first, for to her, nothing seemed to be missing at all. But on entering her bedroom, she was shocked to find that the bed had been stripped of its coverings. At that moment she realized that she had not seen her cat for a long time. She was certain that the burglars had taken it when they had ransacked her flat. Then she began to sob inconsolably. Half an hour later, still sobbing, she telephoned the police and said that she had been wrong to call them fussy old fools. Because, she said, when she went to feed her cat just now she had found it stuffed in the wardrobe in a dirty red bundle.

59. Collecting

People tend to amass possessions, sometimes without being aware of doing so. Indeed they can have a delightful surprise when they find something useful which they did not know they owned. Those who never have to change house become indiscriminate collectors of what can only be described as clutter. They leave unwanted objects in drawers, cupboards and attics for years, in the belief that they may one day need just those very things. As they grow old, people also accumulate

belongings for two other reasons, lack of physical and mental energy, both of which are essential in turning out and throwing away, and sentiment. Things owned for a long time are full of associations with the past, perhaps with relatives who are dead, and so they gradually acquire a value beyond their true worth.

Some things are collected deliberately in the home in an attempt to avoid waste. Among these I would list string and brown paper, kept by thrifty people when a parcel has been opened, to save buying these two requisites. Collecting small items can easily become a mania. I know someone who always cuts sketches out from newspapers of model clothes that she would like to buy if she had the money. As she is not rich, the chances that she will ever be able to afford such purchases are remote; but she is never sufficiently strong - minded to be able to stop the practice. It is a harmless habit, but it litters up her desk to such an extent that every time she opens it, loose bits of paper fall out in every direction.

Collecting as a serious hobby is quite different and has many advantages. It provides relaxation for leisure hours, as just looking at one's treasures is always a joy. One does not have to go outside for amusement, since the collection is housed at home. Whatever it consists of, stamps, records, first editions of books, china, glass, antique furniture, pictures, model cars, stuffed animals, toy animals, there is always something to do in connection with it, from finding the right place for the latest addition, to verifying facts in reference books. This hobby educates one not only in the chosen subject, but also in general matters which have some bearing on it. There are also other benefits. One's friends and relatives, in their turn, may feel obliged to present the collector with gifts related to his collection. And these gifts need not be expensive. A young relative of mine, who is studying for a postgraduate degree in music, recently sent me a present of a book on the history of the piano. It was a very welcome gift as I have an interest in music and am also collecting books related to music.

Collectors may get a feeling of satisfaction from the fact that they have found something rare. But there is also the possibility that they may become obsessed with their hobby and spend all their time and money on it. This can lead to problems. For example, a collector who has a passion for antique furniture may find it difficult to resist the temptation to buy a very expensive piece, even if he does not have the money to pay for it. Or a stamp collector may become so obsessed with his stamps that he neglects his family and friends. In general, however, the advantages of collecting as a hobby far outweigh the disadvantages.

60. Too early and too late

Punctuality is a necessary habit in all public affairs in civilized society. Without it, nothing could ever be brought to a conclusion; everything would be in a state of chaos. Only in a sparsely - populated rural community is it possible to disregard it. In ordinary living, there can be some tolerance of unpunctuality. The intellectual, who is working on some abstruse problem, has everything coordinated and organized for the matter in hand. He is therefore forgiven, if late for a dinner party. But people are often reproached for unpunctuality when their only fault is cutting things fine. It is hard for energetic, quick - minded people to waste time, so they are often tempted to finish a job before setting out to keep an appointment. If no accidents occur on the way, like punctured tyres, diversions of traffic, sudden descent of fog, they will be on time. They are often more industrious, useful citizens than those who are never late. The over - punctual can be as much a trial to others as the unpunctual. The guest who arrives half an hour too soon is the greatest nuisance. Some friends of my family had this irritating habit. The only thing to do was ask them to come half an hour later than the other guests. Then they arrived just when we wanted them.

If you are catching a train, it is always better to be comfortably early than even a fraction of a minute too late. Although being early may mean wasting a little time, this will be less than if you miss the train and have to wait an hour or more for the next one; and you avoid the frustration of arriving at the very moment when the train is drawing out of the station and being unable to get on it. An even harder situation is to be on the platform in good time for a train and still to see it go off without you. Such an experience befell a certain young girl the first time she was travelling alone.

She entered the station twenty minutes before the train was due, since her parents had impressed upon her that it would be unforgivable to miss it and cause the friends with whom she was going to stay to make two journeys to meet her. She gave her luggage to a porter and showed him her ticket. To her horror he said that she was two hours too early. She felt in her handbag for the piece of paper on which her father had written down all the details of the journey and gave it to the porter. He agreed that a train did come into the station at the time on the paper, but he said that it only stopped there to take on water, not passengers. So she sat down to wait for the train which was coming in four hours' time. She had been told that her train was the one which left at five o'clock. When she arrived at the station, she found that her train had already left. She had missed it by a few minutes. This was the first time that she had ever been on her own, and she was very frightened. She did not know what to do. She could not go back to her parents because she had no money with

her. She could not stay at the station because it was too cold. She could not go to the friends' house because she did not know where it was. She had to make a decision. She decided to go to a hotel. She found a hotel near the station and went in. She asked for a room. The hotel clerk looked at her and said that she was too young to stay in a hotel alone. She showed him her ticket and told him that she was waiting for a train. He said that she could wait in the lobby. So she sat down in the lobby and waited for the train. She waited for four hours. When the train arrived, she got on it. She was very tired and very cold. She had a very bad experience.

Book 4

1. Finding Fossil Man

We can read of things that happened 5,000 years ago in the Near East, where people first learned to write. But there are some parts of the world where even now people cannot write. The only way that they can preserve their history is to recount it as sagas - legends handed down from one generation of story - tellers to another. These legends are useful because they can tell us something about migrations of people who lived long ago, but none could write down what they did. Anthropologists wondered for a long time how to classify the Pygmies of the Congo Basin and the Bushmen of the Kalahari Desert in Africa. These tribes live by hunting, fishing and gathering, and they do not plant crops. The anthropologists made a mistake, because they thought these people were still in the Stone Age. They forgot that the Pygmies and Bushmen have been in contact with modern civilization for a long time. The Pygmies and Bushmen are not Stone Age people. They are modern people who have not yet learned to write.

2. Spare that spider

Why, you may wonder, should spiders be our friends? Because they destroy so many insects, and insects include some of the greatest enemies of the human race. Insects would make it impossible for us to live in the world; they would devour all our crops and kill our flocks and herds, if it were not for the protection we get from insect-eating animals. We owe a lot to the birds and beasts who eat insects but all of them put together kill only a fraction of the number destroyed by spiders. Moreover, unlike some of the other insect eaters, spiders never do the least harm to us or our belongings.

Spiders are not insects, as many people think, nor even nearly related to them. One can tell the difference almost at a glance, for a spider always has eight legs and an insect never more than six.

How many spiders are engaged in this work on our behalf? One authority on spiders made a census of the spiders in a grass field in the south of England, and he estimated that there were more than 2,250,000 in one acre; that is something like 6,000,000 spiders of different kinds on a football pitch. Spiders are busy for at least half the year in killing insects. It is impossible to make more than the wildest guess at how many they kill, but they are hungry creatures, not content with only three meals a day. It has been estimated that the weight of all the insects destroyed by spiders in Britain in one year would be greater than the total weight of all the human beings in the country.

Spiders are one of the marvels of nature. Their webs are masterpieces of engineering. A spider's web is stronger than it looks. It can be stretched considerably without breaking, and made of a sticky material which traps flying insects. The threads are as fine as a spider's silk but much stronger - human hair is about as strong as spider's silk of the same thickness.

Spiders, then, are our friends. The little we can do to spare them is surely worth doing.

3. Matterhorn Man

Modern alpinists try to climb mountains by a route which will give them good sport, and the more difficult it is, the more highly it is regarded. In the pioneering days, however, this was not the case at all. The early climbers were looking for the easiest way to the top, because the summit was the prize they sought, especially if it had never been attained before. It is true that during their explorations they often faced difficulties and dangers of the most perilous nature, equipped in a manner which would make a modern climber shudder at the thought, but they did not go out of their way to court such excitement. They had a single aim, a solitary goal---the top!

It is hard for us to realize nowadays how difficult it was for the pioneers. Except for one or two places such as Zermatt and Chamonix, which had rapidly become popular, Alpine villages tended to be impoverished settlements cut off from civilization by the high mountains. Such inns as there were were generally dirty and flea - ridden; the food simply local cheese accompanied by bread often twelve months old, all washed down with coarse wine. Often a valley boasted no inn at all, and climbers found shelter wherever they could---sometimes with the local priest (who was usually as poor as his parishioners), sometimes with shepherds or cheese - makers. Invariably the background was the same: dirt and poverty, and very uncomfortable. For men accustomed to eating seven - course dinners and sleeping between fine linen sheets at home, the change to the Alps must have been very hard indeed.

Why, then, did the early climbers put up with such hardships? The answer, I think, is that they were less interested in the sport than in the sense of accomplishment they got from reaching the top. It is true that they took risks, but in those days they had to take risks. They would never have been able to reach the top at all if they had not been prepared to take risks. They were a hardy race, these early climbers. They were not looking for a comfortable life, but for a challenge, and a sense of pride that they could meet that challenge.

Today, of course, things are different. The modern alpinist may be interested in the sport as well as in the sense of accomplishment. He may also be interested in getting a good photograph or in making a film. But he will still be looking for a route which will give him good sport, and he will still be looking for a challenge. He will still be a hardy race, these modern alpinists.

4. Seeing hands

Several cases have been reported in Russia recently of people who can read and detect colours with their fingers, and even see through solid doors and walls. One case concerns an eleven-year-old schoolgirl, Vera Petrova, who has normal vision but who can also perceive things with different parts of her skin, and through solid walls. This ability was first noticed by her father. One day she came into his office and happened to put her hands on the door of a locked safe. Suddenly she asked her father why he kept so many old newspapers locked away there, and even described the way they were done up in bundles. Vera's curious talent was brought to the notice of a scientific research institute in the town of Ulyanovsk, near where she lives, and in April she was given a series of tests by a special commission of the Ministry of Health of the Russian Federal Republic. During these tests she was able to read a newspaper through an opaque screen and, stranger still, by moving her elbow over a child's game of Lotto she was able to describe the figures and colours printed on it; and, in another instance, wearing stockings and slippers, to make out with her foot the outlines and colours of a picture hidden under a carpet. Other experiments showed that her knees and shoulders had a similar sensitivity. During all these tests Vera was blindfolded; and, indeed, except when blindfolded she lacked the ability to perceive things with her skin. It was also found that although she could perceive things with her fingers this ability ceased the moment her hands were wet.

Ernst Weber, a physiologist in Leipzig, was the first to show that people can perceive things through their fingertips as well as they can through their eyes. He found that the smaller the object, the closer it had to be to the eyes for its details to be seen. The same applies to the fingertips. The closer the object is to the fingertips, the larger it seems to be and the more details can be made out. Weber found that when the fingertips were about three inches from an object, the details of the object were as clear as when it was at the normal reading distance of about fourteen inches from the eyes. If the object was moved closer still, the fingertips could no longer make out its details. This shows that the fingertips can perceive objects in the same way as the eyes, but only up to a certain distance.

Vera Petrova's case is a good example of how people can be trained to perceive things in different ways. She was not born with the ability to perceive things with her skin, but she has learned to do so through long practice. Her father started to train her when she was a small child. He would put different objects in front of her and ask her to describe them without looking. At first she could only make out the general shape of the objects, but with more practice she was able to make out more

details. As she grew older, she was able to perceive things with different parts of her skin, and through solid walls. This shows that the ability to perceive things with the skin can be developed through training.

5. Youth

People are always talking about "the problem of youth". If there is one -- which I take leave to doubt -- then it is older people who create it, not the young themselves. Let us get down to fundamentals and agree that the young are after all human beings -- people just like their elders. There is only one difference between an old man and a young one: the young man has a glorious future before him and the old one has a splendid future behind him: and maybe that is where the rub is.

When I was a teenager, I felt that I was just young and uncertain -- that I was a new boy in a huge school, and I would have been very pleased to be regarded as something so interesting as a problem. For one thing, being a problem gives you a certain identity, and that is one of the things the young are busily engaged in seeking.

I find young people exciting. They have an air of freedom, and they have not a dreary commitment to mean ambitions or love of comfort. They are not anxious social climbers, and they have no devotion to material things. All this seems to me to link them with life, and the origins of things. It's as if they were in some sense cosmic beings in violent and lovely contrast to us suburban creatures. All that is in my mind when I meet a young person. He may be conceited, ill-mannered, presumptuous or fatuous, but I do not turn for protection to dreary clichés about respect for elders -- as if mere age were a reason for respect. I accept that we are equals, and I will argue with him, as an equal, if I think he is wrong.

This is what I have learned from my own youth. And I have found that the world is in general agreement with my view of youth. At least, when talking about the young, most people will say that they are hope of the world, and that it is necessary to guide them in the right way. But then, they hope that the young will listen to them, and they believe that they are wiser than the young, which is why they are always talking about "the problem of youth".

6. The sporting spirit

I am always amazed when I hear people saying that sport creates goodwill between the nations, and that if only the common peoples of the world could meet one another at football or cricket, they would have no inclination to meet on the battlefield. Even if one didn't know from concrete examples (the 1936 Olympic Games, for instance) that international sporting contests lead to orgies of hatred, one could deduce it from general principles.

Nearly all the sports practised nowadays are competitive. You play to win, and the game has little meaning unless you do your utmost to win. On the village green, where you pick up sides and no feeling of local patriotism is involved, it is possible to play simply for the fun and exercise: but as soon as the question of prestige arises, as soon as you feel that you and some larger unit will be disgraced if you lose, the most savage combative instincts are aroused. Anyone who has played even in a school football match knows this. At the international level, sport is frankly mimic warfare. But the significant thing is not the behaviour of the players but the attitude of the spectators: and, behind the spectators, of the nations who work themselves into furies over these absurd contests, and seriously believe - at any rate for short periods - that running, jumping and kicking a ball are tests of national virtue.

I was once present at a tug - of - war in which the two teams were so evenly matched that neither could win. The umpire in charge of the match was at his wits' end. Finally, one of the teams, by a superhuman effort, managed to drag the other team over the line. The crowd went wild with joy. This incident left a deep impression on me. I saw that in a world where people are obsessed with winning, the slightest advantage can trigger a violent reaction. It is this spirit, I believe, that underlies the modern Olympics. We are so used to seeing champions crowned and anthems played that we forget the darker side of sport. The Olympics should be a celebration of human achievement, not a battleground for national pride.

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Once the games were over, the stadium emptied and the swarms of spectators dispersed, a curious lull ensued. The nations suddenly remembered that they were supposed to be at peace with each other. They rubbed shoulders at the crowded terminals, and at length they went their separate ways without rancour. Even the teams themselves, as they boarded their respective buses and trains, seemed to have forgotten their enmity. But it was only a momentary lull. In less than an hour's time they would be back at their respective camps, preparing for the next day's play. And so the cycle of hatred and reconciliation continued.

8. Trading Standards

Chickens slaughtered in the United States, claim officials in Brussels, are not fit to grace European tables. No, say the Americans: our fowl are fine, we simply clean them in a different way. These days, it is differences in national regulations, far more than tariffs, that put sand in the wheels of trade between rich countries. It is not just farmers who are complaining. An electric razor that meets the European Union's safety standards must be approved by American testers before it can be sold in the United States, and an American-made dialysis machine needs the EU's okay before it hits the market in Europe.

As it happens, a razor that is safe in Europe is unlikely to electrocute Americans. So, ask businesses on both sides of the Atlantic, why have two lots of tests where one would do? Politicians agree, in principle, so America and the EU have been trying to reach a deal which would eliminate the need to double - test many products. They

hope to finish in time for a trade summit between America and the EU on May 28th. Although negotiators are optimistic, the details are complex enough that they may be hard - pressed to get a deal at all.

Why? One problem is that while both America and the EU have schemes to test products, they have different approaches, different priorities and different timetables. Another factor is that European companies are more squeamish about animal testing. The Americans say that by accepting outside testing, they are losing control of their own trade policies. And then there are the costs. The EU's tests are supposed to be more expensive than America's, but some American companies have to pay for both.

There is no sign that consumers are being short - changed as a result of these trade barriers. Indeed, EU consumers are probably better off, since they are protected from products that may not be safe. And American consumers may be better off, too. Since they are not being bombarded with unsafe products, they may have more time to consider the products that are actually available.

The real problem is that trade barriers are rising, not falling. This is a result of political will. Politicians are under pressure from their voters to be tough on trade. They are also under pressure from business lobbyists who want to keep out foreign competitors. But the biggest factor is that trade barriers are easy to erect, and difficult to dismantle. Once a trade barrier is in place, it is hard to get rid of it. This is because it is difficult to prove that a trade barrier is not necessary. And if a trade barrier is not necessary, then it is illegal under international law. So, politicians are reluctant to remove trade barriers, even when they know that they are not necessary.

So, what can be done? One solution is to have more international cooperation. The World Trade Organization (WTO) could play a more active role in reducing trade barriers. Another solution is to have more transparency. Politicians could be more open about the reasons for erecting trade barriers. And then there is the question of consumer education. Consumers could be better informed about the safety of products. But these solutions are not easy to implement. And in the meantime, trade barriers are rising, not falling.

9. Royal espionage

Alfred the Great acted as his own spy, visiting Danish camps disguised as a minstrel. In those days wandering minstrels were welcome everywhere. They were not fighting men, and their harp was their passport. Alfred had learned many of their ballads in his youth, and could vary his programme with acrobatic tricks and simple conjuring.

While Alfred's little army slowly began to gather at Athelney, the king himself set out to penetrate the camp of Guthrum, the commander of the Danish invaders. These had settled down for the winter at Chippenham: thither Alfred went. He noticed at once that discipline was slack: the Danes had the self - confidence of conquerors, and their security precautions were casual. They lived well, on the proceeds of raids on neighbouring regions. There they collected women as well as food and drink, and a life of ease had made them soft.

Alfred stayed in the camp a week before he returned to Athelney. The force there assembled was trivial compared with the Danish horde. But Alfred had deduced that the Danes were no longer fit for prolonged battle: and that their commissariat had no organization, but depended on irregular raids. So, faced with the Danish advance, he had to prepare to defend the kingdom. He parcelled out the land into small holdings which were given to the great nobles of the realm in fief. In return for a free gift of the land, the noble swore to perform military service. The king retained a large reserve of land in his own hands. By this policy Alfred managed to create a large army out of very little money. And when the Danes, having had their raids, were again assembled in camp preparing for winter, Alfred struck suddenly. He routed them with his little army and chased them back to their ships. The Danes were not to be seen again in England for many years.

The episode could reasonably be called "Royal espionage". For Alfred had done what no spy had ever done before in the annals of espionage - he had stayed in the enemy's camp and returned with valuable information.

10. Silicon Valley

Technology trends may push Silicon Valley back to the future. Carver Mead, a pioneer in integrated circuits and a professor of computer science at the California Institute of Technology, notes there are now workstations that enable engineers to

design, test and produce chips right on their desks, much the way an editor creates a newsletter on a Macintosh. As the time and cost of making a chip drop to a few days and a few hundred dollars, engineers may soon be free to let their imaginations soar without being penalized by expensive failures.

Mead predicts that inventors will be able to perfect powerful customized chips over a weekend at the office - spawning a new generation of garage start - ups and giving the U.S. a jump - start on its foreign rivals in getting new products to market faster. "We've got more garages with smart people", Mead observes. "We really thrive on anarchy."

And on Asians. Already, orientals and Asian - Americans constitute the majority of the engineering staffs at many Valley firms. And Chinese, Indian and Pakistani engineers are graduating in droves from California's colleges. As the heads of next - generation start - ups, these Asian innovators can draw on customs and languages to forge tighter links with key Pacific Rim markets.

For instance, Alex Au, a Stanford Ph.D. from Hong Kong, has set up a Taiwanese factory to challenge Japan's near lock on the memory - chip market. India - born N.Damodar Reddy's tiny California company reopened an AT&T chip plant in Kansas City last year to profit from the rapidly falling prices of chips. Before it becomes a retirement village, Silicon Valley may prove a classroom for building a global business.

11. How to Grow Old

Some old people are oppressed by the fear of death. In the young there is a justification for this feeling. Young men who have reason to fear that they will be killed in battle may justifiably feel bitter in the thought that they have been cheated of the best things that life has to offer. But in an old man who has known human joys and sorrows, and has achieved whatever work it was in him to do, the fear of death is somewhat abject and ignoble. The best way to overcome it - so at least it seems to me - is to make your interests gradually wider and more impersonal, until bit by bit the walls of the ego recede, and your life becomes increasingly merged in the universal life. An individual human existence should be like a river - small at first, narrowly contained within its banks, and rushing passionately past boulders and over waterfalls. Gradually the river grows wider, the banks recede, the waters flow more quietly, and in the end, without any visible break, they become merged in

the sea, and painlessly lose their individual being. The man who, in old age, can see his life in this way, will not suffer from the fear of death, since the things he cares for will continue. And if, with the decay of vitality, weariness increases, the thought of rest will be not unwelcome. I should wish to die while still at work, knowing that others will carry on what I can no longer do, and content in the thought that what was possible has been done.

Some scientists in the field of artificial intelligence seem to think that a breakthrough in creating true artificial intelligence will be made within the next few decades. I am not so sure. I think it will be much longer before we see machines that can truly think like humans. True artificial intelligence would have to be able to understand the world in the same way that humans do, and this is a very difficult problem. Machines can already do many things that humans can do, but they do not understand what they are doing in the same way that humans do. For example, a computer can play chess very well, but it does not understand the game of chess in the way that a human does. It does not have the same kind of consciousness that a human has. Consciousness is a very difficult concept to define, but it is something that is very important for understanding the nature of intelligence. Without consciousness, it is difficult to say that a machine is truly intelligent.

Another problem with creating true artificial intelligence is that we do not really know how the human brain works. We know a great deal about the structure of the brain, but we do not know how it processes information and creates thoughts. This is another area where much more research is needed. Some scientists think that we will be able to create artificial intelligence by simulating the structure and function of the human brain, but this is also a very difficult task. The human brain is an extremely complex organ, and it is very difficult to simulate its structure and function accurately.

In conclusion, while the idea of creating true artificial intelligence is very exciting, I think it will be a long time before we see machines that can truly think like humans. There are many difficult problems that need to be solved before we can achieve this goal.

12. Banking and the Economy

Banks are closely concerned with the flow of money into and out of the economy. They often co-operate with governments in efforts to stabilize economies and to prevent inflation. They are specialists in the business of providing capital, and in allocating funds on credit. Banks originated as places to which people took their valuables for safe-keeping, but today the great banks of the world have many functions in addition to acting as guardians of valuable private possessions.

One of the most important of these is regular participation in the foreign exchange market. In this market, banks buy and sell foreign currencies on a continual basis, so that an importer can purchase a shipment of goods from another country and pay for it in the currency of that country. The bank's selling price for a particular currency is always slightly higher than its buying price for the same currency, and the difference represents the bank's profit on the transaction.

Banks also provide a service for exporters. When an exporter arranges a shipment of goods to another country, he may need to finance the operation until he receives payment from the importer. Banks can provide loans to exporters at relatively low rates of interest, and they can also provide insurance against the risk of non-payment by the importer.

In addition to these international functions, banks also play an important role in the domestic economy. They are a major source of loans for businesses and individuals, and they help to allocate capital within the economy. They also play a role in the regulation of the money supply, through their ability to create and destroy money in the form of deposits and loans.

Finally, banks are important because they provide a convenient means of payment. People can use bank cheques, credit cards, or debit cards to pay for goods and services, and this makes economic transactions much easier and more efficient.

13. The Search for Oil

The deepest holes of all are made for oil, and they go down to as much as 25,000 feet. But we do not need to send men down to get oil out, as we must with other mineral deposits. The holes are only borings, less than a foot in diameter. My particular experience is largely in oil, and the search for oil has done more to improve deep drilling than any other mining activity. When it has been decided

where we are going to drill, we put up at the surface an oil derrick. It has to be tall because it is like a giant block and tackle, and we have to lower into the ground and haul out of the ground great lengths of drill pipe which are rotated by an engine at the top and are fitted with a cutting bit at the bottom.

There is a lot of luck in drilling for oil. The drill may just miss the oil although it is near; on the other hand, it may strike oil at a fairly high level. When the drill goes down, it brings up soil. The samples of soil from various depths are examined for traces of oil. If they are disappointed at one place, the drillers go to another. Great sums of money have been spent, for example in the deserts of Egypt, in 'prospecting' for oil. Sometimes little is found. When we buy a few gallons of petrol for our cars, we pay not only the cost of the petrol, but also part of the cost of the search that is always going on.

When the crude oil is obtained from the field, it is taken to the refineries to be treated. The commonest form of treatment is heating. When the oil is heated, the first vapours to rise are cooled and become the finest petrol. Petrol has a low boiling point; if a little is poured into the hand, it soon evaporates. The next lot of vapours are cooled and become paraffin. What remains is heavy oil that is used as fuel.

14. The Butterfly Effect

Beyond two or three days, the world's best weather forecasts are speculative, and beyond six or seven they are worthless. The Butterfly Effect is the reason. For small pieces of weather -- and to a global forecaster, small can mean thunderstorms and blizzards -- any prediction deteriorates rapidly. Errors and uncertainties multiply, cascading upward through a chain of turbulent features, from dust devils and squalls up to continent - size eddies that only satellites can see. The modern weather models work with a grid of points of the order of sixty miles apart, and even so, some starting data has to be guessed, since ground stations and satellites cannot see everywhere. But suppose the earth could be covered with sensors spaced one foot apart, rising at one - foot intervals all the way to the top of the atmosphere. Suppose every sensor gives perfectly accurate readings of temperature, pressure, humidity, and any other quantity a meteorologist would want. Precisely at noon an infinitely powerful computer takes all the data and calculates what will happen at each point at 12.01, then 12.02, then 12.03... The computer will still be unable to predict whether Princeton, New Jersey, will have sun or rain on a day one month away. At noon the spaces between the sensors will hide fluctuations that the computer will not know

about, tiny variations in the flow of the atmosphere that will interact with other fluctuations and create a turbulence that will spread rapidly and unpredictably. In a very short time, the computer will lose track of where the turbulence is going, and even more important, it will not know if a new disturbance has occurred somewhere else. Even with the most powerful computers, there will always be a degree of uncertainty about whether the weather will change or not, and by how much. This is the essence of the Butterfly Effect. The name comes from an example by the mathematician Edward Lorenz. He was thinking about how small changes in initial conditions can lead to large - scale effects. He imagined a butterfly flapping its wings in Brazil and then considered what would happen. "Could it be," he wondered, "that a single flap of a butterfly's wings could cause a hurricane in Texas?" His answer was yes, in principle. A butterfly flaps its wings and it causes a tiny change in the air pressure. That change in air pressure causes a slightly different pattern of air movement. That slightly different pattern of air movement causes another slightly different pattern, and so on. By the time the air movement has spread across the Atlantic Ocean, the change has become large enough to cause a hurricane in Texas. The Butterfly Effect is not just a theoretical concept. It has practical implications for weather forecasting, climate modelling, and many other fields. For example, in climate modelling, we need to understand how small changes in the Earth's climate system can lead to large - scale changes in the global climate. If we do not understand the Butterfly Effect, we may make incorrect predictions about the future of the Earth's climate. In addition to weather forecasting and climate modelling, the Butterfly Effect has implications for many other fields. For example, in economics, small changes in interest rates or exchange rates can lead to large - scale changes in the economy. In ecology, small changes in the environment can lead to large - scale changes in the ecosystem. In social science, small changes in public opinion or social behavior can lead to large - scale changes in society. The Butterfly Effect is a reminder that the world is a complex and interconnected place, and that small changes can have large - scale effects.

15. Secrecy in industry

Two factors weigh heavily against the effectiveness of scientific research in industry. One is the general atmosphere of secrecy in which it is carried out, the other the lack of freedom of the individual research worker. In so far as any inquiry is a secret one, it naturally limits all those engaged in carrying it out from effective contact with their fellow scientists either in other countries or in universities, or

even, often enough, in other departments of the same firm. The degree of secrecy naturally varies considerably. Some of the bigger firms are engaged in researches which are of such general and fundamental nature that it is a positive advantage to them not to keep them secret. Yet a great many processes depending on such research are sought for with complete secrecy until the stage at which patents can be taken out. Even more processes are never patented at all but kept as secret processes. This applies particularly to chemical industries, where chance discoveries play a much larger part than they do in physical and mechanical industries. Sometimes the secrecy goes to such an extent that the whole nature of the research cannot be mentioned. Many firms, for example, have great difficulty in obtaining technical or scientific books from libraries because they are unwilling to have their names entered as having taken out such and such a book, for fear the agents of other firms should be able to trace the kind of research they are likely to be undertaking.

J. B. S. Haldane once said that he preferred the society of scientists, who did not care whether their ideas were stolen, because he could do more with their ideas than they could do themselves. He was doubtless right, in so far as his own work was concerned; but it may be questioned whether it is always good for the community that a scientist should "do more" than his fellows. It is for such reasons that the case for having a scientific directorate, whose main concern should be the interests of science as a whole, becomes cogent. Such a body would need to be large enough to carry considerable authority, but not so large as to be unmanageable. It would also need to be composed of persons of very different types of scientific interests, so that the board could really be representative of all the different interests in science. There would also need to be a sufficient number of research workers in reserve so that the board could pass on to them any ideas which are likely to be of immediate value. It would be their task to test out all such ideas, and to make what seems best of them. It would also be the task of this body to arrange for the training of the research workers of the future, in so far as this can be done within the firm.

16. The Search for the Earth's Minerals

The earth is a large, rocky planet where there is little free oxygen or water on the surface. However, beneath the surface there is a great deal of activity. Heat from the interior of the earth melts rocks and creates magma. This magma rises to the surface through cracks in the rocks, and when it cools, it forms new rocks.

Minerals are substances that are formed in this way. They are the building blocks of

rocks. There are over 3,000 different minerals, but only about 20 are common. These common minerals are found in most rocks.

The search for minerals is an important activity. Minerals are used in many different ways. Some minerals, such as gold and silver, are used for making jewellery. Others, such as iron and copper, are used for making tools and machines. Minerals are also used in building materials, such as cement and bricks.

Geologists are scientists who study the earth. They use many different methods to find minerals. One method is to study the rocks on the surface. Geologists can tell a lot about the minerals that are likely to be found beneath the surface by looking at the rocks on the surface. Another method is to use special instruments to detect the presence of minerals. These instruments can measure the magnetic field, gravity, or electrical conductivity of the rocks.

Once a likely area for minerals has been found, geologists will drill holes to take samples of the rocks. These samples will be analyzed in a laboratory to find out what minerals are present. If minerals are found, mining operations may begin.

17. The Greatest Bridge in the World

Verrazano, an Italian about whom little is known, sailed into New York Harbour in 1524 and named it Angouleme. He described it as 'a very agreeable situation located within two small hills in the midst of which flowed a great river.'. Though Verrazano is by no means considered to be a great explorer, his name will probably remain immortal, for on November 21st, 1964, the longest suspension bridge in the world was named after him.

The Verrazano Bridge, which was designed by Othmar Ammann, joins Brooklyn to Staten Island. It has a span of 4,260 feet. The bridge is so long that the shape of the earth had to be taken into account by its designer. Two great towers support four huge cables. The towers are built on immense underwater platforms made of steel and concrete. The platforms extend to a depth of over 100 feet under the sea. These alone took sixteen months to build. Above the surface of the water, the towers rise to a height of nearly 700 feet. They support the cables from which the bridge has been suspended. Each of the four cables contains 26,108 lengths of wire. It has been estimated that if the bridge were packed with cars, it would still only be carrying a third of its total capacity. However, size and strength are not the only important things about this bridge. Despite its immensity, it is both simple and elegant,

fulfilling its designer's dream to create 'an enormous object drawn as faintly as possible'.

18. Porpoises

There has long been a superstition among mariners that porpoises will save drowning men by pushing them to the surface, or protect them from sharks by surrounding them in defensive formation. Marine Studio biologists have pointed out that, however intelligent they may be, it is probably a mistake to credit dolphins with any motive of life - saving. On the occasions when they have pushed to shore an unconscious human being they have much more likely done it out of curiosity or for sport, as in riding the bow waves of a ship. In 1928 some porpoises were photographed working like beavers to push ashore a waterlogged mattress. If, as has been reported, they have protected humans from sharks, it may have been because curiosity attracted them and because the scent of a possible meal attracted the sharks. Porpoises and sharks are natural enemies. It is possible that upon such an occasion a battle ensued, with the sharks being driven away or killed.

Whether it be bird, fish or beast, the porpoise is intrigued with anything that is alive. They are constantly after the turtles, who peacefully submit to all sorts of indignities. One young calf especially enjoyed raising a turtle to the surface with his snout and then shoving him across the tank like an aquaplane. Almost any day a young porpoise may be seen trying to turn a 300 - pound sea turtle over by sticking his snout under the edge of his shell and pushing up for dear life. This is not easy, and may require two porpoises working together. In another game, as the turtles swim across the oceanarium, the first porpoise swoops down from above and butts his shell with his belly. This knocks the turtle down several feet where another porpoise is waiting to give it another butt. The turtles seem to enjoy it, but perhaps they would not if they could feel the scratches on their shells from the porpoises' teeth. After such a burst of activity they usually take a short rest before they start off again.

A porpoise will follow a ship for hours at a time, leaping out of the water and doing somersaults. There is no evidence that porpoises have a language but they communicate with one another by squeaks, clicks and whistles. It has been suggested that they may be able to communicate with humans through these sounds, but this has not been proven. One theory is that they use these sounds to navigate, by detecting the echoes of their own voices. Another theory is that they use them to

communicate their emotions, such as excitement or fear. Still another theory is that they use them to identify one another, as each porpoise has a unique set of squeaks, clicks and whistles.

19. The Stuff of Dreams

It is fairly clear that the sleeping period must have some function, and because there is so much of it the function would seem to be important. Speculations about its nature have been going on for literally thousands of years, and one odd finding that makes the problem puzzling is that it looks very much as if sleeping is not simply a matter of giving the body a rest. 'Rest', in terms of muscle relaxation and so on, can be achieved by a brief period lying, or even sitting down. The body's tissues are self-repairing and self-restoring to a degree, and function best when more or less continuously active. In fact a basic amount of movement occurs during sleep which is specifically concerned with preventing muscle inactivity. If it is not a question of resting the body, perhaps it is the brain that needs resting? This might be a plausible hypothesis were it not for two factors. First the electroencephalograph (which is simply a device for recording the electrical activity of the brain by attaching electrodes to the scalp) shows that while there is a change in the pattern of activity during sleep, there is no evidence that the total amount of activity is any less. The second factor is more interesting and more fundamental. In 1960 an American psychiatrist named William Dement published experiments dealing with the recording of eye-movements during sleep. He showed that the average individual's sleep cycle is punctuated by peculiar bursts of eye-movements, some slow, some rapid, some in both directions. These periods of eye-movements are called REM sleep (Rapid Eye Movement) periods, and they occur at intervals of about 90 minutes throughout the night with an average duration of about 20 minutes. People woken during these periods of REM sleep generally report that they have been dreaming. When woken at other times they reported no dreams. If one group of people were disturbed from their eye-movement sleep for several nights on end, and another group were disturbed for an equal number of nights but when they were not experiencing eye-movement sleep, the first group began to show some personality disorders while the second group did not. REM sleep seems to be essential for the normal functioning of the brain. REM sleep occurs in both humans and animals. Some animals, such as cats, have large amounts of REM sleep, while others, such as cows, have very little. There is some evidence that the amount of REM sleep is related to the intelligence of the animal. The more intelligent the

animal, the more REM sleep it has. But why should REM sleep be essential for the normal functioning of the brain? One theory is that during REM sleep the brain is 'rehearsing' things that it has learned during the day. Another theory is that REM sleep is a time when the brain is 'clearing' itself of useless information. But neither of these theories has been proved yet. So far we have only been able to say that REM sleep seems to be essential for the normal functioning of the brain, and that the amount of REM sleep is related to the intelligence of the animal. We still do not know what the function of sleep is, or why we need to dream.

20. Snake poison

How it came about that snakes manufactured poison is a mystery. Over the periods their saliva, a mild, digestive juice like our own, was converted into a poison that defies analysis even today. It was not forced upon them by the survival competition; they could have caught and lived on prey without using poison, just as the thousands of non-poisonous snakes still do. Poison to a snake is merely a luxury; it enables it to get its food with very little effort, no more effort than one bite. And why only snakes? Cats, for instance, would be greatly helped; no running fights with large, fierce rats or tussles with grown chickens - the mouse or young chicken goes limply into the cat's mouth.

The snakes' poison is highly modified saliva containing zootoxins which act on the nervous system and blood circulation. It is different in every single kind of snake - from the cobra's for instance which affects the nerves, to the viper's which, on the contrary, affects the blood.

One wonders also why nature, with some snakes, concocted poison of such extreme potency. In the conversion of saliva into poison, one might suppose that a fixed process took place. It did not; some snakes manufactured a poison different in every respect from that of others, as different as arsenic is from strychnine, and having different effects. One poison acts on the nerves, the other on the blood.

The spitting cobra is another case of a snake that has modified its saliva into a poison different in nature from that of other snakes. This snake, instead of biting, spits out a jet of venom which may reach a distance of two feet. It is not very accurate, but it is enough to cause a lot of pain and some blindness if it gets into the eyes. The spitting cobra has little poison. What is this snake's advantage in having a poison that is not very powerful? The answer is that it has a very good aim; it is

almost always successful in hitting its target, which is the eyes of the victim. And why should it spit? There is no obvious reason why it should not bite. The answer is that it has a good aim; it is almost always successful in hitting its target, which is the eyes of the victim. By spitting, it can keep a safe distance from its prey, which is a great advantage in a fight.

21. William S. Hart and the Early "Western" Film

William S. Hart was, perhaps, the greatest of all Western stars, for unlike Gary Cooper and John Wayne he appeared in nothing but Westerns. From 1914 to 1924 he was supreme and unchallenged. It was Hart who created the basic formula of the Western film, and devised the protagonist he played in every film he made, the good - bad man, the accidental - noble outlaw, or the honest - but - framed cowboy, or the sheriff made suspect by vicious gossip; in short, the individual in conflict with himself and his frontier environment.

Hart actually knew something of the old West. He had lived in it as a child when it was already disappearing, and his hero was firmly rooted in his memories and experiences, and in both the history and the mythology of the vanished frontier. And although no period or place in American history has been more absurdly romanticized, myth and reality did join hands in at least one arena, the conflict between the individual and encroaching civilization.

Men accustomed to struggling for survival against the elements and Indians were bewildered by politicians, bankers and businessmen, and unhorsed by fences, laws and alien taboos. Hart's good - bad man was always an outsider, always one of the disinherited, and if he found it necessary to shoot a sheriff or rob a bank along the way, his early audiences found it easy to understand and forgive, especially when it was Hart who, in the end, overcame the attacking Indians or the outlaw gang. Audiences in the second decade of the twentieth century found it pleasant to escape to a time when life, though hard, was relatively simple. We still do; living in a world in which undeclared aggression, war, hypocrisy, chicanery, anarchy and impending doom seem to be the norm, we all want a code to live by.

Carrying a gun in the city is illegal in most countries, but it was not so in the Old West. Hart's audiences knew that they were watching a film about the Old West when they saw a gun on the screen, and they were able to distinguish between the film world and the real world. But most of them, as they watched Hart, were

probably unaware that they were also seeing the creation of a new art form. The Western film has been the most popular genre of American cinema since the early days of the silent era, and it has had a profound influence on the development of cinema around the world.

22. Knowledge and Progress

Why does the idea of progress loom so large in the modern world? Surely because progress of a particular kind is actually taking place around us and is becoming more and more manifest. Although mankind has undergone no general improvement in intelligence or morality, it has made extraordinary progress in the accumulation of knowledge. Knowledge began to increase as soon as the thoughts of one individual could be communicated to another by means of speech. With the invention of writing, a great advance was made, for knowledge could then be not only communicated but also stored. Libraries made education possible, and education in its turn added to libraries: the growth of knowledge followed a kind of compound - interest law, which was greatly enhanced by the invention of printing. All this was comparatively slow until, with the coming of science, the tempo was suddenly raised. Then knowledge began to be accumulated according to a systematic plan. The trickle became a stream; the stream has now become a torrent. Moreover, as soon as new knowledge is acquired, it is now turned to practical account. What is called "modern civilization" is not the result of a balanced development of all man's nature, but of accumulated knowledge applied to practical life. The problem now facing humanity is: What is going to be done with all this knowledge? As is so often pointed out, knowledge is a two - edged weapon which can be used equally for good or evil. It is now being used indifferently for both. Could any spectacle, for instance, be more grimly whimsical than that of gunners using science to shatter men's bodies while, close at hand, surgeons use it to restore them? We have to ask ourselves very seriously what will happen if this two - edged weapon falls into the hands of those who would use it for evil purposes. Newspapers and broadcasters, as well as individuals, now spread that information quickly and widely. Disarmament negotiations in Geneva have been going on for years without accomplishing anything. But suppose we succeed in disarming the atom, our work as moral beings is not yet done. It is a problem that calls for very serious consideration. What is the use of disarming the atom if we do not also disarm the mind? It is not enough to take this weapon out of the hands of the soldiers. We must take it out of the hands of the politicians as well. The more knowledge men have, the more responsible they

should be. It is only when we are very much more intelligent than we are at present that we shall be able to realize all that knowledge implies.

23. Bird flight

No two sorts of birds practise quite the same sort of flight; the varieties are infinite; but two classes may be roughly seen. Any ship that crosses the Pacific is accompanied for many days by the smaller albatross, Which may keep company with the vessel for an hour without visible or more than occasional movement of wing. The currents of air that the walls of the ship direct upwards, as well as in the line of its course, are enough to give the great bird with its immense wings sufficient sustenance and progress. The albatross is the king of the gliders, the class of fliers which harness the air to their purpose, but must yield to its opposition. In the contrary school, the duck is supreme. It comes nearer to the engines with which man has 'conquered' the air, as he boasts. Duck, and like them the pigeons, are endowed with such-like muscles, that are a good part of the weight of the bird, and these will ply the short wings with such irresistible power that they can bore for long distances through an opposing gale before exhaustion follows. Their humbler followers, such as partridges, have a like power of strong propulsion, but soon tire. You may pick them up in utter exhaustion, if wind over the sea has driven them to a long journey. The swallow shares the virtues of both schools in highest measure. It tires not, nor does it boast of its power; but belongs to the air, travelling it may be six thousand miles to and from its northern nesting home, feeding its flown young as it flies, and slipping through a medium that seems to help its passage even when the wind is adverse. Such birds do us good, though we no longer take omens from their flight on this side and that; and even the most superstitious villagers no longer take off their hats to the magpie and wish it good - morning.

When Bleriot crossed the Channel at last, it was in a monoplane, an appellation which is now indifferently applied to both the single and double - winged machines, because such machines have by now been so far developed that the initial distinction has no longer any real importance. There is no special branch of standard English for piloting airplanes; still the lingo is so different from that of everyday life that the characters in a play or film have to be made to use some easily recognizable jargon if they are to represent pilots on the stage or screen. So the monoplane became "the thing" with the flying men, a clumsy - looking contrivance of wood and wire and cloth, with something not unlike a box - kite tied in front of it; and so it remained for

many years. The word 'aeroplane' was usurped by the newcomers in exactly the same way as the word 'automobile' was usurped by the manufacturers of motor - cars. In England at least, a motor - car was originally a carriage without horses, and the name stuck, even when the horses had been replaced by an engine. The aeroplane, too, at first was an 'air - plane', a structure built to plane in the air, not just to fly as a bird does, or as an insect does, but to glide on a plane, which means, in practice, to float on an air - current, exactly as a sled glides on a snow - current. But the newcomers called their machines 'aeroplanes', and the name has stuck, just as the name 'automobile' has stuck in America. In France, of course, the word 'avion' has always been used, and in Germany the word 'Flugzeug'.

24. Beauty

A young man sees a sunset and, unable to understand or to express the emotion that it rouses in him, concludes that it must be the gateway to a world that lies beyond. It is difficult for any of us in moments of intense aesthetic experience to resist the suggestion that we are catching a glimpse of a light that shines down to us from a different realm of existence, different and, because the experience is intensely moving, in some way higher. And, though the gleams blind and dazzle, yet do they convey a hint of beauty and serenity greater than we have known or imagined. Greater too than we can describe; for language, which was invented to convey the meanings of this world, cannot readily be fitted to the uses of another.

That all great art has this power of suggesting a world beyond is undeniable. In some moods, Nature shares it. There is no sky in June so blue that it does not point forward to a bluer, no sunset so beautiful that it does not waken the vision of a greater beauty, a vision which passes before it is fully glimpsed, and in passing leaves an indefinable longing and regret. But, if this world is not merely a bad joke, life a vulgar flare amid the cool radiance of the cosmos, and existence an empty laugh braying across the mysteries; if these intimations of a something behind and beyond are not evil humour born of indigestion, or whimsies sent by the devil to mock and madden us, if, in a word, beauty means something, yet we must not seek to interpret the meaning. If we glimpse the unutterable, it is unwise to try to utter it, nor should we seek to invest with significance that which we cannot grasp. Beauty in terms of our human meanings is meaningless.

Beauty is not a need but an ecstasy. It is not a mouth thirsting nor an empty hand stretched forth, but rather a heart enflamed and a soul enchanted. It is not the image

you would see nor the song you would hear, but rather an image you see though you close your eyes and a song you hear though you shut your ears. It is not the sap within the leaf, nor the dove upon the bough, but rather the mistral to come, the storm to be weathered. It is not a matter of satisfying simple needs, but rather of fulfilling the highest aspirations of the human spirit.

Beauty is an ecstasy; it is as simple as hunger. There is really nothing to be said about it. It is like the perfume of a flower: you can smell it and that is all. It is a common property of all great art, and one that differentiates great art from merely good art. The more we try to explain it in terms of its why and how, the more it eludes us; yet we know when we have met it, and we know when we have missed it. The best we can do is to describe it, to try to put it into words, but then it is no longer beauty. It is like trying to put your finger on the wind. It is always beyond our grasp, and that is why it is beautiful.

25. Non-auditory Effects of Noise

Many people in industry and the Services, who have practical experience of noise, regard any investigation of this question as a waste of time; they are not prepared even to admit the possibility that noise affects people. On the other hand, those who dislike noise will sometimes use most inadequate evidence to support their pleas for a quieter society. This is a pity, because noise abatement really is a good cause, and it is likely to be discredited if it gets to be associated with bad science. One allegation often made is that noise produces mental illness. A recent article in a weekly newspaper, for instance, was headed with a striking illustration of a lady in a state of considerable distress, with the caption 'She was yet another victim, reduced to a screaming wreck'. On turning eagerly to the text, one learns that the lady was a typist who found the sound of office typewriters worried her more and more until eventually she had to go into a mental hospital. Now the snag in this sort of anecdote is of course that one cannot distinguish cause and effect. Was it the noise, perhaps, that made the woman ill? Or was it the fact that she was already ill that caused her to be hypersensitive to noise? Another patient might equally well complain that her neighbours were combining to slander her and persecute her, and yet one might be cautious about believing this statement. What is needed in the case of noise is a study of large numbers of people living under noisy conditions, to discover whether they are mentally ill more often than other people are. The United States Navy, for some years, has been conducting an experiment along these very lines. They have in

view a new weapon that would produce a very loud sound and wondered whether the noise could be used as a weapon of war. So they are now studying the effects of a very loud noise on a large number of people. For this purpose they have set up a colony of human guinea pigs on an island in the Pacific. They have been studying the effects of the noise on these people for several months now. One result of the study has been to show that people do not become mentally ill as a result of noise, but they do become very irritable. There is, in fact, a growing body of evidence to suggest that noise is a contributory factor in a number of diseases, but not necessarily the cause. Another effect of noise is that it reduces efficiency. There are many cases on record of people who, by some extraordinary good luck, have been able to work in the midst of noise without being distracted. But the number of such people is small. Now the reason why noise reduces efficiency is that it distracts people. It makes them think about the noise instead of about their work. For example, a man working in a factory where there is a great deal of noise will be thinking about the noise all the time, and this will make him less efficient. Noise also has a harmful effect on people's sleep. It is a common experience that people who live in noisy environments are likely to have bad sleep. They may not be able to fall asleep at all, or they may be woken up several times during the night. This is because noise disturbs their normal sleep pattern. In conclusion, noise has a number of non - auditory effects on people, and these effects are important and should be taken into account.

26. The past life of the earth

It is animals and plants which lived in or near water whose remains are most likely to be preserved, for one of the necessary conditions of preservation is quick burial, and it is only in the seas and rivers, and sometimes lakes, where mud and silt have been continuously deposited, that bodies and the like can be rapidly covered over and preserved.

But even in the most favourable circumstances only a small fraction of the creatures that die are preserved in this way before decay sets in or, even more likely, before scavengers eat them. After all, all living creatures live by feeding on something else, whether it be plant or animal, dead or alive, and it is only by chance that such a fate is avoided. The remains of plants and animals that lived on land are much more rarely preserved, for there is seldom anything to cover them over. When you think of the innumerable birds that one sees flying about, not to mention the equally

numerous small animals like field mice and voles which you do not see, it is very rarely that one comes across a dead body, except, of course, on the roads. They decompose and are quickly destroyed by the weather or eaten by some other creature.

It is almost always due to some very special circumstances that traces of land animals survive, as by falling into inaccessible caves, or into an ice - crevasse, like the Siberian mammoths, when the whole animal is sometimes preserved, as in a refrigerator. This is what happened to the famous Beresovka mammoth which was found preserved and in good condition. In his mouth were the remains of fir - trees - the last meal that he had before he fell into the crevasse some 10,000 years ago. The mammoth has now been restored in the Museum of Zoology in St. Petersburg.

Other animals were trapped in tar pits, like the elephants, sabre - toothed cats, and numerous other creatures that are found at Rancho La Brea, near Los Angeles. Apparently what happened was that water collected on these tar pits, and the animals came to drink. Once they were in the tar, they were stuck fast, and they eventually died there. As the tar pits were gradually filled up by debris, the remains of the animals were buried deeper and deeper, and so were preserved.

There is one fairly common event that sometimes leads to the preservation of land - animal remains, and that is when the animals die in a river or a lake. This may seem a strange statement, but in fact the water in a river or a lake is more likely to be alkaline than acid, and so the bones are more likely to be preserved in such a water. But, even so, the bones of the animals are very likely to be scattered by scavengers and other agents of decay, and only a small fraction of them are likely to be preserved.

One of the most remarkable preservations of land - animal remains has been discovered on the island of Flores in Indonesia. There, on a ledge of rock about 200 metres above sea - level, an almost complete skeleton of a *Homo floresiensis* was found. The skeleton was so small that it was first thought to be that of a child. But when the bones were analysed, it was discovered that they belonged to an adult. The *Homo floresiensis* was a very small human - like creature that lived about 18,000 years ago. It was only about one metre tall, and its brain was only about 400 cubic centimetres, which is about one - third the size of the brain of a modern human. The discovery of the *Homo floresiensis* was a great surprise, for it was thought that all humans had evolved into the modern form long ago. But the discovery of this small human - like creature shows that evolution can take different paths in different parts of the world.

27. The 'Vasa'

From the seventeenth - century empire of Sweden, the story of a galleon that sank at the start of her maiden voyage in 1628 must be one of the strangest tales of the sea. For nearly three and a half centuries she lay at the bottom of Stockholm harbour until her discovery in 1956. This was the Vasa, royal flagship of the great imperial fleet.

King Gustavus Adolphus, 'The Northern Hurricane', then at the height of his military success in the Thirty Years' War, had dictated her measurements and armament. Triple gun - decks mounted sixty - four bronze cannon. She was intended to play a leading role in the growing might of Sweden.

As she was prepared for her maiden voyage on August 10, 1628, Stockholm was in a ferment. From the Skeppsbron and surrounding islands the people watched this thing of beauty begin to spread her sails and catch the wind. They had laboured for three years to produce this floating work of art; she was more richly carved and ornamented than any previous ship. The high sterncastle was a riot of carved gods, demons, knights, kings, warriors, mermaids, cherubs; and zoomorphic animal shapes ablaze with red and gold and blue, symbols of courage, power, and cruelty, were portrayed to stir the imaginations of the superstitious sailors of the day.

Then the cannons of the anchored warships thundered a salute as the Vasa moved slowly out to sea. She was a moving sight indeed as the morning sun shone on her sails, turning them to gold. As she gained speed, the wind became too strong for her sails, and the mast snapped. Then she lurched sideways and sank in less than a minute.

More than a thousand people lost their lives in the accident; most of them were women and children, who had been on board to enjoy the voyage. The Vasa was the first modern warship built from the keel up with a triple - gun - deck, and she was also the last of her kind. Her sinking was not the result of her being rammed by another vessel, or of her being caught in a storm. It was the result of her own structural weaknesses. The Vasa was built too tall for her length, and she was too top - heavy. Her builders had violated several of the rules of shipbuilding. They had made her too wide for her length, and they had made her sterncastle too high. They had also made her gun - decks too heavy, and her keel too light. All these factors combined to make her unstable in the water. In 1961, the Vasa was salvaged from the harbour bottom, and she is now on display in a museum in Stockholm.

28. Patients and Doctors

This is a sceptical age, but although our faith in many of the things in which our forefathers fervently believed has weakened, our confidence in the curative properties of the bottle of medicine remains the same as theirs. This modern faith in medicines is proved by the fact that the annual drug bill of the Health Services is mounting to astronomical figures and shows no signs at all of ceasing to rise. The majority of the patients attending the medical out-patients departments of our hospitals feel that they have not received adequate treatment unless they are able to carry home with them some tangible remedy in the shape of a bottle of medicine, a box of pills, or a small jar of ointment, and the doctor in charge of the department is only too ready to provide them with these requirements.

There is no quicker method of disposing of patients than by giving them what they are asking for, and since most medical men in the Health Services are overworked and have little time for offering time - consuming and little - appreciated advice on such subjects as diet, right living, and the need for abandoning bad habits etc., the bottle, the box, and the jar are almost always granted them. It is rare for a medical man to give a talk without mentioning the drug companies that finance his research. The more cynical of his profession will even go so far as to claim that "Half of what we are taught about medicine is wrong."

Most doctors, however, still believe that medicine is a science, and they are not prepared to admit that the drugs they prescribe are little more than placebos. They feel that they are being honest when they tell patients that a certain drug may be helpful, but they cannot be certain that it will be. They are also not prepared to admit that the huge sums of money they receive from the drug companies for research are a form of bribery. They believe that their research is for the good of the public and that they are justified in receiving the money.

Few doctors are willing to admit that they are "pill - pushers" and that they prescribe drugs for financial reasons rather than for medical ones. They are afraid that if they do so, they will lose their patients' confidence and that they will no longer be respected as members of a noble profession.

29. The hovercraft

Many strange new means of transport have been developed in our century, the strangest of them being perhaps the hovercraft. In 1953, a former electronics engineer in his fifties, Christopher Cockerell, who had turned to boat - building on the Norfolk Broads, suggested an idea on which he had been working for many years to the British government. It was the idea of supporting a craft on a 'pad', or cushion, of low - pressure air, ringed with a curtain of higher pressure air. Ever since, people have had difficulty in deciding whether the craft should be ranged among ships, planes, or land vehicles - for it is something in between a boat and an aircraft. As a shipbuilder, Cockerell was trying to find a solution to the problem of the wave resistance which wastes a good deal of a surface ship's power and limits its speed. His answer was to lift the vessel out of the water by making it ride on a cushion of air, no more than one or two feet thick. This is done by a great number of ring - shaped air jets on the bottom of the craft. It 'flies', therefore, but it cannot fly higher - its action depends on the surface, water or ground, over which it rides.

The first tests on the Solent in 1959 caused a sensation. The hovercraft travelled first over the water, then mounted the beach, climbed up the dunes, and sat down on a road. Later it crossed the Channel, riding smoothly over the waves, which presented no problem.

Since that time, various types of hovercraft have been developed and some of them have entered regular service on both land and water. The hovercraft is particularly useful in large areas with poor communications such as Africa or Australia; it can become a 'flying fruit - bowl', carrying bananas from the plantations to the ports; giant hovercraft liners could span the Atlantic; and the railway of the future may well be the 'hovertrain', riding on its air cushion over a single rail, which it never touches, at speeds up to 300 m.p.h. - the possibilities appear unlimited.

30. How Animals Migrate

Animal migration, one of the most interesting but least understood biological phenomena, actually refers to the seasonal movement of all or part of an animal population to and from a given area. Familiar migrants include many birds; hoofed animals, especially in East Africa and in the Arctic tundra; bats; whales and porpoises; seals; and fishes, such as salmon.

Migration in some cases is obligatory, and in others facultative. Close and careful study of migratory animals indicates that migratory behavior varies in its adaptability to environmental changes. This variability in migratory behavior has led some scientists to question whether the concept of migration is valid. Certainly the description applied to some animals is difficult to reconcile with the description applied to others. For example, migratory behavior has been described as "traveling some distance in search of a new habitat" and as "a regular, annual movement between two habitats".

An example of facultative migration is the arctic fox. On the Aleutian Islands, which are located at the western extremity of the Alaskan Peninsula, the fox is sedentary and does not migrate, since there is a relatively stable and abundant food supply on those islands. But in some other parts of the Arctic, the food supply is seasonally limited, and arctic foxes may travel long distances in search of food. This type of movement between different habitats for the purpose of exploiting food resources may be termed facultative migration.

Another example of facultative migration is the large North American deer, or wapiti. In the Rocky Mountains, wapiti migrate seasonally from high - altitude summer ranges to the lower valleys in winter. However, when food is plentiful in the highlands, wapiti may not migrate at all or may migrate only short distances to nearby valleys. Thus, wapiti behavior varies in its adaptability to environmental changes.

The term "obligatory migration" implies that an animal must migrate. One example of obligatory migration is the Atlantic salmon. These fish are born in freshwater streams, and they spend the first few years of their lives in those streams. After that, they migrate to the ocean, where they live for several years. When they reach sexual maturity, they return to their natal streams to spawn. If they are prevented from migrating, they will not reproduce. Another example of obligatory migration is the monarch butterfly. These butterflies are born in North America, and they migrate south to Mexico for the winter. If they are prevented from migrating, they will die.

The reasons for migration are complex. Some animals migrate to find food, while others migrate to find a suitable place to breed. Still others migrate to avoid harsh weather conditions. In general, migration is a strategy that animals use to increase their chances of survival and reproduction.

31. The sculptor speaks

Appreciation of sculpture depends upon the ability to respond to form in three dimensions. That is perhaps why sculpture has been described as the most difficult of all arts; certainly it is more difficult than the arts which involve appreciation of flat forms, shape in only two dimensions. Many more people are 'form-blind' than colour-blind. The child learning to see, first distinguishes only two - dimensional shape; it cannot judge distances, depths. Later, for its personal safety and practical needs, it has to develop (partly by means of touch) the ability to judge roughly three - dimensional distances. But having satisfied the requirements of practical necessity, most people go no further. Though they may attain considerable accuracy in the perception of flat form, they do not make the further intellectual and emotional effort needed to comprehend form in its full spatial existence.

This is what the sculptor must do. He must strive continually to think of, and use, form in its full spatial completeness. He gets the solid shape, as it were, inside his head - he thinks of it, whatever its size, as if he were holding it completely enclosed in the hollow of his hand. He mentally visualizes a complex form from all round itself; he knows while he looks at one side what the other side is like; he identifies himself with its centre of gravity, its mass, its weight; he realizes its volume, as the space that the shape displaces in the air.

And the sensitive observer of sculpture must also learn to feel shape simply as shape, not as description or reminiscence. He must, for example, perceive an egg as a simple single solid shape, quite apart from its significance as food, or from the literary idea that it will become a bird. And so with solids such as a shell, a nut, a plum, a pear, a tadpole, a mushroom, a mountain peak, a kidney, a carrot, a tree - trunk, a bird's beak, a cloud, a flower. From these he can go on to appreciate more complex forms of combinations of several forms.

The story of the discovery of Troy by Heinrich Schliemann is a good example of the fact that the recognition of the form of an object may be quite independent of its significance. Schliemann, as a child, had heard the story of the destruction of Troy from his father. He became obsessed with the idea that he would find the site of ancient Troy. Years later, when he had made a fortune as a merchant in Russia, he set out on his quest. Guided by the description in Homer's Iliad, he dug at a site in modern Turkey which he thought was the location of Troy. After many years of fruitless digging, he finally found the ruins of a city which he believed was Troy. But what he had really found was a city which had been built on the site of Troy long after the Trojan War. The significance of the discovery was that it showed that the form of the city could be recognized even when its significance had been

completely forgotten.

Another example of the independence of form is to be found in the work of the American sculptor Alexander Calder. Calder was famous for his mobiles, which are sculptures that move in the air. Calder's mobiles are made up of simple geometric shapes such as circles, squares, triangles, and rods. These shapes are joined together by wires or rods so that they can move freely in the air. The significance of Calder's mobiles is not in their description of anything in particular, but in their form. They are a celebration of form in movement, of the way in which simple geometric shapes can be combined to create complex and beautiful forms in motion.

32. Galileo Reborn

In his own lifetime Galileo was the centre of violent controversy; but the scientific dust has long since settled, and today we can see even his famous clash with the Inquisition in something like its proper perspective. But, in contrast, it is only in modern times that Galileo has become a problem child for historians of science.

The old view of Galileo was delightfully uncomplicated. He was, above all, a man who experimented: who despised the prejudices and book learning of the Aristotelians, who put his questions to nature instead of to the ancients, and who drew his conclusions fearlessly. He had been the first to turn a telescope to the sky, and he had seen there evidence enough to overthrow Aristotle and Ptolemy together. He was the man who climbed the Leaning Tower of Pisa and dropped various weights from the top, who rolled balls down inclined planes, and then generalized the results of his many experiments into the famous law of free fall.

But a closer study of the evidence, supported by a deeper sense of the period, and particularly by a new consciousness of the philosophical underpinning of seventeenth - century science, has profoundly modified this view of Galileo. Today, although the old Galileo lives on in many popular writings, among historians of science a new and more sophisticated picture has emerged. At the same time, our sympathy for Galileo's opponents has grown. His telescopic observations are justly immortal; they aroused great interest at the time, they had important theoretical consequences, and they provided a striking demonstration of the potentialities hidden in instruments. But can we blame those who looked and failed to see what Galileo saw, if we remember that to use a telescope at the end of the sixteenth century was like playing a modern violin for the first time? Was the philosopher

who refused to look through Galileo's telescope more culpable than those who alleged that the spiral nebulae observed by Lord Rosse's great telescope in the eighteen - forties were scratches left by the grinder? We can perhaps forgive those who said that the moons of Jupiter were produced by Galileo's spy - glass if we recall that in his day, as for long afterwards, curved glass was the popular contrivance for producing not truth but illusion, untruth; and if we recall that the concept of an external world was not so much a real concept as a psychological necessity in the minds of seventeenth - century philosophers.

The case of Galileo is sometimes misused to illustrate the thesis that science progresses through the conflict of ideas. But this misrepresents the nature of scientific discovery. The real hero of the story is the slow accretion of the body of knowledge which we call science, and of which Galileo became one of the founders. The most important single aspect of Galileo's work may have been his demonstration of how fundamental questions about the nature of the world could be answered by the use of instruments. Whether his own methods were completely scientific is open to debate; but that he did have a method is beyond dispute. His method was to make hypotheses, let them stand the test of experiment, and then generalize the results. He was a pioneer in the use of scientific method, which is why we remember him today as one of the great scientists.

33. Education

Education is one of the key words of our time. A man without an education, many of us believe, is an unfortunate victim of adverse circumstances, deprived of one of the greatest twentieth - century opportunities. Convinced of the importance of education, modern states 'invest' in institutions of learning to get back 'interest' in the form of a large group of enlightened young men and women who are potential leaders. Education, with its cycles of instruction so carefully worked out, punctuated by textbooks - those purchasable wells of wisdom - what would civilization be like without its benefits?

So much is certain: that we would have doctors and preachers, lawyers and defendants, marriages and births - but our spiritual outlook would be different. We would lay less stress on 'facts and figures' and more on a good memory, on applied psychology, and on the capacity of a man to get along with his fellow - citizens. If our educational system were fashioned after its bookless past we would have the most democratic form of 'college' imaginable. Among tribal people all knowledge

inherited by tradition is shared by all; it is taught to every member of the tribe so that in this respect everybody is equally equipped for life.

It is the ideal condition of the 'equal start' which only our most progressive forms of modern education try to regain. In primitive cultures the obligation to seek and to receive the traditional instruction is binding to all. There are no 'illiterates' - if the term can be applied to peoples without a script - while our own compulsory school attendance became law in Germany in 1642, in France in 1806, and in England in 1876, and is still non-existent in a number of 'civilized' nations. This shows how long it was before we deemed it necessary to make sure that all our children could share in the knowledge accumulated by the 'happy few' during the past centuries.

Education in the wilderness is not a matter of monetary means. All are entitled to an equal start. There is none of the hurry which, in our society, often hampers the full development of a growing personality. There is no fixed programme, no discrimination between one pupil and another in the matter of talents and abilities. At the same as it is true that all pupils are equal in the wilderness, it is also true that all pupils are different. No two persons are the same in terms of abilities, talents, and interests. But in our educational system, all pupils are measured by a single standard - that of scholastic ability. This is the fallacy of the 'equal start' in our schools. The fact that all pupils are different means that some will learn more quickly than others, some will need more practice than others, some will be more interested in certain subjects than others. But in our schools, all pupils are given the same curriculum, the same textbooks, the same methods of instruction, and the same tests. This is the fallacy of the 'equal start' in our schools.

We may say that, on the whole, the 'equal start' in our schools is a fallacy. But we must also recognize that the fallacy has a certain amount of truth in it. In our modern society, scholastic ability is an important factor in determining a person's success in life. A person with a high scholastic ability is more likely to get a good job, to earn a high salary, to have a high social status, and to be respected by others. But we must also recognize that scholastic ability is not the only factor in determining a person's success in life. There are other factors such as personal qualities, social skills, and work experience. In our modern society, a person with a high scholastic ability but without good personal qualities, social skills, or work experience is not likely to be successful in life. We must also recognize that in our modern society, education is not only a matter of scholastic ability. Education is also a matter of personal qualities, social skills, and work experience. In our modern society, a person who has received a good education is not only a person with a high scholastic ability but also a person with good personal qualities, social skills, and work experience.

34. Adolescence

Parents are often upset when their children praise the homes of their friends and regard it as a slur on their own cooking, or cleaning, or furniture, and often are foolish enough to let the adolescents see that they are annoyed. They may even accuse them of disloyalty, or make some spiteful remark about the friends' parents. Such a loss of dignity and descent into childish behaviour on the part of the adults deeply shocks the adolescents, and makes them resolve that in future they will not talk to their parents about the places or people they visit. Before very long the parents will be complaining that the child is so secretive and never tells them anything, but they seldom realize that they have brought this on themselves.

Disillusionment with the parents, however good and adequate they may be both as parents and as individuals, is to some degree inevitable. Most children have such a high ideal of their parents, unless the parents themselves have been unsatisfactory, that it can, hardly hope to stand up to a realistic evaluation. Parents would be greatly surprised and deeply touched if they realized how much belief their children usually have in their character and infallibility, and how much this faith means to a child. If parents were prepared for this adolescent reaction, and realized that it was a sign that the child was growing up and developing valuable powers of observation and independent judgment, they would not be so hurt, and therefore would not drive the child into opposition by resenting and resisting it.

The adolescent, with his passion for sincerity, always respects a parent who admits that he is wrong, or ignorant, or even that he has been unfair or unjust. What the child cannot forgive is the parents' refusal to admit these charges if the child knows them to be true.

Victorian parents believed that they kept their dignity by retreating behind an unreasoning authoritarianism. In fact they did nothing of the kind, but children were then too cowed to let them know how they really felt. Today we tend to go to the other extreme, but on the whole this change is a healthy one. However, the authoritarian approach and the laissez - faire approach both have their dangers. The former creates inhibitions and resentments; the latter often results in over - indulgence and lack of discipline. In any case, children have to be prepared for dealing with a world that is full of insecurity, and they have to be given the tools for doing so.

These tools include a healthy self - esteem, which is based on a realistic assessment of one's own abilities; a clear sense of values, which enables a person to make good decisions; and a capacity for empathy, which allows a person to understand the

feelings of others. All these things are necessary for a person to be able to function well in the world, and they can be taught to children in a variety of ways. For example, a child can be taught to value his own work by having it displayed or praised; he can be taught to respect the feelings of others by being made to feel what it is like to be in their shoes; and he can be taught to have a realistic view of his own abilities by being given tasks that are appropriate to his age and level of development.

There is no reason why parents should not be able to teach these things to their children. In fact, they are the best people to do so, because they know their children better than anyone else does. However, they must be prepared to be honest with themselves and with their children, and they must be willing to learn as well as to teach.

35. The process of ageing

At the age of twelve years, the human body is at its most vigorous. It has yet to reach its full size and strength, and its owner his or her full intelligence; but at this age the likelihood of death is least. Earlier, we were infants and young children, and consequently more vulnerable; later, we shall undergo a progressive loss of our vigour and resistance which, though imperceptible at first, will finally become so steep that we can live no longer, however well we look after ourselves, and however well society, and our doctors, look after us. This decline in vigour with the passing of time is called ageing. It is one of the most unpleasant discoveries which we all make that we must decline in this way, that if we escape wars, accidents and diseases we shall eventually 'die of old age', and that this happens at a rate which differs little from person to person, so that there are heavy odds in favour of our dying between the ages of sixty - five and eighty. Some of us will die sooner, a few will live longer - on into a ninth or tenth decade. But the chances are against it, and there is a virtual limit on how long we can hope to remain alive, however lucky and robust we are.

Normal people tend to forget this process unless and until they are reminded of it. We are so familiar with the fact that man ages, that people have for years assumed that the process of losing vigour with time, of becoming more likely to die the older we get, was something self - evident, like the cooling of a hot kettle or the wearing - out of a pair of shoes. They have also assumed that all animals, and probably other organisms such as trees, or even the universe itself, must in the course of time 'wear

out'. Most animals we commonly observe do in fact age as we do if they survive long enough; and mechanical systems like a wound - up watch, or the sun, do in fact run out of energy in accordance with the second law of thermodynamics (whether the whole universe does so is a moot point at present). But these are not analogous to what happens when man ages. A run - down watch is still a watch and can be rewound. An old watch, by contrast, becomes so worn and unreliable that it eventually stops working altogether. It is rather like the engine of a car, which can be repaired and even remade, but which eventually is replaced by a new engine. But a human body is not a car, no matter how much you may like to think so. There is no sudden change in the human body which marks the oncoming of old age. The changes are gradual and, at first, are often scarcely perceptible. It is often said that age is a state of mind, and this is true in part. If you feel young, you will be young, but this does not mean that you can avoid the ageing process. The ageing process is a biological process which cannot be avoided, no matter how much you may like to think you can.

The best current medical opinion seems to be that we are born with a sort of 'clock' inside us which determines how long we can live. This 'clock' is thought to be in the genes, and it is believed that we inherit it from our parents. The idea is that the 'clock' starts ticking at birth, and that it keeps on ticking until it runs out of time. Some people believe that this 'clock' can be 'reset' by things like diet, exercise, or drugs, but there is no real evidence for this at present. It is also believed that the rate of ageing can be slowed down by diet, exercise, or drugs, but again, there is no real evidence for this at present. The fact that some people live longer than others may be due to differences in their genes, or it may be due to differences in their lifestyle. It is likely that both factors play a role. But whatever the cause, the fact remains that we all age, and that we all die.

The ageing process has many implications for society. For example, as the population ages, there will be more and more people who are no longer able to work, and who will need to be supported by society. There will also be more and more people who are ill, and who will need medical care. This will put a strain on the resources of society, both in terms of money and in terms of manpower. Another implication is that as people age, they will become more and more different from each other. Some people will age gracefully, while others will age badly. Some people will be able to cope with the ageing process, while others will not. This will make it more difficult for society to deal with the ageing population as a whole.

In conclusion, the ageing process is a complex and unavoidable biological process which has many implications for society. We need to understand it better if we are

going to be able to deal with it effectively.

36. The cost of government

If a nation is essentially disunited, it is left to the government to hold it together. This increases the expense of government, and reduces correspondingly the amount of economic resources that could be used for developing the country. And it should not be forgotten how small those resources are in a poor and backward country. Where the cost of government is high, resources for development are correspondingly low.

This may be illustrated by comparing the position of a nation with that of a private business enterprise. An enterprise has to incur certain costs and expenses in order to stay in business. For our purposes, we are concerned only with one kind of cost - the cost of managing and administering the business. Such administrative overheads in a business are analogous to the cost of government in a nation. The administrative overheads of a business are low to the extent that everyone working in the enterprise realizes clearly what the objectives of the business are and the means of attaining them. If they are not, the enterprise will have to incur extra costs to clarify its objectives. It may have to set up a committee, spend a great deal of time and money on the plan, and then find out that the plan won't work. In the meantime, of course, the business will have been losing money.

If a nation as a whole is to be more efficient, it has to be better organized. Centralized planning, management, and so on, may be highly efficient by themselves, but from the point of view of the nation as a whole we must be careful about charges of inefficiency. There is always another side to the picture. For example, if we look at the matter of centralization of government functions, we find that while centralization may be highly efficient in terms of economic management, it may also lead to a loss of local self - government. We have to keep in mind that in a large nation there will be great differences in the economic development of different regions. If all the economic decisions are made by a central body, some regions will be left behind. In addition, the large - scale centralization of production that is characteristic of some socialist countries may lead to a loss of the incentives that are provided by a competitive market economy. We have to keep in mind that in a competitive market economy there are always incentives to improve the quality of products and services in order to meet the needs of consumers.

In short, we must be careful when we say that a certain government function, measure, or policy is "inefficient". There may be a complex explanation for the apparent inefficiency. There may be some hidden benefits that we have not yet discovered.

37. The process of ageing

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Normal people tend to forget this process unless and until they are reminded of it. We are so familiar with the fact that man ages, that people have for years assumed that the process of losing vigour with time, of becoming more likely to die the older we get, was something self - evident, like the cooling of a hot kettle or the wearing - out of a pair of shoes. They have also assumed that all animals, and probably other organisms such as trees, or even the universe itself, must in the course of time 'wear out'. Most animals we commonly observe do in fact age as we do if they survive long enough; and mechanical systems like a wound - up watch, or the sun, do in fact run out of energy in accordance with the second law of thermodynamics (whether the whole universe does so is a moot point at present). But these are not analogous to what happens when man ages. A run - down watch is still a watch and can be rewound. An old watch, by contrast, becomes so worn and unreliable that it eventually stops working altogether. It is rather like the human body. A person who has been doing strenuous physical work for a long time may find that his or her body

no longer responds as well as it used to; but if he or she takes a long rest, the body will recover some of its vigour. There is a difference between a worn - out watch and a worn - out body. An old watch cannot be made new again; but a human body can be restored to a certain extent, and, if we take good care of it, it can remain in fairly good condition for a long time.

Our so - called 'control of nature' is a phrase full of conceit. It implies that nature is something outside us, which we can control. We forget that we ourselves are part of nature, and that as we do to nature, nature does to us. Our very life depends on our body's adjustment to the changing environment. We are not much different from other animals in this respect. When we are cold, we shiver and try to get closer to a heat source. When we are hot, we sweat and try to find a cooler place. We do these things because our body has been adjusted to the environment in which we live. We also have a built - in thermostat which regulates our body temperature. When our body temperature rises, we sweat more; when it drops, we shiver more. This is how our body keeps itself in balance. If we interfere with this natural adjustment, for example, by wearing too many clothes when we are cold or by not wearing enough when we are hot, we will get sick. So, we can say that our body has a certain amount of self - control. But this self - control is limited. If we are exposed to too much cold or heat, our body will not be able to adjust itself, and we will die. So, we should respect nature and let our body do its job. We should not be too conceited about our 'control of nature'.

38. Water and the Traveler

Contamination of water supplies is usually due to poor sanitation close to water sources, sewage disposal into the sources themselves, leakage of sewage into distribution systems or contamination with industrial or farm waste. Even if a piped water supply is safe at its source, it is not always safe by the time it reaches the tap. Intermittent tap - water supplies should be regarded as particularly suspect.

Travelers on short trips to areas with water supplies of uncertain quality should avoid drinking tap - water, or untreated water from any other source. It is best to keep to hot drinks, bottled or canned drinks of well - known brand names - international standards of water treatment are usually followed at bottling plants. Carbonated drinks are acidic, and slightly safer. Make sure that all bottles are opened in your presence, and that their rims are clean and dry.

Boiling is always a good way of treating water. Some hotels supply boiled water on request and this can be used for drinking, or for brushing teeth. Portable boiling elements that can boil small quantities of water are useful when the right voltage of electricity is available. Refuse politely any cold drink from an unknown source.

Ice is only as safe as the water from which it is made, and should not be put in drinks unless it is known to be safe.

Drinking water can be obtained from almost every inhabited building, but the quality should be regarded as suspect, unless it has been treated in some way. If you are worried, buy a water filter from a reliable source and use it. Generally, however, if water has been boiled or treated at a bottling plant, the risk of water - borne disease will be small.

39. Waves

Waves are the children of the struggle between ocean and atmosphere, the ongoing signatures of infinity. Rays from the sun excite and energize the atmosphere of the earth, awakening it to flow, to movement, to rhythm, to life. The wind then speaks the message of the sun to the sea and the sea transmits it on through waves - an ancient, elemental, powerful yet gentle message.

Of all nature's forces, gravity is the most familiar and the most mysterious. Gravity is the irresistible force of attraction that moves objects towards each other. In the case of the ocean and the atmosphere, gravity is the force that keeps the ocean's surface in its place, while allowing the atmosphere to move freely above it. Waves are the result of the interaction between the ocean and the atmosphere, as the wind blows across the surface of the water, creating ripples that grow into waves.

Waves can be described in terms of their height, length, and period. The height of a wave is the vertical distance between the crest (the highest point) and the trough (the lowest point). The length of a wave is the horizontal distance between two consecutive crests or troughs. The period of a wave is the time it takes for one complete cycle of the wave to occur, from crest to crest or trough to trough.

Waves can also be classified according to their source. Wind - generated waves are the most common type of waves, created by the wind blowing across the surface of the water. Tsunamis, on the other hand, are large - scale waves generated by underwater earthquakes, volcanic eruptions, or landslides. Seiches are standing

waves that occur in enclosed or semi - enclosed bodies of water, such as lakes or bays.

The power of waves is truly astonishing. Waves can erode coastlines, build up beaches, and transport sediment across great distances. They can also generate electricity, as the movement of the waves can be harnessed to turn turbines. In addition, waves play an important role in the global climate system, as they help to distribute heat around the world.

In conclusion, waves are a fascinating and important part of nature. They are the result of the interaction between the ocean and the atmosphere, and they possess a wide range of characteristics and functions. Whether we are admiring their beauty from the shore, surfing their crests, or harnessing their power for electricity, waves are an ever - present reminder of the power and mystery of nature.

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Although an ocean wave gives the impression of a wall of water moving in your direction, in actuality waves move through the water leaving the water about where it was. If the water was moving with the wave, the ocean and everything on it would be racing in to the shore with obviously catastrophic results.

An ocean wave passing through deep water causes a particle on the surface to move in a roughly circular orbit, drawing the particle first towards the advancing wave, then up into the wave, then forward with it and then -- as the wave leaves the particles behind -- back to its starting point again.

From both maturity to death, a wave is subject to the same laws as any other 'living'

thing. For a time it assumes a miraculous individuality that, in the end, is reabsorbed into the great ocean of life.

The undulating waves of the open sea are generated by three natural causes: wind, earth movements or tremors, and the gravitational pull of the moon and sun. Once waves have been generated, gravity is the force that drives them in a continual attempt to restore the ocean surface to a flat plain.

41. Training elephants

Two main techniques have been used for training elephants, which we may call respectively the tough and the gentle. The former method simply consists of setting an elephant to work and beating him until he does what is expected of him. Apart from any moral considerations this is a stupid method of training, for it produces a resentful animal who at a later stage may well turn man - killer. The gentle method requires more patience in the early stages, but produces a cheerful, good - tempered elephant who will give many years of loyal service.

The first essential in elephant training is to assign to the animal a single mahout who will be entirely responsible for the job. Elephants like to have one master just as dogs do, and are capable of a considerable degree of personal affection. There are even stories of half - trained elephant calves who have refused to feed and pined to death when by some unavoidable circumstance they have been deprived of their own trainer.

The system which seems to work best for elephants is to assign to them their own trainer, who will stay with them for life. Another essential factor is the establishment of a very definite place where the elephant will be trained. It should be a fairly large area, surrounded by a fence or railing, and it should be in an area where the elephant is not likely to be distracted by other animals. Elephants need to be trained to be stable in various situations, so they should be exposed to different environments. They should be trained to stand still when they are being groomed, for example, and to kneel when they are being loaded or unloaded. They should also be trained to respond to commands given in different ways, such as by voice, by whistle, or by a tug on a rope.

Elephants are very intelligent animals, and they can be trained to perform a wide variety of tasks. They can be trained to carry heavy loads, for example, or to work in the logging industry. They can also be trained to perform in circuses, where they can

show off their strength and agility. However, it is important to note that elephants are wild animals, and they should be treated with respect and care. Training elephants should be a process that is based on positive reinforcement, rather than on punishment or coercion.

42. Record of the Past

We might marvel at the progress made in every field of study, but the methods of testing a person's knowledge and ability remain as primitive as ever they were. It really is extraordinary that after all these years, educationists have still failed to devise anything more efficient and reliable than examinations. For all the pious claim that examinations test what you know, it is common knowledge that they more often do the exact opposite. They may be a good means of testing memory, or the knack of working rapidly under extreme pressure, but they can tell you nothing about a person's true ability and aptitude.

As anxiety-makers, examinations are second to none. That is because so much depends on them. They are the mark of success or failure in our society. Your whole future may be decided in one fateful day. It doesn't matter that you weren't feeling very well, or that your mother died. Little things like that don't count: the exam goes on. No one can give of his best when he is in mortal terror, or after a sleepless night, yet this is precisely what the examination system expects him to do.

The moment a child begins school, he enters a world of vicious competition where success and failure are clearly defined and measured. Can we wonder at the increasing number of 'drop - outs': young people who are written off as utter failures before they have even embarked on a career? Can we be surprised at the suicide rate among students?

A good education should, among other things, train you to think for yourself. The examination system does anything but that. What has to be learnt is rigidly laid down by a syllabus, so the student is encouraged to memorize. Examinations do not motivate a student to read widely, but to restrict his reading; they do not enable him to seek more and more knowledge, but induce cramming. They lower the standards of teaching, because they deprive the teacher of all freedoms. Teachers themselves are often judged by examination results, and instead of teaching their subjects, they are reduced to training their students in exam techniques which they despise. The most successful candidates are not always the best educated; they are the best

trained in the technique of working under duress.

The results on which so much depends are often nothing more than a subjective assessment by some anonymous examiner. Examiners are only human. They get tired and hungry; they make mistakes. Yet they have to mark stacks of hastily scrawled scripts in a limited amount of time. Most of them are overworked and underpaid. They are in the position of a doctor who has to diagnose a patient's illness without the benefit of laboratory tests. What wonder that in such circumstances, they often make mistakes?

There must surely be many simpler and more effective ways of assessing a person's true abilities. Is it cynical to suggest that examinations are merely a profitable business for the institutions that run them? This is what it boils down to in the last analysis. The best comment on the system is this ill - fated word - 'examination'.

43. Are There Strangers in Space?

We must conclude from the work of those who have studied the origin of life, that given a planet only approximately like our own, life is almost certain to start. Of all the planets in our own solar system we are now pretty certain the Earth is the only one on which life can survive. Mars is too dry and poor in oxygen, Venus far too hot, and so on. But other suns, stars as the astronomers call them, are bound to have planets like our own, and as the number of stars in the universe is so vast, this possibility becomes virtual certainty. There are one hundred thousand million stars in our own Milky Way alone, and then there are three thousand million other Milky Ways, or galaxies, in the universe. So the number of stars that we know exist is now estimated at about 300 million million million.

We can make the same kind of argument, and have in recent years. For example, we think that between 80 and 90 per cent of all stars, like our sun, are circled by planets which may be inhabited. That means that our nearest neighbours are perhaps 4.3 light years away, which is much too far to think of in terms of visiting them. But even if we never visit them, if we could get at their language, we might be able to communicate with them.

Recently, two Americans made a startling discovery; they have found sound waves in the space between the stars. If such sound waves really exist, they must be the remains of some very large and powerful explosion that took place thousands of millions of years ago. Since these sound waves are spreading outwards at the speed

of light, they are by now far out in the universe. And it is also possible that other civilizations have picked up these waves, and are trying to make something of them. This also gives us a new way to look at the universe, and makes us wonder if there are other intelligent beings out there.

44. Patterns of Culture

Custom has not commonly been regarded as a subject of any great moment. The inner workings of our own brains we feel to be uniquely worthy of investigation, but custom, we have a way of thinking, is behaviour at its most commonplace. As a matter of fact, it is the other way around. Traditional custom, taken the world over, is a mass of detailed behaviour more astonishing than what any one person can ever evolve in individual actions, no matter how aberrant. Yet that is a rather trivial aspect of the matter. The fact of first - rate importance is the predominant role that custom plays in experience and in belief, and the very great varieties it may manifest.

No man ever looks at the world with pristine eyes. He sees it edited by a definite set of customs and institutions and ways of thinking. Even in his philosophical probings he cannot go behind these stereotypes; his very concepts of the true and the false will still have reference to his particular traditional customs. John Dewey has said in all seriousness that the part played by custom in shaping the behaviour of the individual, as against any way in which he can affect traditional custom, is as the proportion of the total vocabulary of his mother tongue against those words of his own baby talk that are taken up into the vernacular of his family. When one seriously studies the social orders that have had the opportunity to develop autonomously, the figure becomes no more than an exact and matter - of - fact observation. The life - history of the individual is first and foremost an accommodation to the patterns of his culture. From his very birth the customs into which he is born shape his experience and behaviour. By the time he can talk, he is the little creature of his culture, and by the time he is grown and able to take part in its activities, its habits are his habits, its beliefs his beliefs, its impossibilities his impossibilities.

Every culture has its own distinctive set of customs and institutions and ways of thinking. These are the building blocks of the culture, and they determine the pattern of the culture. The culture pattern is the overall design of the culture, the way in which the various building blocks are put together. It is the result of the long - term

evolution of the culture, and it is relatively stable. Once a culture pattern is established, it is very difficult to change. It is like a mould into which the members of the culture are poured, and they are shaped by it. The culture pattern is not only a set of rules and regulations, but also a set of values and attitudes. It is the way in which the members of the culture see the world and themselves. It is the way in which they evaluate things and people. It is the way in which they make decisions and take actions.

The study of culture patterns is an important part of anthropology. Anthropologists study the different culture patterns of different peoples, and they try to understand how these patterns are formed, how they function, and how they change. They study the relationships between the culture patterns and the social, economic, political, and religious systems of the peoples. They study the impact of the culture patterns on the individual members of the culture, and they study the impact of the individual members on the culture patterns. They try to understand the dynamics of the culture, the way in which it moves and changes. They try to understand the unity and diversity of the culture, the way in which it is both one and many. The study of culture patterns is also an important part of sociology. Sociologists study the culture patterns of different social groups, and they try to understand how these patterns are formed, how they function, and how they change. They study the relationships between the culture patterns and the social structure, the social relations, and the social processes of the social groups. They study the impact of the culture patterns on the individual members of the social groups, and they study the impact of the individual members on the culture patterns. They try to understand the dynamics of the social group, the way in which it moves and changes. They try to understand the unity and diversity of the social group, the way in which it is both one and many.

The study of culture patterns is also an important part of psychology. Psychologists study the culture patterns of different peoples, and they try to understand how these patterns are formed, how they function, and how they change. They study the relationships between the culture patterns and the mental processes, the mental states, and the mental characteristics of the peoples. They study the impact of the culture patterns on the individual members of the peoples, and they study the impact of the individual members on the culture patterns. They try to understand the dynamics of the mental processes, the way in which they move and changes. They try to understand the unity and diversity of the mental processes, the way in which it is both one and many.

The study of culture patterns is also an important part of history. Historians study the culture patterns of different peoples in different historical periods, and they try to

understand how these patterns are formed, how they function, and how they change. They study the relationships between the culture patterns and the historical events, the historical processes, and the historical trends of the peoples. They study the impact of the culture patterns on the individual members of the peoples, and they study the impact of the individual members on the culture patterns. They try to understand the dynamics of the historical processes, the way in which they move and changes. They try to understand the unity and diversity of the historical processes, the way in which it is both one and many.

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Every child that is born into his group will share them. And no child born into one on the far side of the globe can ever achieve the thousandth part of it. There is no social problem it is more incumbent upon us to understand than this of the role of custom. Until we are able to do so, we will be in danger of violating it in every direction. Only when we understand can we respect. And only when we respect can we hope to modify, if it becomes necessary to modify. But we can't even start to understand until we rid ourselves of the very common notion that custom is only a quaint relic of bygone days.

It is true that in modern times the automatic nature of traditional custom has been much weakened. We no longer live in a world where custom automatically dictates what we do. But the essential role that custom plays in our lives has not changed. We are still creatures of custom, and custom still shapes our experience and beliefs in countless ways.

Custom can never be used as a ready - made solution to modern social problems. But if we are to understand the nature of these problems, we must first understand the role of custom in our lives.

46. Hobbies

A gifted American psychologist has said, "Worry is a spasm of the emotion; the mind catches hold of something and will not let it go." It is useless to argue with the mind in this condition. The stronger the will, the more futile the task. One can only gently insinuate something else into its convulsive grasp. And if this something else is rightly chosen, if it is really attended by the illumination of another field of interest, gradually, and often quite swiftly, the old undue grip relaxes and the process of recuperation and repair begins.

The cultivation of a hobby and new forms of interest is therefore a policy of the first importance to a public man. But this is not a business that can be undertaken in a day or swiftly improvised by a mere command of the will. The growth of alternative mental interests is a long process. The seeds must be carefully chosen; they must fall on good ground; they must be sedulously tended, if the vivifying fruits are to be at hand when needed.

To be really happy and really safe, one ought to have at least two or three hobbies, and they must all be real. It is no use starting late in life to say: "I will take an interest in this or that." Such an attempt only aggravates the strain of mental effort.

A man may acquire great knowledge of topics unconnected with his daily work, and yet get hardly any benefit or relief. It is no use doing what you like; you have got to like what you do. Broadly speaking, human beings may be divided into three classes: those who are toiled to death, those who are worried to death, and those who are bored to death. It is no use offering the manual labourer, tired out with a hard day's work, the chance of playing a game of football or baseball. It is no use inviting the politician or the professional or business man, who has been working or worrying about serious things for six days, to work or worry about trifling things at the weekend.

As for the unfortunate people who can neither toil nor worry, right in the middle of one of their periodic ongosings into boredom, no earthly use can be made of them by anybody. In most cases, the so - called hobbies of the average person are really more like habits. For example, one man's hobby is reading, another's is fishing, another's is gardening, another's is playing the piano. But if you were to ask these people how much time they spend on their hobbies, you would be surprised to find that they spend hardly any time at all. They have the habit of reading, fishing, gardening or playing the piano, but they do not really have the hobby. In fact, they are so busy with their daily work that they have no time to develop a real hobby.

A real hobby is an absorbing pursuit outside one's daily work. It is something that one can lose oneself in. It is not something that one does just to kill time. A real hobby gives one a sense of accomplishment and satisfaction. It is something that one can be proud of. A real hobby can also be a great source of relaxation and rejuvenation.

So, if you want to be really happy and really safe, start early in life to develop a real hobby. Choose something that you are really interested in. Do not choose something just because it is fashionable or because other people are doing it. Develop your hobby slowly but surely. Do not expect too much too soon. And do not give up too easily. If you do these things, you will find that your hobby will become a great source of happiness and safety in your life.

47. The Great Escape

Economy is one powerful motive for camping, since after the initial outlay upon equipment, or through hiring it, the total expense can be far less than the cost of hotels. But, contrary to a popular assumption, it is far from being the only one, or

even the greatest. The man who manoeuvres carelessly into his twenty pounds' worth of space at one of Europe's myriad permanent sites may find himself bumping a Bentley. More likely, Ford Escort will be hub to hub with Renault or Mercedes, but rarely with bicycles made for two.

That the equipment of modern camping becomes yearly more sophisticated is an entertaining paradox for the cynic, a brighter promise for the hopeful traveller who has sworn to get away from it all. It also provides - and some student sociologist might care to base his thesis upon the phenomenon - an escape of another kind. The modern traveller is often a man who dislikes the Splendide and the Bellavista, not because he cannot afford, or shuns their material comforts. but because he is afraid of them. Affluent he may be, but he is by no means sure what to tip the doorman or the chambermaid. Master in his own house, he has little idea of when to say boo to a maitre d'hotel.

From all such fears camping releases him. Granted, a snobbery of camping itself, based upon equipment and techniques, already exists; but it is of a kind that, if he meets it, he can readily understand and deal with. There is no superior 'they' in the shape of managements and hotel hierarchies to darken his holiday days.

To such motives, yet another must be added. The contemporary phenomenon of car ownership, which has been mass-produced and which has invaded every aspect of modern life, has helped bring about a situation in which the once - instinctive identification of the person with the place has been weakened. Instead, we have a far more impersonal relationship with the places through which we pass: we view them through car windows at high speed and we are more concerned with the cars in front of us, the cars behind us, the cars to the side. Our sense of place is not the same as that of the ancient hunters and gatherers who knew every rock and tree in their territory. Nor is it the same as that of the peasant who has a deep and personal relationship with the land on which he has worked for generations. In this new situation, camping offers a way of re - establishing a connection with the land, of getting to know a place more intimately than we could from a car window or a hotel balcony. It is a way of getting back to nature, of experiencing the world in a more direct and less artificial way. To some people, camping has become a spiritual as well as a physical escape.

48. Planning a share portfolio

There is no shortage of tipsters around offering "get-rich-quick" opportunities. But if you are a serious private investor, leave the Las Vegas mentality to those with money to fritter. The serious investor needs a proper "portfolio" -- a well-planned selection of investments, with a definite structure and a clear aim. But exactly how does a newcomer to the stock market go about achieving that?

Well, if you go to five reputable stock brokers and ask them what you should do with your money, you're likely to get five different answers, -- even if you give all the relevant information about your age, family, finances and what you want from your investments. Moral? There is no one "right" way to structure a portfolio. However, there are undoubtedly some wrong ways, and you can be sure that none of our five advisers would have suggested sinking all (or perhaps any) of your money into Periwigs.

So what should you do? We'll assume that you have sorted out the basics -- like mortgages, pensions, insurance and access to sufficient cash reserves. You should then establish your own individual aims. These are partly a matter of personal circumstances, partly a matter of psychology.

For instance, if you are older you have less time to recover from any major losses, and you may well prefer to boost your pension income. So you might be more conservative with your investments. On the other hand, if you are younger and can afford to take the long view, you may decide to invest in more speculative stocks, hoping for that big kill in a few years' time.

If you are closer to the "get - rich - quick" end of the spectrum, you will be more interested in speculative stocks that may double or triple in a short time. If you are at the more conservative end, you may prefer bonds or cash deposits. Once you have decided on your investment aims, you can then begin to look for the best investment vehicles to achieve those aims.

The stock market offers a vast array of different investment vehicles, from blue - chip stocks to penny stocks, from bonds to real - estate investment trusts. You need to understand the characteristics of each type of investment vehicle, and how they fit into your overall portfolio. For example, blue - chip stocks are generally considered to be more stable and less risky than penny stocks. Bonds are generally considered to be more conservative than stocks, but they also offer lower returns. Real - estate investment trusts can provide a good income stream, but they are also more sensitive to changes in the real - estate market.

You also need to consider the costs associated with each type of investment vehicle. Some investment vehicles, such as mutual funds, have relatively high management fees. Others, such as exchange - traded funds, have lower management fees. You need to make sure that the costs associated with your investments do not eat up too much of your returns.

Finally, you need to keep an eye on your portfolio. You should review your portfolio regularly, at least once a year, to make sure that it still meets your investment aims. If your circumstances change, such as if you get married, have a child or change jobs, you may need to adjust your portfolio accordingly.

In conclusion, planning a share portfolio is not an easy task. It requires a good understanding of the stock market, a clear set of investment aims, and a willingness to keep an eye on your investments. But if you are a serious private investor, it is well worth the effort.